



# Capital to back women startups with ₹10 crore collateral-free loans

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday announced that the Delhi Government will provide collateral-free loans of up to ₹10 crore to women-led startups and self-help groups, with the Government itself acting as guarantor for the loans.

The announcement was made at the inauguration of the two-day Mega Self Help Group Mela 2026 in Rohini.

Addressing the event near Unity One Mall at Rohini West Metro Station, the Chief Minister said the Government was working to make women in the Capital financially independent through entrepreneurship, local manufacturing, and market access for handmade products.

She said the Government would also create regular

marketing platforms for indigenous products in malls and large commercial centres across Delhi to help women entrepreneurs and self-help groups reach more customers.

The mela was organised by the North-West District Administration and featured products made by women-led self-help groups, including handicrafts, khadi items, crochet work, food products, and household goods. Around 24 self-help groups participated in the event.

The Chief Minister said the initiative aimed to strengthen Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of "Vocal for Local," "Atmanirbhar Bharat," and "One District, One Product." She said locally made products deserved stronger branding and better market support.

The Chief Minister said women working from home

through small businesses and handmade production were making an important contribution to both household incomes and the national economy.

She added that Indian products were now gaining recognition globally across sectors, and similar opportunities should be created for locally produced household and handicraft items.

"People often prefer foreign brands, but products made in India are not behind anyone in quality. What they need is proper branding and market support," she said.

The Chief Minister said the Delhi Government wanted more women to join self-help groups and turn their skills into sustainable businesses. She said banks were also being linked with such initiatives to improve access to credit



and financial services for women entrepreneurs.

According to the Chief Minister, the collateral-free loan support scheme would particularly help women star-

tups and self-help groups that struggle to secure large loans due to a lack of collateral or financial guarantees.

The event was attended by North-West Delhi MP

Yogendra Chandolia, MLA Kulwant Rana, North-West District Magistrate Soumya Saurabh, officials from the district administration, representatives of banking institu-

tions, and women associated with self-help groups.

The Chief Minister also linked the initiative with broader economic and sustainability campaigns being promoted by the Delhi Government. Referring to fuel conservation efforts, she said the Government was encouraging citizens to adopt measures such as "Monday Metro" and "No Vehicle Day" in line with the Prime Minister's appeal for responsible energy use. She said small lifestyle changes by citizens could collectively strengthen the economy and reduce unnecessary fuel consumption.

Handicraft products displayed at the mela were also showcased under the "One District, One Product" initiative for North-West Delhi. Organisers said the exhibition aimed to connect women entrepreneurs directly with

buyers while promoting traditional and locally manufactured products.

The Chief Minister congratulated the participating women and the district administration for organising the event. She said such programmes not only support women-led enterprises but also help strengthen the larger goal of self-reliance.

Officials said the mela was designed to provide exposure and business opportunities to women associated with self-help groups while encouraging greater public participation in supporting local products.

The Delhi Government said similar initiatives would continue in the future to strengthen women entrepreneurship, improve access to finance, and expand market opportunities for indigenous products across the Capital.

## Nine hospitalised after midnight fire in Shahdara

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi



Nine people, including women and a 12-year-old girl, were hospitalised after a fire broke out in a four-storey residential building in east Delhi's Shahdara area early Sunday morning. Officials said the victims suffered breathing problems due to heavy smoke inside the building and were rescued by fire and police personnel.

According to the Delhi Fire Services (DFS), the fire was reported at around 12.03 am from a residential building located at D-45, Mansarovar Park. Three fire tenders and a water bowser were immediately rushed to the spot after the emergency call was received.

Officials said the fire had started in domestic items kept in the parking area on the ground floor of the building. Thick smoke quickly spread through the structure, trapping several residents on different floors.

DFS and police teams carried out a rescue operation and evacuated nine people from the building. All of them were taken to Guru Teg Bahadur Hospital after complaining of breathing difficulties caused by smoke inhalation.

The injured were identified as Vanshika (20), Tanishka Soni (19), Durgesh (49), Yogesh Verma (50), Raj Rani (65), Arun Garg (48), Ananya (12), Renu Garg (19) and Prateek Garg (19).

A senior Delhi Fire Services official said the blaze

remained confined to the parking area and was later brought under control before it could spread to the upper floors.

Police said preliminary investigation suggested that the fire may have been caused by a short circuit in a motor installed in the parking area.

"The fire reportedly started due to a short circuit in a motor and remained limited to the parking space of the building. Police and fire teams responded quickly and safely rescued all trapped residents," a police statement said.

Officials said no deaths or burn injuries were reported in the incident. All those admitted to the hospital were treated for smoke inhalation and later discharged.

The incident triggered panic in the locality during the night as residents gathered outside the building while rescue operations were underway. Videos showing fire personnel rescuing people from the smoke-filled building later surfaced on social media platforms.

Officials said the narrow

lanes in the area posed initial difficulties for fire tenders reaching the spot, but the teams managed to control the situation in time and prevent a major tragedy.

Police said further investigation is underway to determine the exact cause of the fire and whether there were any electrical safety lapses inside the building.

Fire incidents linked to electrical short circuits continue to remain a concern in several residential areas of the Capital, especially during the summer season when electricity usage increases sharply.

Authorities have repeatedly advised residents to ensure proper maintenance of electrical wiring, motors and power equipment to avoid such incidents. Fire officials also urged people living in multi-storey buildings to keep emergency exits clear and avoid storing combustible material in parking areas or staircases.

Officials said timely intervention by the fire department and local police helped prevent casualties in Sunday's incident.

## IP University extends admission deadline to May 30

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Guru Gobind Singh Indraprastha University has extended the last date for submission of online applications for admissions to its National Level Test and merit-based programmes till May 30, giving students additional time to complete the process.

The university had earlier fixed May 15 as the deadline for applications. Officials said the extension applies to admissions being conducted through national-level entrance tests and merit-based criteria for the academic session.

In a statement issued on Sunday, the university advised applicants to carefully select the correct programme and programme code while filling out the application forms. Students were asked not to submit forms in haste and to verify



all details before final submission to avoid mistakes during the admission process.

The university clarified that separate online links have been provided for Common Entrance Test (CET), National Level Test and merit-based programmes. Candidates have been asked to ensure that they apply through the appropriate admission category according to the programme for which they are seeking admission.

Officials said the option to

apply for CET-based programmes has now been closed. However, admissions to some of those programmes may still be conducted through Common University Entrance Test (CUET) scores if seats remain vacant after the initial admission rounds.

The university administration urged students and parents to regularly visit the official university websites for updated admission information, programme details

and counselling-related notifications.

The admission process at IP University covers a wide range of undergraduate and post-graduate programmes offered across its affiliated institutions and schools. Thousands of students from Delhi and other states apply every year for professional and academic courses in fields such as engineering, law, management, journalism, education and health sciences.

University officials said applicants should remain cautious while selecting programmes because incorrect programme codes or categories could create difficulties during counselling and seat allotment stages.

The university has been conducting admissions through multiple channels, including national-level entrance examinations, merit-based criteria and

CUET scores, depending on the course requirements and seat availability.

Officials also indicated that applicants should carefully read eligibility conditions and admission guidelines available on the university portal before applying. Students were advised to keep all required academic and personal documents ready during the online registration process.

According to the university, information regarding counselling schedules, document verification and seat allotment will be released separately after completion of the application process.

The extension is expected to benefit students who were unable to complete their applications before the earlier deadline or were waiting for clarification regarding programme categories and admission procedures.

## Vice Chancellor conducts surprise check at IPU CET centres

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Guru Gobind Singh Indraprastha University (IPU) Vice Chancellor (VC) Padma Shri Prof (Dr) Mahesh Verma conducted a surprise inspection of Common Entrance Test (CET) centres on Sunday to review examination arrangements and ensure strict compliance with academic standards.

The inspections were carried out while entrance examinations for several postgraduate and undergraduate programmes were

underway at different university centres, despite the day being a Government holiday. The tests held on Sunday included MSc Environment Management, Para-Medical programmes, MSc Applied Geoinformatics, Master in Public Health, Med and BSc Environment Science.

According to the university, the Vice Chancellor visited all CET centres personally while candidates were appearing for the examinations. Faculty members and staff on duty were reportedly taken by surprise during the inspection as the visit had not



been announced in advance.

University officials said the inspection was aimed at monitoring examination procedures closely and ensuring that all arrangements were being conducted smoothly and transparently.

During the visit, Prof Verma

reviewed the conduct of examinations, supervision arrangements and the functioning of examination centres. He interacted with officials involved in the examination process and assessed whether protocols were being followed properly.

Speaking on the inspection, the Vice Chancellor said the university maintains close monitoring of all important academic activities and remains committed to preserving the credibility of examinations.

"We closely observe every aspect related to the exami-

nation process. It is important to ensure that no lapse takes place and that the integrity of the system remains protected," he said.

He said the university has maintained transparency and discipline in its entrance examination system for more than 25 years and would continue to uphold the same standards in future as well.

The university has been conducting entrance examinations for a wide range of programmes as part of the ongoing admission process for the upcoming academic session.

### ARTICLE OF DISSOLUTION OF PARTNERSHIP FIRM

This is to inform that the partnership firm, **Secret Ingredient Projects**, R/O- C-1/7, Safdar Jung Development Area, New Delhi-110016, having **GST No. 07ADFFS9118K2ZM** has been dissolved with effect from **30th March 2026**.

All the partners of the firm have mutually agreed to dissolve the partnership and discontinue the business activities of the firm from the above-mentioned date. All rights, liabilities, assets, and obligations of the firm shall be settled mutually among the partners as per the terms agreed between them.

Henceforth, the firm "**Secret Ingredient Projects**" shall cease to operate as a partnership firm from the effective date of dissolution.

For Secret Ingredient Projects  
Sd/- Partners



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CHANGE OF NAME

I, **Vidya Devi, Mother of No.16022521W LNK Devendra Partap Singh R/o- Vill- Barui, PO- Jhauwara, Teh- Lambhua, Dist- Sultanpur, U.P- 228001**, have changed my name from **Vidya Devi to Vidayavati Singh**, vide affidavit dated 16/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1339)C

**Baba Farid University of Health Sciences, Faridkot (Admission Branch)**

**Baba Farid University of Health Sciences, Faridkot Admission Notice**

**M.Sc. Nursing courses (PMNET-2026)**

Online applications are invited alongwith requisite fee for admission to M.Sc. Nursing course, session-2026 in all the Govt./University constituent/Private colleges of Punjab through University website from 19.05.2026 to 16.06.2026. Prospectus for admission to M.Sc. Nursing course will be available on university website from 19.05.2026. The Entrance Test (PMNET-2026) for admission to M.Sc. Nursing course will be conducted on 27.06.2026.

**Post Basic B.Sc. Nursing course (PPBNET-2026)**

Online applications are invited alongwith requisite fee for admission to Post Basic B.Sc. Nursing course, session-2026 in all the Govt./University constituent/Private colleges of Punjab through University website from 19.05.2026 to 16.06.2026. Prospectus for admission to Post Basic B.Sc. Nursing course will be available on university website from 19.05.2026. The Entrance Test (PPBNET-2026) for admission to Post Basic B.Sc. Nursing course will be conducted on 27.06.2026. The Schedule of Counselling will be intimated later on through University website.

Note:- Any Notification/Corrigendum/Amendment by Govt. of Punjab will be followed. For Prospectus/fee details/schedule/online counseling/details & updates visit us at: [www.bfuhhs.ac.in](http://www.bfuhhs.ac.in)

Registrar

3108/12/2026-27/11514 Dated CHD :- 15/05/2026

## Jor Bagh named NDMC's next 'Anupam Colony' by Vice Chairman

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Vice Chairman NDMC, Kuljeet Singh Chahal, on Sunday declared Jor Bagh as the civic body's next "Anupam Colony" and led a plantation drive there under the 'Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam' campaign, an official said.

'Anupam Colony' initiative is based on 100 per cent waste segregation at source, on-site composting, recycling and active community participation to promote cleaner and greener neighbourhoods.

The drive saw participation from resident welfare association members, local residents, senior citizens and NDMC officials and staff, an official statement said.



Before the plantation drive, Chahal unveiled a certification board declaring Jor Bagh as NDMC's latest "Anupam Colony", an initiative focused on sustainable and decentralised waste management, the statement added.

"Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam" is not merely a plantation

drive, but a mass movement of emotional and social responsibility. When we plant a tree, we lay the foundation for a secure future for coming generations while paying tribute to our mothers and Mother Nature," Chahal said.

He said Jor Bagh has

joined colonies such as Satya Sadan Officers Flats, Bharti Nagar, Aradhana Colony, Babu Dham Colony, New Moti Bagh and Kaka Nagar under NDMC's "Towards Cleaner and Greener Colonies" vision.

"Under the vision of 'Towards Cleaner and Greener Colonies', Jor Bagh has now been certified as NDMC's next 'Anupam Colony'," he said.

Chahal said NDMC has prepared a year-long green calendar under which plantation drives will be held every Sunday across New Delhi. He also urged citizens to respond to the Prime Minister's call for responsible civic behaviour and collective participation during challenging times.

## Couple held for robbing elderly in e-rickshaws

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

A couple has been arrested for allegedly stealing cash or valuables from elderly passengers travelling in e-rickshaws in west Delhi's Moti Nagar area, police said on Sunday.

The accused has been identified as Suresh (25) and his wife, the police said, adding that they were apprehended after an investigation into the theft of ₹1 lakh from a 60-year-old passenger earlier this week.

According to the police,



the complainant, a resident of Kirti Nagar, had hired an e-rickshaw from a showroom on Shivaji Marg on May 13.

The man was carrying a small bag containing ₹1 lakh cash. After reaching his destination, he found that the bag had been torn and the cash was missing, they said.

An e-FIR was registered at Moti Nagar police station on May 14 and an investigation was launched. A team analysed CCTV footage from the route taken by the complainant and identified the e-rickshaw allegedly used in the crime. "Using technical surveillance and local inputs, the accused couple was traced and apprehended," a senior police officer said.

During interrogation, the accused allegedly disclosed that they used to target elderly passengers travelling in e-rickshaws and steal cash and valuables from

their bags during transit without raising suspicion.

Police recovered ₹90,000 of the stolen amount from the possession of the accused along with the e-rickshaw used in the commission of the offence.

"The accused had no previous criminal involvement on record. Further investigation is underway to ascertain whether the couple was involved in other similar theft cases targeting passengers and senior citizens in different parts of the city," the police officer added.

## Project Sangam shows visible impact on Delhi traffic issues

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Delhi Traffic Police's multi-agency initiative "Project Sangam" has started showing visible results across several parts of the Capital, with authorities carrying out coordinated action against illegal parking, traffic bottlenecks, wrong-side driving and road safety violations.

The project, launched as a collaborative and citizen-focused exercise, has brought together traffic police, civic agencies, Resident Welfare Associations (RWAs), market bodies and Government departments to improve traffic flow and road safety in different zones of Delhi.

According to Delhi Traffic Police, enforcement drives under the project have led to action against illegal parking, encroachments and unsafe road practices in major congestion-prone areas. In East Delhi, special enforcement drives were conducted on Vikas Marg to tackle illegal parking and wrong-side movement of e-rickshaws. Traffic Police also sent proposals to the Public Works Department for construction of service roads near Jhilmil Industrial Area to prevent vehicles from entering roads from the wrong direction.

In West Delhi, regular challans were issued against cranes parked improperly near Hari Kunj. Authorities also directed agencies to



reposition a Safe City Project camera box near Metal Forging after it obstructed visibility of traffic signals.

Traffic Police said focused action was also taken in North Delhi. Motorcycle patrols were intensified and no-parking signboards were installed on Maharaja Agrasen Marg in Pitampura. Encroachment removal drives were also carried out near KP Block Market to ease traffic congestion and improve pedestrian movement.

In South and Central Delhi, authorities proposed installation of boom barriers and speed breakers in Kailash Hills to improve traffic regulation and road safety. Multiple agencies are also coordinating to address parking management and pedestrian safety near Sunder Nursery and Nizamuddin areas, officials said.

Delhi Traffic Police stated that the project is based on cooperation between enforcement agencies and local residents rather than only punitive measures.

# CNG hits record ₹80.09/kg after 2nd hike in 48 hours

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

The price of Compressed Natural Gas (CNG) has increased once again in Delhi on Saturday, marking the second hike in just 48 hours. With the latest revision effective from 6.00 am on Sunday, CNG prices in Delhi climbed to ₹80.09 per kg, breaching the ₹80-mark for the first time. The price is ₹88.70 per kg in Noida and Ghaziabad and ₹85.12 in Gurugram. The increase comes two days after IGL had already raised CNG prices by ₹2 per kg on Friday, when Delhi's CNG rate had moved to ₹79.09 per kg. Major natural gas distributor Indraprastha Gas Limited (IGL) said that the price hike aims to marginally offset the impact of increase in input gas cost along with steep appreciation of US dollar. "The retail selling price of CNG has been increased by ₹1/kg wef 6 am on 17.05.2026 in all GAS of IGL. The revision in retail prices of CNG has been effected only to marginally offset the impact of increase in input gas cost along with steep appreciation of USD. Even after revision, CNG would still offer upto 45 per cent savings towards the running cost when compared to vehicles running on alternate fuel at the current level of prices," the IGL said. The back-to-back hikes are set to increase transportation expenses for private vehicle owners, cab drivers and public transport users who rely on CNG as a relatively economical fuel option. The CNG price hike impacts public transportation, feeding into retail inflation. With a large section of public trans-



ports now running on CNG, it is expected that the increased cost would be passed on to the commuters. Additionally, delivery charges for food, groceries and online shopping may increase. Over time, prices of essential goods such as vegetables, milk, and household items often go up because transportation becomes more expensive. Fare hikes, in general, erode household savings and reduce spending power of the masses. Reacting to the price hike, a consumer at a CNG station in Lodhi Road, said, "Prices are rising too much and they should come down. The latest hike follows a broader increase in fuel prices across the country. Earlier this week, petrol and diesel prices were raised by ₹3 per litre amid rising global energy prices linked to the ongoing West Asia conflict. After the revision, petrol in Delhi is retailing at ₹97.77 per litre, up from ₹94.77, while diesel prices have increased from ₹87.67 to ₹90.67 per litre. The price shift is one of back-to-back revisions being held amid the geopolitical tensions in the Middle East,

which supplied about 40 per cent of its crude imports. The latest fuel price hikes have triggered concerns among transport operators, with auto and taxi unions seeking a revision in fares. In a letter addressed to Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, the Delhi Auto Rickshaw Union and Delhi Pradesh Taxi Union said an increase in fares would ease the financial burden on drivers and help avoid disputes with passengers over charges. The unions have demanded that the minimum fare for the first 1.5 kilometres be increased from ₹30 to ₹50, while the per-kilometre fare should be revised upward from ₹11 to ₹15. They have also sought waiting charges of ₹1 per minute along with an additional luggage fee of ₹25. However, the unions said the existing night fare structure, which permits a 25 per cent surcharge between 11 pm and 5 am, should remain unchanged. Analysts warned that the combined impact of higher petrol, diesel and CNG prices could eventually slow demand growth and add to inflationary pressures.

# Temperature rises to 41.9°C, IMD warns of extreme heat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Delhiites should be prepared to face extreme heat and strong winds in the coming days. Delhi on Sunday recorded a maximum temperature of 41.9 degree Celsius, 1.5 notches above the seasonal average. The minimum temperature settled at 25.9 degrees Celsius on Sunday morning, 0.6 notches below the seasonal average, the IMD stated. Relative humidity was recorded at 28 per cent at 5.30 pm. The India Meteorological Department (IMD) has issued an alert that the mercury may reach 45 degrees Celsius this week. Delhi and the National Capital Region have already been reeling under an intense heatwave with mercury rising above normal. According to the met department, a prolonged spell of heatwave is expected starting Monday, with the maximum temperature expected to reach 45 degrees Celsius. "The maximum and minimum temperatures over Delhi are likely to be in the range of 43°C to 45°C and 25°C to 27°C, respectively," a press release by the IMD said in its forecast for Monday (May 18). The weather department, however, did not immediately issue a colour-coded alert. It predicted strong surface winds, with speeds reaching 20-30 kmph occasionally gusting to 40 kmph during the day. The weather department, in its press release, said that the maximum temperatures in Delhi would remain between the 43

and 45 degrees Celsius range from May 18 to May 20. Meanwhile, the minimum temperature is also expected to be above normal at most places over Delhi for this duration. "Maximum temperatures over Delhi are expected to remain above normal during the coming days, and heatwave conditions are likely to develop from May 18," an IMD official said. Delhi had, on Saturday, recorded a maximum temperature of 40.8°C, just about 0.4°C above the normal, and a minimum temperature of 24.8°C, 1.7°C below the normal. On Sunday too, the maximum temperature went above 40 degrees Celsius. The IMD forecast released on Sunday said that a 'hot spell' will prevail in the plain areas in North and North-Western India for the entire week. "Heat wave to severe heat wave conditions are likely to prevail over plains of northwest India and central India during many days of the week," the MeT Department said. During this time, people will also have to face heat waves. In such a situation, the Meteorological Department has advised people to be cautious and not to go out in the sun unless necessary. Meanwhile, the IMD is planning to expand its criteria for heat alerts to include a percentile-based threshold — a shift that would, for the first time, formally capture the kind of humid, oppressive heat that coastal regions routinely experience but that existing guidelines have long failed to flag.



# CM Rekha launches ₹100 cr projects in Dwarka for roads, drainage, power

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday launched various development projects worth approximately ₹100 crore in the Dwarka Assembly constituency. The projects launched in the Dwarka Assembly constituency mainly include repair and construction of roads in various areas, renovation and modernisation of chaupals, extensive works to strengthen the drainage system, beautification and green development of parks, laying of new sewer pipelines, transformer upgradation in various colonies, and replacement of old electricity cables. During the programme organised on the occasion, several important development works related to the area were initiated with the objec-



tive of providing better basic facilities to citizens and giving a modern shape to the regional infrastructure. The Chief Minister said that after completion of these pro-

jects, there will be significant improvement in problems such as waterlogging, damaged roads, sewer overflow and power supply in the area. Along with this, citizens will

get a safer, cleaner and more convenient environment. The Chief Minister said that that the Government's goal is not limited only to large schemes, but to effectively deliver basic facilities to every colony, every locality, every section and every citizen. She said that for the first time in Delhi, budget has been provided on such a large scale for development works in every Assembly constituency. She informed that development works worth around ₹100 crore have been launched in the Dwarka Assembly constituency, while additional special budget has also been allocated for various projects in the area. The Chief Minister informed that the Dwarka area will benefit from a new metro project worth ₹6,200 crore, under which new corridors are being developed under Phase-

5. She said that during previous Governments, metro projects had come to a halt because the Delhi Government was unable to provide even its share on time, whereas our Government has released ₹10,000 crore for metro expansion and accelerated development works. The Chief Minister said that after the formation of the double-engine Government, rapid work has also been carried out towards resolving issues related to unauthorised colonies. She said that long-pending issues related to registry and regularisation has been resolved so that people can get legal rights over their homes. Member of Parliament Kamaljeet Sehrawat, MLA Pradyumn Rajput, several public representatives of the area, officials and distinguished citizens were present on the occasion.

# Govt pushes 2-day WFH, carpooling, shifted office hours for fuel savings

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has advised private companies and organisations to adopt a two-day work-from-home policy, make changes to office timings, and urge employees to avail carpooling and public transport to support the fuel-saving efforts amid global uncertainties. Private entities involved in essential, emergency services like hospitals and other health establishments, electricity, water, sanitation and related municipal services, were not covered by the advisory issued

by the Delhi labour department. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta earlier this week launched the 90-day 'Mera Bharat, Mera Yogdan' fuel-saving campaign, stipulating two-day work-from-home for all Delhi Government employees, and use of public transport. She had said the private sector too will be urged to support these fuel-saving initiatives in response to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's appeal on wise expenditure of resources. The labour department advisory issued Sunday said in the background of the prevailing



global situation, it is imperative to conserve fuel — petrol, diesel and CNG — and ensure its optimal use.

Commuting to and from offices is one of the largest contributors to daily vehicular fuel consumption in the Capital, it noted.

A large proportion of this fuel use can be avoided through adoption of work-from-home (WFH) arrangements, which have demonstrated its operational feasibility during COVID-19 and GRAP-related curbs, it said. "In order to contribute to national fuel conservation efforts, all employers of industrial establishments, factories, shops and commercial establishments in Delhi, including IT, IT Enabled Services (ITES), among others are strongly encouraged to implement a minimum of two days of work-from-home per week," the advisory said.

# Traffic Police issue 2,846 challans in wrong-side driving crackdown

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Delhi Traffic Police issued 2,846 challans and registered 32 FIRs during a special enforcement drive against wrong-side driving and other traffic violations carried out across the Capital on Saturday evening. The two-hour operation was conducted jointly by the Traffic Police and local police teams between 4 pm and 6 pm at several vulnerable locations identified for frequent traffic violations and unsafe driving practices.



According to Delhi Traffic Police, the campaign was mainly aimed at curbing wrong-side driving, which

officials described as one of the leading causes of road accidents and traffic congestion in the city.

Out of the total challans issued during the drive, 757 were specifically for wrong-side driving. Police also registered 32 FIRs under Section 281 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and Section 184 of the Motor Vehicles Act against motorists allegedly involved in dangerous and rash driving that endangered public safety. Officials said integrated checking pickets were established at multiple hotspots across Delhi where incidents of wrong-side driving are regularly reported. Traffic personnel inter-

cepted violators and prosecuted them under relevant legal provisions during the operation. Apart from wrong-side driving, enforcement teams also took action against several other traffic violations. These included drunken driving, triple riding on two-wheelers, riding without helmets, dangerous driving, use of black films on vehicles and improper parking. Delhi Traffic Police said the drive was part of its continuing efforts to strengthen road discipline and improve commuter safety across the city.

# Delhi Police staff ordered to use metro after PM fuel-saving appeal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police has directed its personnel, particularly those posted at the Police Headquarters and offices connected by Metro, to use public transport for routine commuting following Prime Minister Narendra Modi's appeal to reduce fuel consumption and unnecessary expenditure. The General Administration Branch (GAB) of Delhi Police headquarters, with the approval of Senior officers, has



issued a set of directions, containing 13 measures aimed at reducing avoidable vehicular movement, conserving electricity and ensuring economical use of Government resources across all districts and specialised units of the force.

According to the order, staff posted in offices having Metro and public transport connectivity, especially at PHQ, have been encouraged to use public transport for daily commuting. "Staff posted in offices having Metro/public transport connectivity, particularly at PHQ, shall be encouraged to use public transport for routine commuting whenever operationally feasible," read the memorandum, issued by Deputy Commissioner of Police (GAB) Aalap Patel.

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# DMRC adds 24 extra Monday trains to boost public transport in NCR

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

With plans to run 24 additional train trips every Monday, deploy extra security personnel, expand ticketing facilities and strengthen last-mile connectivity services, the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) announced a series of measures aimed at encouraging more people to shift from private vehicles to public transport across Delhi-NCR.

The DMRC on Sunday said it will introduce 24 additional train trips with the deployment of six extra trains every Monday from May 18, while similar arrangements may also be made on other days depending on passenger demand.

The move comes as part of efforts to strengthen mass transit systems and improve urban mobility amid growing emphasis on energy security, environmental sustainability and reduced dependence on petroleum-based transport. According to the corporation, the additional services are aimed at handling a possible increase in passenger footfall and ensuring smooth and uninterrupted operations during peak travel periods.

It said passenger demand will be monitored closely and further steps will be taken whenever required. To manage higher commuter volumes, the DMRC will also deploy additional security personnel, open extra ticket counters, activate spare door frame metal detectors and baggage scanners, and take steps to reduce waiting time at frisking points, it stated.

Highlighting the metro network's role in integrated transport connec-

tivity, the corporation said several metro stations are linked with railway stations, interstate bus terminals, airport terminals, Namo Bharat Regional Rapid Transit System (RRTS), Noida Metro and Rapid Metro Gurugram. The connectivity network enables commuters to move conveniently between multiple transport systems and reduces reliance on private vehicles, it added.

The DMRC also underlined the metro network's accessibility to major commercial centres, Government offices, educational institutions, corporate hubs and tourist destinations across Delhi-NCR.

It said areas such as Connaught Place, Chandni Chowk, Cyber City, Hauz Khas, Nehru Place and key university campuses are directly connected through the metro network, making daily commuting easier for office-goers, students and tourists.

On last-mile connectivity, the DMRC said around 1 lakh passengers use services such as e-autos, e-rickshaws, bike taxis, cab aggregators and bicycle rentals daily across 160 metro stations, according to the DMRC.

The DMRC 'Saarthi App' offers integrated journey planning and allows commuters to book metro tickets and last-mile transport services through a single platform, it added.

The corporation also said that hydrogen-powered bus services have recently been introduced in the Central Vista area with support from Indian Oil Corporation Limited (IOCL) to improve last-mile connectivity between metro stations and Government offices.



## IN FOCUS



A pair of sparrows perch on the ground, in Prayagraj, Uttar Pradesh, PTI

# UP Govt prepares Dairy Master Plan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Lucknow

To promote indigenous cow breeds and increase milk production, the Yogi Adityanath Government has prepared a major Dairy Master Plan in Uttar Pradesh. Under the directives of Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, four major schemes have been implemented across the state to strengthen the rural economy while promoting indigenous cattle breeds, the UP government said in a statement on Sunday. The government's strategy is being viewed as 'Operation-4' because it revolves around four key schemes. These include the Mukhyamantri Swadeshi Gau Samvardhan Yojana, Mukhyamantri Pragatisheel Pashupalak Protsahan Yojana, Nandini Krishak



Samridhhi Yojana and Mini Nandini Krishak Samridhhi Yojana. Under these schemes, dairy units ranging from 2 to 25 cows are being provided subsidies worth lakhs of rupees. Additional Chief Secretary of the Animal Husbandry Department, Mukesh Meshram, said that the Yogi Adityanath government is offering substantial subsidies for rearing advanced indigenous cow breeds. Under the Nandini Krishak

Samridhhi Yojana and Mini Nandini Krishak Samridhhi Yojana, up to 50 per cent subsidy is being provided for establishing dairy units and boosting milk production. The financial model of these schemes is also unique. It includes 15 per cent beneficiary investment, 35 per cent bank loan and up to 50 per cent government subsidy. This is making it easier for small and medium farmers to start dairy businesses. Under the

Mukhyamantri Swadeshi Gau Samvardhan Yojana, a subsidy of up to ₹80,000 is being provided for a two-cow unit. This is expected to help develop a modern dairy network across the state on a large scale. Under the Mukhyamantri Pragatisheel Pashupalak Protsahan Yojana, cattle rearers maintaining high-quality indigenous cow breeds with higher milk yield are being given incentive amounts ranging from ₹10,000 to ₹15,000. This is promoting both breed conservation and milk production. The Yogi Adityanath government is particularly focusing on the conservation and promotion of advanced indigenous breeds such as Gir, Sahiwal and Gangatiri. These schemes are expected to create new employment opportunities in villages.

The government is rapidly working on a strategy to connect women and youth with the dairy sector and make them self-reliant. This is expected to give the rural economy fresh momentum. Additional Chief Secretary Mukesh Meshram said, "The impact of the government's indigenous cow-based schemes is now becoming visible on the ground. More than 1,500 units have already been established under the Mukhyamantri Swadeshi Gau Samvardhan Yojana, while over 7,500 awards have been distributed under the Pragatisheel Pashupalak Protsahan Yojana." Similarly, 72 dairy units have been established under the Nandini Krishak Samridhhi Yojana and 245 units under the Mini Nandini Yojana, providing fresh strength to the rural economy, the statement said.

## EPICs found strewn in Birbhum field



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Kolkata

A large number of Electoral Photo Identity Cards (EPIC) were found scattered in a field in West Bengal's Birbhum district on Sunday, while over a hundred Aadhaar cards and other documents were recovered from a TMC office in Bidhannagar, triggering political sparring and prompting police investigations in both incidents. The first incident came to light in Kirnahar area of Birbhum's Nanoor block, where locals spotted the voter cards lying across a field on Sunday morning. The field is located adjacent to the residence of a former Booth Level Officer (BLO), triggering suspicion and commotion in the area. Police reached the spot after being informed and began an investigation. According to local sources, the former BLO, Hiranyaprabha Mete Maji, who earlier served in Purba Bardhaman district's Ketugram block, was questioned by police over the matter. She had reportedly worked as a BLO from 2012 till 2025 before being removed in accordance with administrative norms.

# NEET-UG leak: CBI conducts searches at Renukai Chemistry Classes in Latur

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Latur

The Central Bureau of Investigation, which is probing the alleged NEET-UG paper leak, conducted searches at the main office of Renukai Chemistry Classes (RCC) in Maharashtra's Latur city on Sunday, sources said. CBI officials began the search at RCC in the city's Shrivnagar locality in the afternoon, and it was still underway till late evening, they said. The central agency had questioned RCC founder Shivravi Motegaonkar for nearly eight hours on Friday



at his residence, located in the same area. Sources said the CBI suspects that some doctors from Latur had purchased the "leaked" NEET examination paper. A CBI team has been

camping in Latur for the past four days. The federal agency has registered an FIR and formed teams to probe the alleged paper leak that resulted in the cancellation of the exam held on May 3.

The National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET) was conducted across 551 Indian cities and at 14 overseas centres. Nearly 23 lakh candidates had registered for the test, which was administered by the NTA (National Testing Agency) across the country. According to the NTA, information regarding alleged malpractice was received on the evening of May 7, four days after the exam was held. It said the inputs were escalated to central agencies the following morning for "independent verification and necessary action".

# Eid-ul-Adha to be celebrated in India on May 28, say Muslim clerics

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ New Delhi

Eid-ul-Adha will be celebrated in India on May 28 as the crescent moon marking the beginning of the Islamic month of Zil Hijja was not sighted on Sunday evening in most parts of the country, Muslim clerics said. Unlike Eid-ul-Fitr, Eid-ul-Adha is observed on the 10th day after the sighting of the moon. Shahi Imam of Fatehpuri Mosque in Delhi's Chandni Chowk, Mufti Mukarram Ahmed, said religious authorities contacted different parts of the country



regarding the sighting of the Zil Hijja moon on Sunday evening, but no confirmed reports were received from anywhere. "In view of this, it has been decided that Eid-ul-Adha will be celebrated on May 28," he told PTI. Shahi Imam of Jama

Masjid, Syed Shaban Bukhari, also announced in a video statement that Eid-ul-Adha would be observed on May 28, saying there were no reports of the moon being sighted anywhere in the country. Eid-ul-Adha, also known as Bakrid, is observed two months and nine days after Eid-ul-Fitr. Muslim organisation Imarat-e-Sharia Hind also said in a statement that no authenticated report of moon sighting was received from any part of the country and therefore Eid-ul-Adha would be celebrated on May 28.

# Amit Shah arrives in Raipur on three-day visit

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Raipur

Union Home Minister Amit Shah arrived in Raipur on Sunday on a three-day visit to Chhattisgarh during which he will attend a series of programmes and chair a meeting of the Central Zonal Council in Bastar region. It is Shah's first visit to Chhattisgarh after the state was declared free from armed Maoists on March 31. Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai said Shah's visit will give new momentum to development works in the state and further strengthen the government's resolve for a safe and prosperous Bastar.

Shah landed at Swami Vivekananda Airport here shortly after 8 pm and was received by CM Vishnu Deo Sai, Deputy Chief Minister Vijay Sharma, state ministers, BJP MPs, MLAs and other leaders of the party.

Sai and Sharma reached the airport in a single arcade while other leaders arrived in a bus in keeping with the austerity call given by Prime Minister



Narendra Modi amid the West Asia crisis. Shah left for a hotel in Nava Raipur Atal Nagar, where he will stay overnight, officials said. In a post on 'X', Sai said, "A warm welcome and greetings to Union Minister of Home Affairs and Cooperation, Amit Shah Ji, in Chhattisgarh, the 'nanihal' (the place of Lord Ram's maternal grandparents)

home of Lord Shri Ram and the sacred land of Mother Kaushalya." With the steadfast support of the Central government, Chhattisgarh has been continuously advancing towards a bright future of peace, good governance, and development, Sai said. "Thanks to the Home Minister's unwavering resolve and guidance, along with the dedicated efforts of the 'Double Engine' government, Bastar today stands liberated from Naxalism and is soaring to new heights of progress," he said. On Monday, at around 10.40 am, Shah will flag off new vehicles for the state police emergency response service 'Dial 112' and mobile forensic science laboratory from the parade ground of Police Training School in Raipur, a government official said. Shah will then leave for the Bastar district and visit Netanar village, where he will inaugurate a 'Jan Suvidha Kendra' aimed at providing easier access to government and digital services in remote areas, the official said.

# UP school dropout rates at 3% now: Adityanath

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Lucknow

Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Sunday said the school dropout rates in Uttar Pradesh have reduced to 3 per cent, asserting that his government will bring it down to zero. He was addressing a cheque distribution programme for 24,717 part-time instructors after their monthly honorarium was hiked from ₹7,000 to ₹17,000 in the state. Adityanath said the government also had no hesitation in extending benefits to part-time instructors as they never adopted "coercive methods" nor resorted to violence or pressure tactics for their demands. Launching a sharp attack on previous governments,



Adityanath alleged that the state of basic education before he became the CM in 2017 was "barren" and on the verge of collapse. "The dropout rate in the state used to be around 17-18 per cent. Out of every 100 children, nearly 17 or 18 would leave school prematurely. Today, we have reduced it to around three per cent and we

will bring it down to zero," he said. "When political leadership itself is corrupt, indecisive and directionless, then teachers, instructors and employees are unfairly blamed for failures," Adityanath said. Addressing the gathering, the chief minister said several proposals were pending in 2017 to terminate the ser-

vices of instructors in schools where the number of students had fallen below 100, but his government chose not to proceed with such measures. "There was neither a clear policy nor an honest intent earlier. How could basic education have improved in such a situation?" he said. Adityanath also defended schools involving students in community work and criticised the tendency to object to such activities on social media. "Whenever children participate in community service, some people project it negatively. I would say teachers should not face action for such initiatives, instead, they should be honoured for preparing children for the future," he said.

# Capital's war on drugs hid an extortion ring

Yadav was missing for weeks until he was questioned on May 11, which led to his arrest and extended court custody. The court also noted phone calls between Yadav and other officers during the raid.

Finding Yadav's wealth turned the case into a larger scandal. Financial investigations found suspicious transactions over ₹100 crore, and some sources say there was extortion of up to ₹50 lakh per case. The unit reportedly targeted businesspeople and people involved in the drug trade, running a system that created fake narcotics cases to force settlements.

Currently, the agency is tracking the entire money trail. Investigators are examining bank accounts, digital records, and possible connections to drug syndicates. As unit head, Yadav is believed to have orchestrated these operations with little interference. During questioning, Inspector Yadav reportedly named three senior IPS officers.

The CBI has not released or confirmed any names. The agency is investigating whether senior leaders protected the Dwarka unit or participated in the alleged ₹100-crore scheme.

Sources say the CBI sent a detailed report to central authorities, including the MHA, which oversees the Delhi Police. This has led to high-level transfers and concerns at the Centre about oversight and leadership in the Delhi Police. The Anti-Narcotics Cells of the Delhi Police are meant to fight drug trafficking. But this case suggests that some units may have started preying on citizens instead. The scheme reportedly targeted innocent people and small players in the drug scene. Officers planted evidence and threatened to file false cases, which hurts public trust and real drug enforcement. Yadav's ability to avoid arrest and the amount of his alleged wealth suggest there may be bigger problems with oversight and asset checks.

The investigation is still ongoing. CBI officials say more people are being questioned, and the focus is now on the whole financial network, past cases handled by the Dwarka ANC, and whether senior officers were involved. Yadav's custody has

been extended, and the courts are staying closely involved as the inquiry continues. As the CBI continues its investigation and the MHA reviews the report, there could be more arrests, major reforms, or a wider cleanup in the coming weeks. For now, Inspector Subhash Yadav's arrest has revealed a hidden economy operating within law enforcement. According to an insider who asked not to be named, the full truth may involve many more people.

# Questions mount as HDFC revises defaulter list...

On April 17, HDFC Bank filed rectified data of large defaulters up to March. As per the data, Banks large defaulters reduced from ₹54,315 crores to ₹49,432 crore. Recovery cases or entries reduced from 4,914 to 4,195. Rectified data up to March filed shows that HDFC banks has reduced the dues of their top defaulter Feed Back Energy Distribution dues from ₹1,876 crore to ₹876 crore. Similarly second biggest defaulter's dues were also reduced in the rectified filing. In up to February filing HDFC Bank said Chennai based SreeRengaraj Ispat Industries' dues was ₹1,764 crore. But the rectified filing up to March of the company shows dues is only ₹176 crore. Both companies are in insolvency or liquidations stages and there is no chance by them to pay loan dues to HDFC Bank within a month, after *The Pioneer* published the report on April 9. On April 22, *The Pioneer* wrote to HDFC Bank, asking how they reduced ₹4,883 crore and reduced 719 cases or entries: "We have just analysed HDFC Bank's new data filed to TransUnion CIBIL on Large Defaulters List up to March 2026, which shows a reduction of cases/entries. In your data up to February filings (we reported on April 9), the total dues were ₹54,315 crore with 4914 cases or entries. Now as per your March filing, the total dues reduced to ₹49,432 crore with 4195 cases or entries. So as per new data, 719 cases or entries are reduced and dues reduction of ₹4,883 crores. We are not going into all specifics of reduction. We are only seeking response on the main cases. As per your February filings, the highest dues were shown to

Delhi based Feedback Energy Distribution and its linked firm Feedback Infra with 17 cases or entries with a total due of ₹1,876 crore. Now as per your latest March filing, this company is having only eight cases or entries with a dues of ₹876 crore. The same is the case of Chennai based Sree Rengaraj Ispat Industries — with due of ₹1,764 crore with 10 cases or entries. Now in the March filings, the same company is having only one entry with Rs. 176 crore. The rest of the largest defaulters in our April 9 report is same in the new list and same dues are shown. Seeking your response on the reduction of 719 entries in the new filing of March 2026 and reduction of ₹4,883 crore. Is this mistakes corrected or loans repaid or written off or restructured?" Till date HDFC Bank, embroiled in many controversies, including their Chairman Atanu Chakraborty's exit without telling reasons, has not yet responded. As per the rectified list of large defaulters, Kolkata-based Riverbank Developers is the biggest defaulter with ₹1,572 crore in dues, followed by Karvy Stock Broking (₹1,558 crore), Mumbai-based Tycoons Avanti Projects (₹1,085 crore), Himachal Pradesh based and Delhi registered Indian Technomac (₹1,024 crore) and Noida based Daewoo Motors India Limited with a dues of ₹1,023 crore to HDFC bank through 14 loans. Other major defaulters of HDFC Bank in the range of ₹600 crore to ₹1,000 crore are : Cuttack based Gupta Power Infrastructure (₹976 crore), Mumbai based Tridhaatu Ventures (₹903 crore), Bengaluru based Camson Bio Technologies (INR 854 crore) and Faridabad based CMI Limited (₹758 crore). All these companies are now under insolvency or liquidation process. *The Pioneer* has published more than 20 articles so far about Largest Defaulters of 12 Public Sector Banks and three major private banks, crossing more than dues of ₹30 lakh crore is pending in recovery cases and many of the defaulter companies have fizzled out through insolvency or liquidation process and the persons behind these companies have siphoned this huge amount of money to their private accounts, assets in India and abroad. Now it is time for Finance Ministry and Government to make changes in laws and create Fast Track Courts to recover the money of public,

looted by these large defaulters in connivance with Bankers and their political patronising nexus with Corporates.

# After NEET shock, CBSE faces heat over...

The CBSE also announced this time that if students wish to view their answer sheets, they can do so by paying a fee of ₹100 instead of ₹700. If they want verification or validation of the answer sheet, that too will cost ₹100 instead of ₹500. If they want any particular answer rechecked, the fee will be ₹25 per question. "We have decided that if, during re-evaluation, a student's marks increase, then the amount paid for re-evaluation will be refunded to the student. We are more concerned about the well-being, welfare and mental state of our children. Money is important, but it is not the priority in this particular matter," he said. Kumar said the effort is to ensure that no child feels that they received lower marks than they deserved. "We will simply provide you with a copy of your answer sheet. By merely looking at the answer sheet, it will become evident how the marking was carried out. Once you review it, you may realise if there were instances where you should have been awarded higher marks. Since the answer sheets have already been scanned, I do not believe there is any need or any alternative method for further re-examination," he said. "Earlier, when the CBSE conducted evaluation or marking, it was generally done within the geographical jurisdiction of the respective regional offices. However, with OSM, it has now become possible to have answer sheets evaluated even outside the regional office area," the school education secretary explained.

# Satheesan announces ministerial team

The UDF also decided to appoint senior legislator Thiruvanchoor Radhakrishnan as Speaker of the Assembly, while Shanimol Usman will serve as

Deputy Speaker. He added that discussions on the allocation of portfolios among coalition partners were almost complete, with only minor corrections remaining. The final list would be formally submitted to the Governor and later notified through an official gazette following approval.

# India dismisses allegations of declining...

Rebutting the reported allegations, George highlighted India's cultural, religious and linguistic diversity. "Look at India, how beautiful it is. There is no other country in the world where so many religions have originated — Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism and Sikhism. These religions originated in India and continue to flourish," he said. He stressed how major world religions found a home in India and continue to thrive. "India is perhaps one of those very few countries where the Jewish population never faced any persecution. This is the beauty of India," he said. "Christianity came to India immediately after the resurrection of Jesus Christ, and continues to flourish in India. Today, more than 30 million Christians are in India. Christianity came to India much before it came to Europe," he said. George further said, "Islam came to India during the time of Prophet Muhammad himself and flourished in India." The diplomat, citing the recently held assembly elections in the country, said India is a vibrant democracy where peaceful transition of power is a key feature. George said India achieved economic success without "compromising" on democratic principles. "We did not go for violence to eliminate poverty. We went through the democratic process to eliminate poverty." "We are one-sixth of the total population of the world, but not one-sixth of the problems of the world. This is the beauty of India, which makes us proud. Every minority thrives," he said. "When we became independent, the minority population was 11 per cent, now it is more than 20 per cent," he said, emphasising that people from all faiths live happily in India. (PTI)

## GRAPEVINE

### India exhibits austerity at Cannes

The 79th edition of the Cannes International Film Festival in France is underway till May 23, 2026, where six Indian films have been shortlisted. To 'promote' Indian cinema, India too is being represented by all the stakeholders of Cinema world. Like every year, top officials from the Government side also reached France, with some of them with spouse, children for the May 12 inauguration day. Hotel price were exorbitant for a small accommodation per night INR value ₹80,000. Grapevine has it that sooner the officials landed in France, news flowed in of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's May 10 appeals like judicious use of fuel, use of public transport and above all avoid foreign trips. While half of the dozen officials immediately booked a return flight to India, some of them have already curtailed their schedules.



### How did the CBI Director get an extension?

Talks are very much on how CBI Director Praveen Sood got yet another extension. Grapevine has it that Chief Justice of India Surya Kant seems to have not agreed to the names suggested by Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Only Rahul Gandhi, the other member of CBI appointment committee, publicly said he dissented as a responsible Leader of Opposition. This is the second extension of the CBI Director. Government infact had given a long list of officers, instead of proposing 4/5 names, a practice being applied for last two appointments of new VBI Director. The same things had happened in the previous selection panel as LoP and CJJ as well had expressed displeasure over 50 names presented in the meeting.



### The Bihari Babus

In the wake of recent controversies related to the secondary education (CBSE and NEET), two top IAS from Bihar cadre – Sanjay Kumar and Rahul Singh – are in the thick of storm. While 1990 batch Sanjay Kumar is head of the School Education Department of Central Government, 1996 batch Rahul Singh heads CBSE and his boss is Sanjay Kumar. Both the officer has time and again proved his mettle in his home cadre and was being looked upon for significant assignments in Bihar where change of guard happened just now. Sanjay Kumar has been tagged as Bihar's Shashi Tharoor within the intellectual circle and is due to retire next month end, Rahul Singh who spearheaded significant movement in social sector like Jeevika in Bihar was awaiting a green signal from Bihar leadership until the CBSE evaluation goof-up happened. The Whatsapp groups of related batches and cadre of IAS officers are filled with sympathy for the duo. One of the IAS quipped, "why do you leave Nagaland cadre 1995 batch Abhishek Singh, current NTA DG, as he too has a Bihari DNA". He meant to say Abhishek Singh hails from Ranchi (now Jharkhand) from undivided Bihar when he made it into IAS and also a competent career bureaucrat.



## Fire breaks out in Delhi-bound Rajdhani

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Bhopal

A fire broke out on a Rajdhani Express train heading from Thiruvananthapuram to New Delhi in Madhya Pradesh's Ratlam district on Sunday morning, damaging two coaches and affecting traffic on the Mumbai-Delhi route for several hours, officials said. While no casualties were reported in the fire, a van carrying repair and other equipment to the site later overturned in the district, injuring five railway staffers.

Schedules of more than 10 trains on the Mumbai-Delhi route were affected due to damage caused to the overhead equipment in the incident. Rail traffic was later restored after more than seven hours, even as an investigation was underway into the cause of the blaze.

The Thiruvananthapuram-Hazrat Nizamuddin Rajdhani Express (train no. 12431) had departed from Ratlam Junction at around 3.45 am. The blaze erupted at 5.15 am in the B-1 coach of the train between Vikramgarh Alot and Lunirichha stations



Flames and smoke billow after a fire broke out in an AC coach of the Thiruvananthapuram-Hazrat Nizamuddin Rajdhani Express in Madhya Pradesh's Ratlam district on Sunday

under the Kota division of the railways and also damaged the luggage-cum-guard van behind the coach, West Central Railway's Chief Public Relation Officer Harshit Shrivastava told PTI over the phone.

The coach, carrying as many as 68 passengers, was evacuated within 15 minutes, and there were no

casualties, officials said. Railway authorities immediately switched off the overhead electric supply, and the fire was doused.

The affected coach was later detached from the rake, and the train headed for its onward journey at around 9.45 am, Shrivastava said. Arrangements were made to accommodate the passen-

gers in other coaches for their onward journey up to Kota in Rajasthan, Kota railway PRO Ravindra Lakhara said.

Some trains were halted at different stations following the incident, and the movement was restored after more than seven hours, the officials said. "The fire affected the movement of 13 passenger trains. The repair

WHILE NO CASUALTIES WERE REPORTED IN THE FIRE, A VAN CARRYING REPAIR AND OTHER EQUIPMENT TO THE SITE OVERTURNED IN THE DISTRICT, INJURING FIVE RAILWAY STAFFERS

work of the overhead equipment on the (Delhi-bound) up line, on which the train caught fire, was completed around 1 pm. On the down Delhi-Mumbai line, it was done at 8.30 am," Lakhara said. Ratlam Divisional Railway Manager Ajay Kumar Kalara was monitoring the situation. A relief train and a tower wagon were sent for rescue and restoration work.

In a related incident, five railway staffers were injured, one of them critically, as a van carrying essential equipment for overhead electric line repair overturned on its way to Alot from Shyamnagar in Ratlam when a cow suddenly strayed into the middle of the road, they said. The injured persons were rushed to the hospital and were subsequently referred to Kota in Rajasthan, officials said.

### New book about Project Cheetah set to be launched on May 23

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Nearly four years after the launch of 'Project Cheetah', which sought to bring back the world's fastest animal to India, a new book about the initiative will be launched on May 23. It is authored by Prashant Agrawal, an Indian Foreign Service (IFS) officer, who led the negotiations that made the cheetah's return to the country possible.

The book, 'Bringing the Cheetah Back to India', published by Hachette India, is an account of the diplomatic effort to restore the cheetah. "This book for the first time narrates the human drama behind one of conservation's most ambitious experiments," according to the book's blurb.

From high offices in Namibia to fast-paced action in New Delhi, 'Bringing the Cheetah Back to India' tells the astonishing story of how nations joined hands in a race against time to resurrect a ghost, restore an ecosystem.

## Why no action against Pradhan, asks Rahul

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Sunday asked Prime Minister Narendra Modi why he was not sacking Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan despite repeated paper leaks in his tenure. In a post on social media, Gandhi also questioned the "silence" of the prime minister on the matter.

"NEET 2024: Paper leaked. Exam not cancelled. Minister did not resign. CBI set up an investigation. A committee was formed."

"NEET 2026: Paper leaked. Exam cancelled. Minister still did not resign. CBI is investigating again. Another committee will be formed," Gandhi posted on social media.

The National Testing Agency cancelled the National Eligibility cum Entrance Exam (Undergraduate) held on May 3 amid allegations of



irregularities. The re-exam has been scheduled for June 21.

"Mr Modi, the country is asking you some questions — answer them! Why are paper leaks happening repeatedly? Why are you silent time and again on this 'Pariksha pe Charcha'? Why aren't you dismissing the education minister who keeps failing repeatedly?" The Leader of Opposition in

Lok Sabha asked, using the hashtag "#SackPradhan".

'Pariksha pe Charcha' is a programme in which the prime minister interacts with students, parents and teachers. The initiative aims to reshape the examination experience of students by fostering confidence, positivity, and holistic well-being.

On Saturday, Gandhi demanded that the prime

minister should immediately sack Pradhan or take responsibility himself.

He also alleged that the "BJP-RSS nexus" has destroyed India's education system and said the hard work of 22 lakh NEET aspirants has gone to waste.

"The whole country knows that two days before NEET, its question paper was being distributed on WhatsApp. Dharmendra Pradhan ji says he has nothing to do with the matter. The (Parliamentary) Committee had made recommendations but he put it in the dustbin on the pretext that opposition people were on the committee and that it was of no use," Gandhi said in a video statement.

Pradhan on Friday announced that the NEET-UG re-examination would be held on June 21. He said the medical entrance exam would be computer-based from next year onwards in view of irregularities linked to it.

## CBSE's 3 language policy sparks concerns over timing, logistics



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ New Delhi

Concerns have been raised over the implementation of the CBSE's three-language policy for Class 9 by a section of educationists and parents who have questioned the timing of the changes and the preparedness of schools, as the academic session is already well underway.

The Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) on Friday made three languages, including at least two native Indian languages, compulsory for Class 9 students from July 1 this year, even as schools had already begun classes and unit tests for the new academic session.

Mount Abu School Principal Jyoti Arora termed the implementation "very sudden". She also said greater clarity was needed on the status of English within the policy framework to ensure smooth implementation.

Though the three-language formula introduced by the CBSE is in sync with the National Education Policy, "which is a very progressive document", its implementation after the academic session had already begun has created "a sense of restlessness" among stakeholders, Arora told PTI.

Roji Devi, mother of a Class 9 student, said, "My son has opted for French as the second language with English as the first language in one of the top schools in Delhi. Unit tests for both

English and French for 40 marks have been completed and suddenly he has to leave one of these two under the new CBSE guideline."

"Why has CBSE issued these guidelines just now, after 45 days into the new session? You are allowing something first and saying two months later that you can't do it. Had the CBSE issued the guidelines in March, we would have prepared or even looked for other options. Isn't democracy about informed choices? Isn't the CBSE's decision arbitrary?" she said.

A key shift in the curriculum is the classification of English as a foreign language, with the Board allowing only one foreign language within the three-language framework. This could restrict students from choosing both English and another foreign language as their second and third languages.

"My daughter had taken French as her third language from Class 6, and she was clear that in Class 9 she would continue with English and French. She never focused much on Hindi because students earlier had the flexibility to choose any two languages in Classes 9 and 10," said Tina Singhal, parent of a Class 9 student.

"Now suddenly, she may have to drop French despite having a genuine interest in it. She has been preparing for French for months, and now there is pressure on children because they have to manage an additional language," she said.

## Himachal Pradesh: 69.16% polling in urban local bodies election

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Jammu

A turnout of 69.16 per cent was recorded in the election to 51 urban local bodies in Himachal Pradesh on Sunday, officials said.

The polling was peaceful throughout the state, State Chief Election Commissioner Anil Khachi said. He said 72.42 per cent polling was recorded in municipal councils and nagar panchayats, and 63.44 per cent in municipal corporations, adding that the percentage could increase slightly.

Voting for 51 urban local bodies commenced at 7 am and concluded at 3 pm. It was held simultaneously in 64 wards in the four municipal corporations of Dharamshala, Solan, Mandi and Palampur, 229 wards in



25 municipal councils and 156 wards in 22 nagar panchayats in a single phase, with as many as 1,147 candidates in the fray for the 449 posts. A 70-year-old man, Anjan Sharma, died near a polling booth while he was on his way to cast his vote in municipal council elections in Chamba. Preliminary reports suggest that he suffered a heart attack.

There was some commotion when BJP MLA from Una

Satpal Singh Satti entered a booth in Ward Number 6 in Santagorh in his constituency. The voting percentage was 63.72 in the municipal corporations of Dharamshala and Palampur in Kangra district, 68.78 per cent in Mandi and 58.32 per cent in Solan.

Women voters surpassed men in Kangra and Mandi while male voters exceeded in Solan district Municipal Corporation polls.

## Fuel, LPG price hike an assault on working class, says CITU

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

The Centre of Indian Trade Unions (CITU) on Sunday vehemently condemned the BJP-led Central Government's decision to sharply increase the retail prices of essential fuels and cooking gas, terming the move a "direct assault" on the livelihoods of the working class, small farmers, and ordinary citizens.

Demanding an immediate and unconditional rollback of the inflated prices, the trade union body called upon its State committees and affiliated unions across the country to launch fierce, united protests against the hike.

In a scathing statement issued by CITU General Secretary Elamaram Kareem, the union criticised the



overnight hike of ₹3 per litre on petrol and diesel, alongside a ₹2 per kg increase in CNG prices effective from May 15. The union noted that this "merciless move" comes on the heels of previous steep hikes in domestic cooking gas, which pushed the price of a 14.2 kg LPG cylinder to a staggering ₹913 in Delhi, and shot commercial LPG prices up by over ₹14.50.

Slamming the Centre's justification linking the hike to

West Asian conflicts and Brent crude crossing the \$100 per barrel threshold, CITU termed the narrative "hypocritical and dishonest." The union pointed out that when international crude oil prices collapsed to record lows during the 2020 pandemic and hovered around \$60-\$70 per barrel as recently as January 2026, the Government refused to pass on the benefits of cheap fuel to Indian consumers.

## Houselisting operations for Census 2027 kick off in 5 States, Delhi MCD area

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

The field operations for the Houselisting and Housing Census (HLO) under Phase I of Census 2027 have commenced in five States and Union Territories namely Rajasthan, Meghalaya, Maharashtra, Jharkhand and Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) area in Delhi NCT, as part of the ongoing nationwide Census exercise, ministry of home affairs said here on Sunday.

It also said more than 1.44 crore households have already completed Self-Enumeration through the official portal (se.census.gov.in) across 25 States/UTs. The initiative

marks a significant step towards the digitisation of Census operations and offers residents a convenient and secure platform to participate in the Census process.

The Self-Enumeration (SE) facility, introduced for the first time in Census operations, continues to receive an encouraging response from the public.

Meanwhile, House-to-House Houselisting Operations by Enumerators are presently in progress in Andhra Pradesh, Arunachal Pradesh, Bihar, Chandigarh, Chhattisgarh, Dadra & Nagar Haveli and Daman & Diu, Haryana, Madhya Pradesh, Punjab, Telangana and Uttarakhand.

The Self-Enumeration (SE)



facility has commenced today in Gujarat, Jammu & Kashmir, Ladakh and Puducherry and will remain available till May 31, 2026. The corresponding Houselisting and Housing Census field operations in these States/UTs will be conducted from June 1 to June 30, 2026.

The Self-Enumeration facility is also currently underway in Uttar Pradesh and will continue till May 21, following which the HLO field operations will be conducted from May 22 to June 20.

Earlier, the Houselisting and Housing Census operations conducted from April 16 to May 15 were completed in the States/UTs of Andaman & Nicobar Islands, Lakshadweep, Mizoram, Odisha and Sikkim,

along with the NDMC area and Delhi Cantonment Board area in the National Capital Territory of Delhi.

Residents who have completed Self-Enumeration are requested to keep their generated Self-Enumeration ID (SE ID) ready and share the same with the Enumerator during the field visit to complete the HLO process. Households that have not opted for Self-Enumeration will be covered during the physical house-to-house visit by Enumerators.

Census 2027 is being conducted using digital tools for the first time while retaining the traditional door-to-door enumeration process to ensure comprehensive and accurate coverage.

During field visits, Enumerators are collecting data digitally through a dedicated mobile application. During this phase, information relating to housing conditions, household details, amenities available and assets possessed by households is being collected through a structured questionnaire comprising 33 notified questions. The data collected form an important basis for evidence-based planning and implementation of welfare and development programmes.

All data collected under the Census Act, 1948, remains strictly confidential and is used solely for statistical purposes and development planning.

## States Focus



### NOT JEALOUS OF CM JOSEPH VIJAY, SAYS RAJINIKANTH

Superstar Rajinikanth on Sunday denied he was "jealous" about Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay and clarified that his recent meeting with DMK president MK Stalin was "purely" a friendship call and not done with any political motive. Talking to reporters at his Poes Garden residence, and responding to some reports, the top star made it clear that the meeting with the former chief minister Stalin was not an attempt to hinder Vijay's chief ministerial aspirations or merge political parties. Dismissing that he had any envy towards TVK founder and chief minister Vijay, the "Jailer" star said there was a 25-year generational gap between him and the CM and commended Vijay's impressive achievements at a young age, which he said surpassed even those of the legendary MGR (MG Ramachandran) and NTR (NT Rama Rao).



### ADHIR WRITES TO CM SUVENDU OVER ANIMAL SLAUGHTER NOTICE

Senior Congress leader Adhir Chowdhury on Sunday sought the intervention of West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari over the State Government's public notice on animal slaughter guidelines, as it has caused "confusion and unrest", particularly among the minority community in Murshidabad district. Chowdhury, in a letter to Adhikari, said the public notice issued by the State Government on May 13 regarding adherence to "Animal Slaughter Guidelines" has caused confusion and unrest in Murshidabad, where the minority community constitutes the majority of the population.

## BJP sets 13-point agenda for Kerala, focuses on OBC outreach

TG BIJU  
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Buoyed by its victory in three seats in the April 9 Kerala Assembly elections, the BJP has unveiled a 13-point political agenda that it said would shape its strategy in the State ahead of the next Lok Sabha elections.

The agenda places a clear focus on consolidating support among Hindu backward communities while recalibrating the party's outreach to minority groups.

It was part of a political resolution adopted at a BJP State core committee meeting held on Saturday and chaired by Rajeev Chandrasekhar, a party source said.

According to the source, the party's document does not explicitly outline fresh outreach initiatives towards minority communities, particularly Christians, despite earlier attempts to build closer ties with the community ahead of the Assembly elections.

Those efforts, however, were not sustained for



various reasons, the source added.

On minority outreach, the source said the party has not discontinued engagement with the Christian community, pointing out that its members continue to hold organisational positions in several districts.

However, it has moved away from attempts to build institutional bridges with Church leadership amid the growing political alignment of bishops with the Congress-led UDF.

The informal shift, according to party insiders, fol-

lowed the Catholic Church's strong opposition to the Centre's move to introduce the contentious Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act (FCRA) Amendment Bill, 2026, in Parliament-a development that put the BJP on the defensive during the Kerala Assembly election campaign.

At the same time, the BJP's agenda places sharper emphasis on Hindu backward communities, particularly through its position on OBC reservation, stating that it should not be implemented under the guise of

religious reservation.

The party is seen as attempting to strengthen its outreach to key social groups, including the numerically significant Ezhava community, which remains a crucial support base for the State's two major Left parties, the Communist Party of India (Marxist) and the Communist Party of India.

On reservations, the BJP said that "religious reservation under the guise of OBC reservation should be completely abolished" and that reservation policies should be restricted to OBC, SC/ST and EWS categories.

The resolution further stated that no group should receive preferential treatment through "appeasement" and stressed the need for equal opportunities for all Malayalis.

"The BJP will not allow backward class reservation to be turned into religion-based reservation," Chandrasekhar said, highlighting the issue as part of the party's efforts to further expand its outreach among backward Hindu communities. (PTI)

## West Bengal will handover land to BSF for border fence in 45 days: Minister

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Bongaon (WB)

West Bengal minister Ashok Kirtania on Sunday said the State Government was committed to handing over land to the Border Security Force (BSF) within 45 days for the erection of a fence along the Bangladesh border.

Kirtania, the Food and Supply minister, who represents the Bongaon Uttar constituency in North 24 Parganas district, remarked after visiting his constituency to review the progress of land acquisition and meet

Border Security Force (BSF) officials to assess the ground-level developments.

He said land acquisition in most parts of the North 24 Parganas district was progressing satisfactorily, but flagged resistance in the Basirhat area.

"I had a word with the district magistrate, and I was informed that, except for three mouzas in Basirhat, there are no issues. Some residents of Basirhat are refusing to move from the fencing area, and some families who will fall inside the fencing are refusing rehabilitation,"



West Bengal minister Ashok Kirtania

Kirtania told reporters.

The minister said he directed the district magistrate to resolve the impasse within a week. "I have asked the DM to convince them within a week," he said.

The newly elected BJP Government in West Bengal, led by Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari, had in its first Cabinet meeting on May 11 decided to transfer land to the BSF for completing the fencing of the India-Bangladesh border, with a 45-day deadline for the handover. The Cabinet had authorised the transfer of

around 600 acres to the BSF.

West Bengal shares approximately 2,217 km of the roughly 4,097 km India-Bangladesh border.

According to Union Home Ministry data, of the 2,217 km in West Bengal, around 1,648 km has been fenced while 569 km remains uncovered, of which 456 km is feasible for fencing.

The BJP had accused the previous Trinamool Congress Government of Mamata Banerjee of consistently delaying land acquisition for fencing, a charge the TMC denied.

## West Bengal Govt clears handover of 7 highway stretches to NHAI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Kolkata

The West Bengal Government gave in-principle approval for handing over seven stretches of national highways to the NHAI and the NHIDCL, paving the way for long-pending infrastructure works on key road corridors in the State.

These stretches were under the national highway wing of the State's Public Works Department (PWD), and the handover proposals had been pending for nearly a year despite repeated requests from the Union Ministry of Road Transport and Highways, according to an official statement.

The press note issued by the chief secretary's office on Saturday said, "Development works on these stretches stood stalled in the absence of a formal handover. With today's clearance, the central agencies can move forward without further delay."

Among the stretches handed over to the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) are 329.6 km of NH-312 connecting Jangipur, Omarpur, Krishnagar, Bongaon and Basirhat up to



Ghojadanga along the India-Bangladesh border, besides NH-31 from the Bihar-West Bengal border to Gazole, and NH-33 up to Farakka.

Four other stretches, including the Sevoke Army Cantonment-Coronation Bridge-Kalimpong-West Bengal-Sikkim border route under new NH-10, have been handed over to the National Highways and Infrastructure Development Corporation Ltd (NHIDCL), the note stated.

The other corridors include the Hasimara-Jaigaon stretch up to the India-Bhutan border, the Baradighi-Mainaguri-Changrabandha route up to the Bangladesh border, and the Siliguri-Kurseong-Darjeeling hill road.

The State Government said that infrastructure works on

the seven stretches would strengthen connectivity to Sikkim, Bhutan and Bangladesh, while improving links between north Bengal and the Dooars.

These projects are also expected to improve the Bihar-West Bengal corridor through Malda and Murshidabad and boost connectivity in Nadia and North 24 Parganas districts up to the Bangladesh border at Ghojadanga.

"With these approvals, the State Government has cleared the way for the central agencies concerned to commence development works on all seven stretches," the statement said and described the move as part of efforts for "coordinated execution of critical national infrastructure projects".

## Odisha Police arrest 1,771 in 5 days, seize 3,000 kg ganja

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Bhubaneswar

The Odisha Police have arrested 1,771 people and seized over 3,000 kg of ganja, 20 unlicensed guns and other illegal items during a special drive, an official statement said on Sunday.

On the instructions of DGP Yogesh Bahadur Khurania, the five-day drive was conducted from May 12-16 under the leadership of SPs and police commissioners across the State. Additional Director

General of Police (Law and Order) Sanjay Kumar supervised it.

The main objectives of the operation were to execute non-bailable warrants (NBW), arrest persons wanted in pending cases, prevent smuggling of narcotics (ganja and brown sugar), seize vehicles involved in transportation of illegal weapons and minerals and crack down on drunken driving, the statement said.

Speaking to reporters



here, Khurania said, "The special drive by Odisha Police was successful as we have executed more than 1,700 NBWs, six persons have been booked under NSA, while 50 absconders were nabbed during the five days."

## AMMK MLA Kamaraj will face disqualification: Dhinakaran

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Tiruchirappalli

TTV Dhinakaran, chief of AMMK, said on Sunday that his party MLA, S Kamaraj, who supported the TVK Government during the floor test, would face disqualification.

Amma Makkal Munnetra Kazhagam, which was allied with the NDA comprising AIADMK, BJP and PMK, contested 11 Assembly seats in the Tamil Nadu elections and secured victory only in the Mannargudi constituency.

AMMK candidate S Kamaraj won the election by



TTV Dhinakaran, S Kamaraj

defeating senior DMK leader TRB Rajaa by a margin of 1,566 votes.

On May 12, Dhinakaran "removed" his party's lone MLA from the organisation for the legislator's "unilateral

support for the ruling Tamilaga Vetttri Kazhagam.

"Kamaraj's action is a major betrayal of the workers of AMMK, as well as those from alliance parties who worked for his victory in

the election, besides the people who placed their faith in him and voted for him," he had said.

The development comes days after Dhinakaran levelled "horse-trading" allegations against TVK over his MLA's alleged support for the ruling party, charges that TVK dismissed.

"I have now removed Kamaraj from the party. Let him go and join the other side (TVK) and become a minister if they offer him the post. Then we shall see what the next step is. Even if only one MLA defects, disqualification provisions will

apply," Dhinakaran told reporters.

"He (Kamaraj) thinks we cannot take action because he is the party's lone MLA. We will take the necessary steps. TVK accepting his support is legally questionable. We will strongly oppose what we consider a case of 'horse-trading,'" he alleged.

Emphasising the enduring legacy of AIADMK founder MG Ramachandran (MGR) and former Chief Minister J Jayalalithaa, Dhinakaran urged party leaders to maintain unity and avoid hasty decisions that could "demoralise cadres".

## Nicobar project recipe for ecological disaster: Jairam

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Congress leader Jairam Ramesh on Sunday wrote to Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on the Great Nicobar Island Project, saying the project in its present shape and form is a recipe for "ecological disaster".

Congress leaders have been flagging concerns over the project, claiming it would have a bearing on the ecology and tribal rights in the region.

In his letter to the minister, he said that while there can be no two opinions on the need to strengthen India's defences, he suggested some measures to help strengthen its strategic capabilities around the Great

Nicobar project.

He said such measures have been proposed by naval officers in their writings and can help improve the country's defence without much damage to the area's ecology.

Ramesh shared the letter on social media, saying, "After writing to the Union Minister of Environment, Forests, & Climate Change and the Union Minister of Tribal Affairs, I have written to the Raksha Mantri on the Great Nicobar Island Project."

Ramesh, who has earlier served as Environment minister, said on May 1, the Government of India had issued a press note titled 'The Great Nicobar Island Project: FAQs'.



Kirtania told reporters.

The minister said he directed the district magistrate to resolve the impasse within a week. "I have asked the DM to convince them within a week," he said.

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around 600 acres to the BSF.

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The BJP had accused the previous Trinamool Congress Government of Mamata Banerjee of consistently delaying land acquisition for fencing, a charge the TMC denied.

## UDF will have most capable team of ministers: Venugopal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Alappuzha (Kerala)

Ahead of the swearing-in of the VD Satheesan-led Government in Kerala, senior Congress leader KC Venugopal on Sunday said that the UDF dispensation would have "one of the most capable teams" of ministers and would move forward in line with the aspirations of the people.

Speaking to reporters, the AICC general secretary said the announcement of ministers would be made ahead of the swearing-in ceremony on Monday.

"We will have one of the most capable teams as ministers in the UDF Government. The State is waiting in hope for a new

regime that can bring meaningful change and work for the public, rather than indulge in unnecessary controversies. The UDF Government is preparing itself for that responsibility and should be given time to function," he said.

He said that the five guarantees given by UDF during the election period will be implemented.

The guarantees include free bus travel for women and a monthly assistance of ₹1,000 for college-going girl students.

Responding to criticism from Opposition parties and some caste leaders over the prominence of the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) in the UDF, Venugopal said such remarks were attempts



to create controversy even before the Government assumed office.

He said such "venomous statements" should be avoided.

"The election results themselves showed that people in Kerala do not

accept communal polarisation. Repeatedly targeting the IUML was a deliberate attempt to create divisions in society and was not driven by good intentions.

Kerala is a land where love and communal harmony thrive, not a place where

divisive politics would succeed," he said.

Regarding the functioning of the UDF, he said none of the constituent parties would try to dominate one another, and that all decisions would be taken collectively.

"Congress has its own ideology and methods, while IUML has its own, but within the UDF framework, all decisions would be taken through consensus," he said.

Venugopal also said the party had wanted senior leader Ramesh Chennithala to be included in the Cabinet and that his willingness to join was a positive development.

He added that Alappuzha would receive strong representation and that its development would remain his key focus.

## Swearing-in marks launch of Team UDF: Shafi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Congress MP Shafi Parambil on Sunday said the swearing-in of the Kerala chief minister and the council of ministers on Monday would mark the launch of "Team UDF."

Speaking to reporters, Parambil said the process had moved swiftly, with the CM being decided within 11 days and only a few more days taken to finalise the ministers.

"All ministers are going to be sworn in on Monday. It is the launch of Team UDF. The days are coming when the promises made by the UDF to the people will be realised," he said.

Parambil, who is KPCC vice-president and MP from



Vadakara, said the ongoing discussions on the Cabinet were a crucial process to ensure the formation of a Government that works in the interest of the people.

"There is no controversy as claimed. Decisions are being taken after examining all options. The proposal will be placed before the AICC, which will approve it," he said.

He said similar discussions were being held with other UDF constituents, and there were no major differences, with things moving forward smoothly.

"Our supporters will reach here to witness the swearing-in event. It will be the beginning of the relief sought by people after 10 years of hardship," he said.

# BJP-led NDA governs 80% of India territory, says Shah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Gandhinagar

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Sunday hailed the BJP's recent victory in West Bengal polls and said the party and its NDA allies now govern 80 per cent of the country's territory.

Addressing a gathering after inaugurating and laying the foundation stone for projects worth ₹620 crore for the Gandhinagar Municipal Corporation, he said the Congress was "wiped out" in Gujarat's local body elections. The AAP "could not even open an account", he said.

Earlier in the day, Shah attended multiple events. Addressing a gathering after inaugurating Ganesh Housing's "Million Minds Tech Park" in Ahmedabad, he said Gujarat must now elevate itself to the top position in the service sector after performing exceptionally well across key segments like manufacturing, engineering, and green energy.



Union Home Minister Amit Shah during the inauguration of the Million Minds Tech Park and GREMI City Campus in Ahmedabad

At the National Institute of Design in Gandhinagar, he pitched for the creation of a separate vertical to connect designers with commercial opportunities, drawing a parallel with the transformation brought about in cricket by the IPL.

He also inaugurated a milk processing and packaging plant of Madhur Dairy in Gandhinagar district and said

that the massive growth of the sector has brought about a profound transformation in the lives of women.

Shah said the BJP's "unstoppable journey of development" in Gujarat began under Prime Minister Narendra Modi and was later carried forward by former chief ministers Anandiben Patel and Vijay Rupani and current CM Bhupendra Patel.

"As a result of this pro-development approach of the BJP, Congress was completely wiped out in the recent local body elections. Even if we search far and wide with binoculars, Congress is nowhere to be seen," Shah said.

"And people from AAP, claiming 'we will win this, we will win that', got wiped out in Delhi, and here they couldn't even open an account here," he added.

Shah praised BJP workers for maintaining close contact with people and resolving their issues, saying this had strengthened public trust in the party. Recalling the COVID-19 pandemic period, Shah said BJP workers across Gujarat served people selflessly.

"Somewhere they delivered food kits to the poor, somewhere they took those who had no one to hospitals, somewhere they arranged testing, and somewhere BJP workers managed vaccination lines without taking their own vaccine," Amit Shah said.

## BKS seeks 100% procurement of pulses, oilseeds; pitches for cow-based agriculture

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Sukma (Chhattisgarh)

The Bharatiya Kisan Sangh (BKS) on Sunday demanded 100 per cent assured procurement of pulses and oilseeds, direct incentives for crop diversification and a complete ban on the use of modern gene-editing tools in farming and crop development. The demands were raised following a two-day executive committee meeting of the BKS held in Mount Abu, Rajasthan, on May 16-17.

In a statement, the RSS affiliate said India's dependence on imports of pulses and edible oils even after 78 years of Independence was a serious concern linked to the country's food security and sovereignty.

The farmers' body urged the Centre to adopt a "comprehensive and practical" policy framework to achieve self-reliance in pulses, oilseeds and edible oil production.

BKS general secretary Mohini Mohan Mishra said the prevailing monocropping system was harmful to



biodiversity, food diversity and climate sustainability.

He also stressed the need for crop diversification through intercropping, mixed farming and crop rotation, along with promoting 'Gau Krishi Vaanijyam' (cow-based agriculture and commerce), to preserve soil fertility and reduce input costs for farmers.

The BKS demanded guaranteed 100 per cent procurement of all pulses and oilseed crops, claiming that even limited procurement of pulses in 2016 led to a sharp increase in production.

It also sought direct financial incentives for farmers

adopting soil conservation practices, climate-resilient agricultural practices and crop diversification.

The BKS also called for the conservation and promotion of indigenous seeds and improved varieties developed through conventional breeding methods to protect farmers from purchasing costly seeds repeatedly.

"To save farmers from the cycle of purchasing expensive seeds every year, the government should promote conservation and development of indigenous seeds and improved varieties developed through conventional breeding methods," it said.

## Bihar schools told to follow NCERT bag weight norms

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Patna

The Bihar Education Department has asked all private and Government-aided schools to adhere to the NCERT's guidelines to ensure that the gross weight of a school bag does not exceed 10 per cent of the child's body weight.

The department has also directed schools to ensure that weighing scales are installed on campus to regularly check the weight of bags. Any private schools found to be in violation will face action, officials said.



Bihar Education Minister Mithlesh Tiwari said on Sunday "All private and Government-aided schools in the state will have to follow the NCERT School Bag Policy, 2020 and ensure that the weight of a school bag does not exceed 10 per cent of the child's body weight. The move is aimed at reducing the physical burden on students."

The weight of the bag needs to be monitored on a regular basis in the school, the minister said. He said the institutions must design suitable timetables to prevent students from carrying unnecessary materials to school.

"The decision has been taken following the instructions of Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary. The NDA Government is taking steps to make the education system in the state more transparent, equitable and accessible, keeping the interest of parents and students in mind.

## Protest against demolition drive turns violent in Kolkata, 3 cops injured

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Kolkata

A protest against the recent bulldozer action in Kolkata's Tiljala turned violent on Sunday as demonstrators hurled stones at police personnel in the minority-dominated Park Circus area, injuring at least three officials and damaging several vehicles.

The flare-up came days after bulldozers rolled into Tiljala as part of the West Bengal Government's demolition drive against alleged illegal constructions following the factory fire that killed two persons earlier this week.

On Sunday afternoon, a large number of people

gathered near Park Circus Seven Point Crossing to protest against the anti-encroachment drive and attempted to block roads, police said.

As police tried to disperse, what they described as an "unlawful assembly", a section of protesters allegedly resorted to stone-pelting, triggering chaos in the area.

Several vehicles parked along the roadside, including those carrying central forces, were vandalised, officials said. Heavy deployment of Kolkata Police and central forces was made in the area after the clashes. Route marches and intensified patrolling were undertaken

in adjoining localities to prevent further escalation and restore normalcy.

Kolkata Police Additional Commissioner Ashesh Biswas said action has already been initiated against those involved in the violence.

"Some people tried to block the road. It was an illegal gathering. The police were trying to disperse them, and there was pelting of stones. Three of our colleagues were injured," Biswas told reporters.

"We have already arrested a few people," he said. The officer said police followed standard operating procedures, and efforts were



underway to identify all those involved in the violence.

"There was an attack on the police. We will see who is behind it and arrest everyone. Strict legal action will

be taken," he added. While the police maintained the agitation was linked to administrative action against illegal buildings, some locals claimed that grievances over

## TTD achieves over 89% green cover in Tirumala

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Tirupati

The TTD has recorded 89.4 per cent forest cover in Tirumala while undertaking extensive measures to conserve forest wealth and restore native species in the Seshachalam Hills.

According to the latest India State of Forest Report (ISFR), nearly 2,431 hectares out of the total 2,719 hectares under Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD) limits are covered with forest vegetation, contributing significantly to biodiversity conservation and climate regulation.

"TTD has achieved 89.4 per cent forest cover in Tirumala while carrying out extensive conservation measures to protect forest wealth and restore native species in the Seshachalam Hills," said an official press release from the temple body on Sunday. TTD has been protecting the rich forest wealth of Seshachalam Hills since 1980, while maintaining ecological balance and catering to the spiritual needs of millions of devotees, it said.

The TTD Forest Department functions under



the supervision of the Deputy Conservator of Forests with four forest ranges, including two in Tirumala and two in Tirupati, headed by Forest Range Officers (FROs).

As part of forest protection measures, flying squads patrol jungle areas around the clock to curb illegal tree felling and poaching activities, while around 26.5 kilometres of fire lines are maintained annually to prevent forest fires.

TTD has also undertaken a drive to plant native species like Peepal, Banyan, Sandalwood, Red Sanders, Mango and Jamun across 576 hectares to replace exotic Acacia plantations.

Special nurseries are being maintained in all four forest ranges to raise native, ornamental and medicinal plant species required for

forest restoration programmes, the release said.

The Seshachalam forests are home to wild creatures like elephants, leopards, bears, and snakes, prompting the department to take special measures to mitigate human-wildlife conflict and rescue injured animals.

The department has set up water pits in forest areas during summer for wild animals and deployed snake rescue teams at the queue line premises to ensure devotees' safety.

Besides forest conservation, the department supplies sandalwood logs, firewood, Darbha grass and other materials required for temple rituals while maintaining gardens, greenery programmes and road dividers in Tirumala and Tirupati.

## Key Myanmar-based trafficker held in NCB crackdown on cross-border drug syndicate

TONY DAS  
■ Guwahati

A key Myanmar-based drug trafficker, who was operating as a major supplier of methamphetamine and heroin from across the border, was arrested by the Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB), an official statement said on Sunday.

The arrest was made in Delhi on Saturday following extensive surveillance, intelligence development, interstate coordination and follow-up operations by the NCB in its sustained crackdown on transnational drug trafficking networks operating along the India-Myanmar border, it said.

The accused, identified as Thancintuang alias Chintuang alias Tluanga, is the second major Myanmar-based drug supplier nabbed by the NCB this year, it added.

Chintuang had emerged as one of the most significant traffickers operating along the Myanmar-Mizoram-Manipur-Assam-Tripura corridor, and has been identified as a major international supplier of methamphetamine and heroin from the neighbouring country, the statement said.

Investigations revealed his extensive involvement in organising cross-border trafficking networks routing narcotic consignments through Mizoram, Manipur, Assam and Tripura into various parts of India and Bangladesh.

He was wanted in multiple cases registered under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act by the NCB and several drug law enforcement agencies.

Chintuang was also accused in two NDPS cases registered by the Mizoram Police in 2025 relating to the suspected trafficking of methamphetamine and heroin. He was additionally found involved in six NDPS cases registered by the Mizoram Excise and Narcotics Department in 2023, linked to heroin trafficking.



THANCINTUANG, ALSO KNOWN AS CHINTUANG, IS ACCUSED OF MANAGING A LARGE NARCOTICS OPERATION ALONG THE INDIA-MYANMAR CORRIDOR, FOCUSING ON METHAMPHETAMINE AND HEROIN

Investigations indicated his involvement in illicit drug trafficking networks valued at approximately ₹115 crore, the NCB statement said.

He is linked to seven NDPS cases connected with the Myanmar-Mizoram-Tripura-Assam corridor, and is also suspected in five other cases associated with the Myanmar-Manipur-Assam axis.

Chintuang was the prime accused in a 2024 NCB Agartala zone case involving the seizure of 14 kg of methamphetamine and 2.8 kg of heroin. He was also the prime accused in another NCB Agartala zone case of 2025 involving the seizure of 49.1 kg of methamphetamine tablets.

During the investigation, several members of the syndicate and close associates of Chintuang were identified and apprehended by NCB, the statement said. Among them, Vungkhanhawna, identified as a close associate and key facilitator, played a major role in coordinating movement and delivery of narcotic consignments linked to the Myanmar-based trafficking network.

He was arrested during

follow-up operations and was also found involved in another NDPS case registered by Mizoram Police.

Another associate, Lalrampari, functioned as a major hawala operator responsible for handling and channelling proceeds generated through illicit drug trafficking activities of the syndicate. She was arrested by the NCB on August 8, 2024.

Investigation revealed hawala transactions amounting to nearly ₹100 crore linked to the network, following which the matter was shared with the Enforcement Directorate (ED).

Properties suspected to have been acquired through proceeds of drug trafficking were also frozen by the authorities.

Further investigation led to the arrest of Abu Saleh alias Saifuddin from Assam's Cachar on November 20, 2025. He was identified as a major Indian operative and logistics coordinator associated with Chintuang's network and was actively involved in the transportation and distribution of narcotic substances across the Assam corridor.

## IMD issues heavy rain alert for Kerala

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Thiruvananthapuram

The IMD on Sunday issued an orange alert in two districts as heavy rain was reported in various parts of Kerala.

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) declared an orange alert for Pathanamthitta and Alappuzha districts, indicating the possibility of very heavy rainfall ranging from 115.6 mm to 204.4 mm in 24 hours at isolated places. A yellow alert has been issued for Thiruvananthapuram, Kollam, Kottayam, Ernakulam, Idukki, Kozhikode, Wayanad, Kannur and Kasargod, warning of heavy rainfall between 64.5 mm and 115.5 mm.



On May 18, a yellow alert has been sounded in Pathanamthitta, Alappuzha, Kottayam, Idukki, Ernakulam, Thrissur, Palakkad and Malappuram districts, while on May 19 it will be in force in Malappuram, Kozhikode, Wayanad, Kannur and Kasargod.

The Kerala State Disaster Management Authority (KSDMA), in a statement, urged people living in landslide- and flood-prone areas to remain vigilant and move to safer locations as per official instructions.

Residents along riverbanks and downstream areas of dams have also been advised to exercise caution and relocate if necessary.



Marshall Islands-flagged tanker, 'Symi', carrying around 20,000 tonnes of LPG arrives at Kandla Port in Gujarat's Kachchh district



Editor's  
TAKE

## Trump in Beijing: A pragmatic pause

The Xi-Trump summit stabilised a fragile relation, revived channels of dialogue, and rekindled the hope that the two nations could manage tensions

The visit of US President Donald Trump to China was closely watched by the world. The three-day visit during which Trump met Xi Jinping was laden with symbolism and expectations but ended with piecemeal declarations and no breakthroughs in bilateral relations or convergence on the major geopolitical issues confronting the world. The Trump visit at least reassured the world that the dialogue was still possible and that both nations had shown diplomatic courtesy to hear each other's viewpoint.

In recent times, the US-China relations have deteriorated sharply over trade disputes, Taiwan, and competing geopolitical ambitions. The Trump-Xi meeting was less about dramatic breakthroughs and more about restoring the diplomatic channels open at the highest level, should a need arise. The immediate outcome of the summit was the strengthening of the fragile trade truce reached earlier.

The agreement to maintain lower tariffs and continue easing restrictions on critical sectors such as rare earth exports suggests that both sides are interdependent. Yet another major takeaway from the meeting was Trump's invitation to Xi for another summit in the United States later this year, which indicates that both countries value continuous dialogue. This is a good sign, as the flash points in the world are many, and the world sits on a nuclear pile. But beneath diplomacy was economic brinkmanship at work. Trump announced that China would purchase Boeing aircraft. This could be both an economic and a political glue. The presence of major American business leaders—including executives from Boeing, Nvidia, Apple, and Tesla—shows that despite political rivalry, economic interdependence between the two powers remains intact. Yet the summit's significance extended beyond commerce. Xi Jinping's warning that mishandling Taiwan could place bilateral relations in "great jeopardy" reaffirmed Beijing's hegemony in the South China Sea. Trump avoided public escalation on the issue during the visit. This restraint itself was meaningful.

Both leaders appeared to realise that their tensions could destabilise not just Asia but the world order. The discussions on Iran were equally revealing. Trump claimed that China would assist diplomatic efforts and expand energy cooperation with the United States. In a world order that is volatile and fragmented, even limited cooperation between the two powers carries global importance. Perhaps the most important takeaway from the visit is the emergence of what Beijing described as a framework of "strategic stability."

Trump's visit is a recognition that there are limits to how much you can afford to ignore China, and complete disengagement with the dragon is neither realistic nor desirable. The message to the world is therefore both reassuring and cautionary. While the structural tensions over technology, military influence, trade dominance, and Taiwan remain unresolved, the diplomatic channels are still open. The Trump-Xi summit was not a breakthrough in the diplomatic sense but an assurance that there is hope after all and that both powerful nations are willing to manage their rivalries with dialogue.

# Cannes 2026 and the Future of Cinema

As AI and platform-driven storytelling reshape the moving image, Cannes 2026 stands at the crossroads between nostalgia and reinvention. The festival is no longer merely defending cinema's past grandeur; it is negotiating cinema's future



CHAITANYA K  
PRASAD

Every year, Cannes arrives dressed like a spectacle but behaves like a question. It has the red carpets, the cameras, the yachts, the gowns, the carefully practised indifference of people who know they are being watched. But beneath all that choreography, Cannes is rarely just about glamour. At its best, it is where cinema pauses, looks at itself in the mirror, and asks: What are we becoming?

In 2026, that question feels sharper than usual. This year's Cannes does not feel like a festival trying to prove that cinema is still powerful. It feels like a festival trying to understand what power even means when the moving image has escaped the theatre, slipped into phones, fractured into reels, entered virtual worlds, and now stands face to face with artificial intelligence. The old grammar of cinema is still present: directors, juries, premieres, applause, but something in the air feels unsettled. Not broken, just restless.

And that restlessness may be the most exciting thing about Cannes 2026. For a long time, Cannes has carried the aura of certainty. It knew what counted as cinema. It knew who the masters were. It knew what kind of film deserved silence, reverence and a ten-minute standing ovation. But this year feels less certain, and therefore more alive. The absence of obvious, overpowering studio giants has created a strange freedom. The festival seems less dominated by cinematic empires and more open to the stubborn, fragile, risky films that still believe in the intelligence of an audience. That matters.

Because cinema, especially now, is under pressure to become everything except cinema. It is expected to be content, campaign, franchise, algorithm, intellectual property, meme, marketable asset and global product. Cannes 2026 feels like a resistance to that flattening. Not a rejection of the future, but a refusal to let the future be decided only by platforms, data and speed. What is fresh this year is not merely the presence of new technology. It is the discomfort around it.

Artificial intelligence is no longer sitting politely outside the gates of cinema. It is here, close enough to provoke anxiety, curiosity and negotiation. The interesting thing is that Cannes is not treating this as a simple villain story. It is not saying technology will destroy art, nor is it blindly celebrating every innovation as progress. Instead, the festival seems to be staging a more difficult conversation: can cinema absorb new tools without surrendering its soul? That is the real



drama of Cannes 2026.

The future of cinema may not be a clean battle between humans and machines. It may be messier, stranger and more intimate. AI may write, restore, enhance, simulate, predict, recreate and disturb. Immersive formats may alter the way we experience a story. Virtual production may change where films are made and who gets access to scale. But the heart of cinema will still depend on something that cannot be automated so easily: a human being trying to make sense of another human being.

For India, Cannes 2026 is interesting in a quieter but deeper way. India's presence this year is not only about visibility. It is about memory.

It is about returning to the world not merely with stars and spectacle, but with cinema that carries history, politics, language and regional truth. The restoration of the 1986 Malayalam classic, Amma Ariyan, by John Abraham, is one of the most meaningful Indian moments at Cannes this year precisely because it does not chase the obvious idea of glamour.

It brings another India to the Croisette. It brings the India of people's cinema, political cinema, regional cinema, cinema made with urgency rather than polish. Amma Ariyan returning in restored form is not just an archival achievement. It is a reminder that Indian cinema has always had underground rivers running beneath its mainstream ocean. And perhaps the world is only now learning how vast those rivers are. This is what India must understand about Cannes: participation cannot be measured only in how many famous faces walked the carpet. That is the least interesting metric. Indian cinema is not one thing. It is not Bollywood alone. It is Malayalam, Bengali, Tamil, Marathi, Assamese, Manipuri, Kannada, Telugu, Punjabi, Hindi, independent, commercial, documentary, experimental, devotional, angry, absurd, intimate and epic. It is a civilisation arguing with itself through images.

When India arrives at Cannes through a restored Malayalam classic, it sends a subtle but

CANNES ITSELF  
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The author is a  
Commentator and Writer on  
Cinema, Branding, Media  
Management and Geo-  
Strategic Communication.  
Inputs by Zoya Ahmad and  
Vaishnavie Srinivasan

dailypioneer

@Chatty111Prasad

The Pioneer

## Hypertension: India's biggest public health emergency



MANOJ VASANT  
MURHEKAR



P GANESH  
KUMAR

### 2ND OPINION

We have the drugs. We have the programme. We have the proof. What India lacks is the political will to measure hypertension properly, manage it consistently, and make control of blood pressure a public health priority. Imagine a disease that kills more Indians every year than tuberculosis, HIV and malaria combined. A disease whose treatment can cost less than a cup of chai each month. A disease for which medicines are already available free in government hospitals. Yet only a fraction of those living with it have it under control. That disease is hypertension. India is home to nearly 220 million people with high blood pressure. Cardiovascular diseases - heart attacks, strokes, and related conditions - already claim more than 2.5 million Indian lives every year, and hypertension is their

single biggest driver. The tragedy is not that we do not know how to prevent these deaths. It is that we are failing to do what is already proven to work. Unlike cancer or many chronic illnesses, hypertension is neither complicated nor expensive to manage. A simple, off-patent medicine such as amlodipine, available for as little as one rupee a day, can control blood pressure in the majority of patients. Studies show that improving hypertension treatment and adherence rates would not only save lives but also reduce long-term healthcare costs by preventing expensive hospitalisations for heart attacks, strokes, and kidney disease. Globally, improving blood pressure control is considered one of the most powerful adult health interventions available today. Reaching even 50% population-level control could prevent millions of deaths and cardiovascular events over the coming decades. For India, the gains could be transformative. The India Hypertension Control Initiative (IHCI), launched in 2018, has already demonstrated that large-scale blood pressure control is possible through public health systems. Expanding from 26 districts to more than 150 districts across 26 states, the programme has shown that decentralised, protocol-driven care can significantly improve outcomes. The most important lesson from IHCI is simple: hypertension control works best when care is

taken closer to people's homes. Health and Wellness Centres, or Ayushman Arogya Mandirs, improved blood pressure control rates while reducing missed follow-up visits. What India needs now is not another pilot project but a national commitment built around a few non-negotiable principles. First, every state must adopt a simple, standardised treatment protocol. Clear protocols help health workers escalate treatment quickly and consistently. Second, uninterrupted drug supply is essential. Drug stockouts break trust, interrupt adherence, and directly increase the risk of heart attacks and strokes. Third, every health facility must have validated blood pressure machines and properly trained staff. Fourth, India must embrace task-sharing. Doctors alone cannot manage 220 million patients. Nurses, pharmacists, health workers, and frontline staff must all share responsibility for screening, follow-up, counselling, and medicine refills. Finally, India needs a simple digital monitoring system that measures what matters: blood pressure control rates. Every preventable death from uncontrolled blood pressure is ultimately a failure not of medicine, but of governance.

Dr Manoj Vasant Murhekar is Director and Dr. P. Ganeshkumar is Scientist & Head, Division of Noncommunicable Diseases ICMR National Institute of Epidemiology

The Pioneer  
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### DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



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### DIPLOMACY MUST PREVAIL OVER ESCALATION

Iran's warning that it is prepared to resume direct military confrontation with the United States if negotiations collapse is deeply concerning. The continuing tensions over the Strait of Hormuz are not merely a regional issue but a global economic threat. Nearly one-fifth of the world's oil and gas supplies pass through this narrow corridor, and any prolonged disruption could trigger inflation, higher fuel prices and financial instability across the world.Iranian Foreign Minister Seyed Abbas Araghchi has pointed out that even ordinary Americans are already facing the economic fallout through rising borrowing costs, mortgage pressures and increasing loan defaults. The warning highlights how modern conflicts no longer remain confined to battlefields; they

rapidly spill into economies and households worldwide.At the same time, Tehran's insistence that any agreement must recognise its sovereignty concerns shows how difficult the negotiations remain. The failure of talks in Islamabad and the subsequent hardening of rhetoric on both sides underline the fragile state of diplomacy.Yet, amid all this, there remains a narrow opening for peace. Reports of possible mediation efforts by Beijing following discussions between Donald Trump and Xi Jinping offer some hope. The world cannot afford another prolonged conflict in West Asia. Diplomacy, compromise and restraint must prevail before economic uncertainty turns into a wider global crisis.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

Please send your letter to the [info@dailypioneer.com](mailto:info@dailypioneer.com).  
In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

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AG RAJMOHAN | ANANTAPUR

AVINASH GODBOLEY, DEWAS

## LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

### Reform entrance exams holistically

The recent scam involving the NEET examination has severely damaged public confidence in India's medical and engineering entrance systems. While strict punishment for those involved is necessary, it cannot compensate for the emotional distress and lost opportunities suffered by lakhs of sincere students.The issue goes beyond isolated malpractice. It exposes deeper flaws in an education system dominated by rote learning, coaching centres and "mug-and-jug" preparation methods that reduce learning to memorisation. The growing involvement of coaching institutions in such scandals further questions the fairness and credibility of the present selection process. Merely shifting to computer-based testing is not enough. Greater weightage should be given to Class 10 and 12 board examination performance in science and mathematics subjects, along with achievements in Olympiads and National Talent Search examinations. Such measures would reward consistent academic excellence rather than performance in a single high-pressure test.India needs an admission system that values genuine talent, integrity and holistic learning. Without meaningful reforms, recurring scams will continue to undermine both merit and public trust.

### Population control needs long-term solutions

The Andhra Pradesh government's decision to offer financial incentives for larger families reflects growing concern over the declining Total Fertility Rate in southern states. With fertility rates falling below replacement levels and the elderly population steadily increasing, the issue certainly deserves serious attention and long-term planning. However, monetary incentives alone are unlikely to reverse the trend. Many educated couples delay marriage until they achieve financial and professional stability. Even after marriage, couples often postpone parenthood due to career pressures, rising living costs and uncertainty about the future. Today, raising children involves enormous expenses related to education, healthcare and housing. For middle-class and lower-income families, ensuring a secure future for even one child has become increasingly difficult. In such circumstances, incentives of ₹30,000 or ₹40,000 appear more symbolic than transformative. Unless governments address employment generation, affordable education, healthcare and social security, population policies based merely on incentives are unlikely to succeed. Governments must create conditions where families feel economically secure and socially confident enough to raise more children willingly.

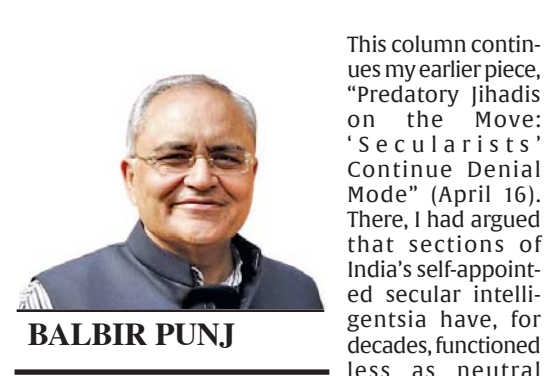
### Austerity must begin at the top

Frugality and austerity have become fashionable slogans after the Prime Minister's recent appeal for restraint in the use of resources. India has never been a nation blessed with unlimited resources, and ordinary citizens have always been compelled by modest incomes to live carefully and economically. If austerity is truly the need of the hour, it must begin with those in power. The public deserves answers about oversized ministerial convoys, excessive security entourages, costly official vehicles and frequent foreign visits undertaken over the years. It appears ironic that the burden of sacrifice is now being placed primarily upon citizens already struggling with rising fuel prices, cooking gas costs and inflation. Genuine austerity should first be visible in political conduct before being preached to the public. Endless speeches, political rhetoric and repetitive attacks on opponents consume precious hours while contributing little to governance. Public life demands efficiency, restraint and seriousness. Citizens will willingly embrace austerity when they see the same discipline practised sincerely by those who govern them.

# Why Conversion Cases Like TCS Nashik Persist?

# Why education must teach systems thinking

This unfinished draft was prepared by late Balbir Punj a day before his passing on April 18. A month has now passed since his demise. In light of the recent arrest of Nida Khan in the alleged conversion case, which has once again brought the Nashik TCS matter into focus, the draft acquires renewed relevance



This column continues my earlier piece, “Predatory Jihad on the Move: ‘Secularists’ Continue Denial Mode” (April 16). There, I had argued that sections of India’s self-appointed secular intelligentsia have, for decades, functioned less as neutral guardians of constitutionalism and more as apologists for organised religious conversion networks, coercive mobilisation, and ideological radicalism. The Nashik TCS sexual exploitation and conversion controversy has once again exposed that uncomfortable reality.

The reactions to my previous article, both in private correspondence and on social media, only strengthened my conviction that a large section of our society instinctively recognises the pattern. Yet an entrenched ecosystem continues to minimise, rationalise, or suppress any scrutiny of conversion-linked networks. The issue, therefore, is not whether such tendencies exist, but how they continue to operate so effectively within contemporary India while retaining moral legitimacy in elite discourse.

The broader subcontinental experience offers important context. Wherever exclusivist Islamist politics has acquired overwhelming social or political dominance, pluralism has steadily weakened. Pre-Islamic cultures, minority traditions, and indigenous civilisational memories have either been marginalised or erased. In such societies, ideological assertion is open and unapologetic; there is little requirement for the language of secular camouflage. The demographic contrast across the subcontinent remains striking. At the time of Partition, Muslims in residual India constituted under ten per cent of the population; today the figure stands near fifteen per cent. Meanwhile, non-Muslim minorities—Hindus, Sikhs, Buddhists—in neighbouring Islamic states have witnessed severe decline. In Pakistan, Hindus-Sikhs together accounted for nearly fifteen per cent of the population at independence; today they are reduced to a negligible minority. In Bangladesh, the Hindu-Buddhist population has steadily contracted over the decades. These are not merely statistical developments. They are indicators of bigger civilisational change.

Lahore offers a poignant illustration. Traditionally associated with Lav, the son of Lord Rama, the city once represented a vibrant confluence of Hindu, Sikh, and Jain heritage. Syed Muhammad Latif’s nineteenth-century work ‘Lahore’ documents numerous temples and shrines that once flourished there. During my visit to Pakistan in 2003, I searched for remnants of that civilisational landscape. What survived was largely neglect, silence, and decay. Even the ancient Lav Temple within Lahore Fort appeared abandoned to memory rather than preserved as heritage.

Afghanistan presents an even harsher lesson. Once a flourishing centre of Hindu-Buddhist learning and later sanctified by the travels of Guru Nanak, it housed thriving Hindu-Sikh communities until the late twentieth century. Decades of extremism, sectarian violence, and Taliban rule virtually extinguished that presence. Civilisations do not disappear overnight; they erode gradually when ideological intolerance acquires institutional sanction. Kashmir remains India’s most painful internal example. The land of Rishi Kashyap, once renowned for Shaivite-Buddhist scholarship, underwent profound transformation after the fourteenth century.

Kalhana’s Rajatarangini portrays a society rooted in intellectual plurality, yet subsequent centuries of Islamisation steadily altered its demographic and cultural character. Under Hindu Dogra rule (1846-1947), pluralism witnessed a brief revival. However, during the twentieth century, under the communal politics of Sheikh Abdullah, the irony was that forces of Islamist consolidation grew steadily stronger in the name of secularism, even as the marginalisation of Kashmiri Pandits deepened. By the late 1980s and early 1990s, the fragility of that coexistence stood brutally exposed through the mass exodus of Kashmiri Pandits. Amid terror, targeted killings, and an atmosphere of fear, hundreds of thousands of Pandits were forced to become refugees within their own country. For many Muslims of the subcontinent during the tumultuous years of Partition, religious allegiance often appeared to supersede territorial nationalism. In this



context, the observations recorded by Dr. Karan Singh in his autobiography ‘Heir Apparent’ assume considerable significance. Recalling the Pakistan-backed invasion of Jammu and Kashmir in October 1947, he noted that a substantial section of Muslim personnel within the State Forces, influenced by religious affinity, gradually drifted away from loyalty to the Maharaja and awaited an opportunity to defect. His observations reflected the tragic communal contagion unleashed by Partition across the subcontinent.

India, however, differs fundamentally from its neighbours because its timeless civilisational plural ethos, the constitutional structure still imposes restraints upon overt sectarianism. Consequently, coercive mobilisation often assumes subtler forms. In Islamic Pakistan, reports of abductions and forced conversions of Hindu-Christian-Sikh girls’ surface regularly. Such acts cannot be institutionalised so openly in residual India. Instead, allegations increasingly centre on covert grooming, emotional manipulation, conversion-linked pressure and ‘Love-Jihad’. The recent controversy surrounding the world’s second-largest IT services brand TCS unit in Nashik has been cited as one such instance. Recent years have also witnessed repeated clashes during Hindu religious processions, particularly during Ram Navami and Hanuman Jayanti celebrations. Earlier this year, Hindu youth Tarun Kumar was allegedly lynched in Delhi’s Uttam Nagar following a dispute during Holi festivities. Such incidents deepen public anxiety and widen the distance between elite commentary and lived social experience. Judicial interventions have occasionally attempted to restore balance.

In 2021, the Madras High Court rejected arguments seeking to prevent Hindu processions through Muslim-majority localities, warning that such reasoning would damage the secular fabric of the nation and encourage fragmentation. Yet this is scarcely a recent phenomenon. More than seven decades ago, Dr. B. R. Ambedkar, in his seminal work ‘Pakistan or the Partition of India’, identified three recurring flashpoints underlying Hindu-Muslim tensions: cow slaughter, music before mosques, and religious conversions. At this juncture, an important distinction must be maintained: the actions of individuals or groups cannot and should not be attributed to an entire community.

When Hindu godman Asaram Babu was convicted, there was no nationwide mobilisation seeking immunity from the law. In contrast, Sections of the Islamist have rushed to defend the accused, while conspicuous silence has prevailed across significant sections of the Muslim community. That asymmetry inevitably raises difficult questions. This phenomenon is not confined to India alone. Following the October 2023 attacks by Hamas on Israel, disturbing visuals emerged from Gaza showing crowds celebrating the violence and the taking of hostages. Such scenes, irrespective of geopolitical context, compel a deeper examination of societal attitudes. India’s strength has always rested in civilisational pluralism. But it cannot survive upon biased silence or moral asymmetry. It requires reciprocity, honesty, and the courage to confront coercion regardless of its source.

The lesson for India is neither intolerance nor triumphalism. A confident civilisation neither persecutes minorities nor abandons historical memory. Democracies endure only when laws function without selective outrage and when intellectual honesty prevails over ideological convenience. India’s plural character survived through centuries because of its Hindu civilisational ethos, which is inherently secular, democratic, and inclusive—rooted not merely in constitutional mandate, but in a deeper cultural consciousness. If that equilibrium is weakened by denial, evasiveness, or protected radicalism, the damage will not remain confined to any one community alone; it will gradually erode the very foundations of national cohesion and stability.

Swami Vivekananda was prophetic. Speaking to ‘Prabuddha Bharata’ in April 1899, he warned: “Every man going out of the Hindu pale is not only a man less, but an enemy more.” His words a reminder that a civilisation incapable of preserving confidence in its own cultural foundations ultimately weakens the very pluralism it seeks to defend.

The writer was an eminent columnist, former Chairman of the Indian Institute of Mass Communication (IIMC). This article was shared by his daughter Shweta Punj

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 The Pioneer



For over a century, modern education has been organised around disciplines. Knowledge has been divided into subjects, departments, and specialisations, each with its own methods, vocabulary, and carefully guarded boundaries. This structure served an important purpose. It enabled depth, rigour, and the steady advancement of knowledge within well-defined domains. But the world for which this model was designed no longer exists.

The defining challenges of our time do not arrive neatly packaged within disciplinary boundaries. They emerge at intersections; messy, fast-moving, and consequential. Climate change is simultaneously a scientific, economic, and political problem. Artificial intelligence is as much about ethics and labour markets as it is about computation. Global supply chains are shaped as much by geopolitical calculation as by engineering efficiency. The student trained exclusively within a single discipline is, increasingly, unprepared for the reality they will inherit.

**The Synthesis Problem**

Our curricula continue to rest on a quiet assumption: that if students are trained deeply in individual disciplines, they will somehow synthesise this knowledge when required. This assumption is no longer tenable. Synthesis is not an automatic outcome of exposure. It is a learned capability; one that requires deliberate cultivation, structured practice, and explicit instruction. What is missing in most educational systems is not more content. It is a different foundation: ways of thinking that enable individuals to operate in a world of deeply interconnected systems.

**Geopolitical Systems Thinking as a Foundational Capability**

Consider helium. Its role in semiconductor manufacturing is technical and largely invisible to the public; it is used to cool equipment and maintain clean manufacturing environments. Yet, helium supply is tied to natural gas extraction, concentrated in a handful of geographies including the United States, Qatar, and Russia. A conflict affecting energy markets can constrain helium availability, which in turn affects semiconductor fabrication yields, slows the development of advanced chips, and cascades into the broader computational and AI ecosystem. India’s semiconductor ambitions make this chain directly relevant.

The government’s India Semiconductor Mission, backed by a production-linked incentive package, is a significant industrial policy bet. But the success of that bet depends not only on engineering capability and capital investment. It depends on securing access to gases, chemicals, and equipment that are themselves embedded within complex geopolitical dependencies; many of them involving China, the dominant processor of rare earth elements critical to electronics manufacturing.

To understand these chains is not to accumulate facts across physics, engineering, and international relations. It is to apply a way of thinking; one that connects resource flows, technological systems, and structures of political power into a coherent whole. This is what the discipline of geopolitical systems thinking offers, and what current curricula do not systematically develop.

**What Must Change**

The implications for curriculum design are consequential. First, ways of thinking must be treated as foundational, not incidental. Geopolitical systems thinking: the ability to trace interdependencies across domains, recognise how disruptions propagate through interconnected systems, and anticipate second-order effects should be explicitly taught, practised, and assessed. It cannot be left to emerge organically from interdisciplinary exposure. It must be built in. Second, this kind of thinking must be embedded across disciplines, not cordoned off in standalone electives. Engineering programmes should incorporate geopolitical risk into supply chain and materials curricula. Business schools should situate strategy within the realities of trade regimes, sanctions, and resource dependencies. Policy programmes must integrate technological and scientific literacy as core competencies, not optional supplements.

India’s National Education Policy 2020 gestures in this direction, calling for multidisciplinary learning and flexibility across streams. That instinct is correct. But multidisciplinary alone, simply combining subjects, does not automatically produce the integrative thinking the moment demands. The goal is not breadth for its own sake. It is the deliberate development of cognitive tools that help students situate their knowledge within larger systems of power, resource, and consequence.

Third, pedagogy must shift decisively towards case-based and problem-driven learning. Students should be required to map connections, trace cascading effects, and reason under conditions of genuine uncertainty; not as an enrichment exercise, but as a core mode of instruction. India’s own experience: the API crisis, the fertiliser shock, the semiconductor dependency question, the evolving geometry of the Indo-Pacific, provides a rich and underutilised set of cases for exactly this kind of teaching.

The twentieth century privileged increasing specialization, rewarding those who developed deep expertise within narrowly defined domains. The emerging century, by contrast, places greater value on the capacity to integrate knowledge, interpret complexity, and act across disciplinary boundaries. If education is to remain responsive to contemporary challenges, its foundational assumptions must evolve accordingly. The curriculum of the future will be shaped not only by the content it delivers, but more fundamentally by the modes of thinking it cultivates.



# From ‘Make in India’ to ‘Make in India Brand’: Reimagining rural manufacturing



power combined with smart governance models. Make in India Mantra gets a new transformation and shape to “Make in India Brand” to be launched by Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT), Government of India. Make in India Brand will set a benchmark for large manufacturing industries, MSME, Startups and academia as well. Make in India Brand will be set the tone for enormous assurance to quality and packaging. This will in turn creates value addition for Swadeshi and Vocal for Local innovation led product development and deployment across India and globe.

Under the Make in India Brand, a brand new unique and interesting manufacturing products ranging from automotive, steel, agriculture, healthcare, and many more are identified and well recognized. The main objective is to enhance scalability, stability and reach widely

to the last mile across local and global international markets. This will boost our nation’s manufacturing mission leading to steer our nation’s economy and thereby achieve the visionary path of Viksit Bharat@2047.

India has been identifying its strength through establishing a robust manufacturing ecosystem in rural locations across PAN India. This will accelerate rural employment and push women self help groups. Government of India’s pioneering Rural Prosperity and Rural Resilience program [RPRP] will increase resilience and active participation and collaboration of larger, small, and medium enterprise, industry associations, academia, research laboratories like CSIR, DRDO and global players in rural location thereby achieve enhanced research and development and rural productivity combined with sustainability. This will lead to rural economic stability as well.

Rural Prosperity and Rural Resilience programs change the mindset of our nation and thereby transform the lives of rural communities. In addition to the above RPRP will pave the way for the livelihood security, development of Village level rural infrastructures, creating a balance in human harmony enrooting to local economic growth in India. This program will make India to achieve a landmark milestone in the historic rural development. RPRP will also increase the value of artisans

and small-scale farmers. It will also push the rural technologies and supply chain and demand for the Swadeshi product. Swadeshi rural products produced in villages also will make a



vibrant entry in MSMEs pioneering Government e Market place [GeM] and Open Network for Digital Commerce [ONDC].

India is rapidly working to identify one hundred Unique products which are not either manufactured or produced in ample quantity. These products will be rejuvenated and marketed under Make in India Branch name across local and global value chains.

## Successful Case Study

**Rural Prosperity and Rural Resilience program: ZOHO Corporation, Tenkasi, Tamil Nadu** — ZOHO, a pioneering IT giant has established its hub in Tenkasi, Tamil Nadu is the first to change

the rural dynamics of our nation by developing IT solutions, ZOHO desk in rural village. This has changed the traditional old urbanization to rural talent hub. It focuses on hub-spoke models thereby creating nerve IT centres nearby locations. This is the first industry in India to contribute for community-based employment. increase the scientific innovation and research and development Training school has also started thereby training and nurture youth, making them capable for market ready employment in ZOHO and allied industries. ZOHO is the testament for rural development leading to achieve labor productivity in terms enhancing the livelihood, employment, skill development for youth and self-help groups.

ZOHO is the best proven example in India for the development modern rural infrastructures, youth employment, harnessing the potential of natural resources leading to improve the rural economy of our nation. ZOHO is the classical example for RPRP of Government of India and adds enormous rural productivity leading to prosperity of our nation.

**IEEE Smart Village (ISV):** Community driven empowerment of climate change resilience

IEEE Smart Village (ISV), a philanthropic program facilitated by IEEE Philanthropic division, launched its first historic rural project in June 2025 in Ernakulam district of Kerala. It has established a resilient rural hub called a Climate-Resilient Enterprise (CRE) Hub. The objective of the hub is to promote and empower self-help women group leading to build and run by com-

munity-based rural women enterprises.

The hub successfully supports and partners with twenty-five local MSMEs. This is principally a technology driven program which constitutes creating a solar-power dryer and cold storage for fisheries, agriculture, dairy products, and various livestock. In addition to the above, this program supports frugal innovation driven solar powered EV vehicles which are created to reduce the carbon footprints and promote clean energy and green mobility transportation.

India’s community driven program like Unnat Bharat Abhiyan, RuTAG (Rural Technology Action Group) and My Bharat being Government of India initiatives of Ministry of Education and IIT Delhi,

Office of Principal Scientific Advisor to Government of India and Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports respectively, emerge as driving force for technological innovation, scientific and interdisciplinary research. This will form as fulcrum to accelerate the local rural manufacturing in collaboration with industries especially the Indian MSMEs.

Rural Prosperity and Rural Resilience program will create modern and model villages across PAN India. It will also build harmony across our people and nation. RPRP will form a smart roadmap for Viksit Bharat@2047.

Head Institute Industry Interface Program Hindustan College of Science and Technology, Mathura

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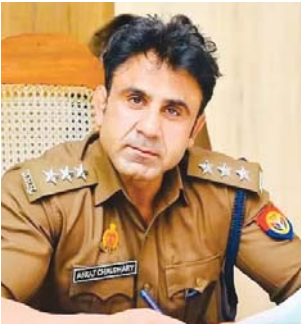
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## Order Order

### Sambhal violence: Police officer cross-examined

Former Sambhal Circle Officer Anuj Chaudhary on Saturday told a court here that the police did not open fire during the violent protests against the survey of the Shahi Jama Masjid in November 2024, an advocate said. Chaudhary, now posted as an Additional Superintendent of Police, was cross-examined through video conferencing before District Judge Vidushi Singh in Chandausi in connection with the killing of a person, identified as Bilal, during the November 24, 2024, violence. In 2024, a local court had ordered a survey of the Shahi Jama Masjid on a suit by a Hindu devotee alleging that it was built at the site of an ancient Harihar temple. During the second round of the survey, a group of people who were opposing the survey turned violent and clashed with security personnel which led to the death of four people and injuries to dozens. Twelve FIRs were registered in connection with the violence.



### Navi Mumbai court acquits two in 2018 murder case

A court in Navi Mumbai has acquitted two persons accused of beating a man to death in 2018, citing a lack of forensic evidence linking the duo to the crime and an unexplained delay in registering the first information report (FIR). Additional Sessions Judge Makarand R Mandawgade of the Belapur court on Friday, acquitted Mohammad Akram Tajajul Khan (56) and Akbar Ali Najjar alias Iqbal Gulam Mohammad Najjar (38) of charges under section 302 (murder) of the Indian Penal Code (IPC). The prosecution had alleged that on the morning of October 30, 2018, an altercation broke out at the Green Park slum in APMC, Vashi, after the victim, Saeed Mansuri, picked up a wooden table belonging to Khan. The dispute escalated into a scuffle, during which Khan and Najjar allegedly assaulted Mansuri with sticks, inflicting fatal head injuries that led to his death.



## Court sentences Azam Khan to 2 years in MCC violation case

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Rampur

A court in this Uttar Pradesh district sentenced Samajwadi Party (SP) leader Azam Khan to two years of imprisonment on Saturday in a case related to objectionable remarks made against government officials during the 2019 Lok Sabha poll campaign.

The court also imposed a fine on Khan, who appeared before it through video-conferencing from the Rampur jail, where he is currently lodged in connection with another case, prosecution officials said.

The case pertains to a speech delivered by Khan during an election rally in the Mankara area within the Bhot police station limits in 2019, when he was contesting the polls from the Rampur Lok



Sabha seat as the candidate of the SP-BSP-RLD alliance.

According to the prosecution, Khan made objectionable remarks against government officials, including the then district magistrate of Rampur, Anjaneya Kumar Singh, from the public meeting. The speech was later circulated on social media



## SC to hear pleas on wages of priests, temple staff

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court is scheduled to hear on Monday a plea to constitute a judicial commission or an expert committee to review the wages and other benefits given to priests, 'sevadars' and temple staff in state-controlled temples.

A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta is likely to hear the PIL filed by advocate Ashwini Upadhyay. The plea, filed through advocate Ashwani Dubey, seeks directions to the Centre and states to constitute a judicial commission or an expert committee to review the remuneration and other benefits given

to the priests and temple staff in state-controlled temples.

"Petitioner also seeks a declaration that priests and temple staff are employee' under Section 2(k) of the Code on Wages, 2019. Petitioner submits that once the State assumes the administrative, economic and financial control over temples, an employer-employee relationship arises and denial of dignified wages to priests and temple staff violates the right to livelihood guaranteed under Article 21," it said.

Upadhyay said the cause of action accrued on April 4, when he went to Varanasi to attend a public programme and after performing 'Rudrabhishek' in the Kashi Vishwanath temple, which is



controlled by the state, he came to know that even the minimum wages to live with dignity are not given to the priests and temple staff. "Recently, in Andhra

Pradesh and Telangana, priests and temple staff organised a large-scale protest demanding the minimum wages. Priests and temple staff are not getting even the minimum



Supreme Court Justice Manmohan delivering Dr HR Bhardwaj Memorial lecture on the topic – The emergence of AI and it's implications for Justice delivery and legal systems New Delhi on Sunday

PIONEER PHOTO

## Financial advisor gets 2-year RI, fined in breach of trust case

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Thane

A Thane court has sentenced a financial advisor to two years rigorous imprisonment in a case of criminal breach of trust filed by a woman and imposed a fine of Rs 30 lakh on him.

Special court judge G T Pawar, however, cleared the accused, Mateshwar Rajpat Giri, of charges of cheating under the IPC, as well as stringent provisions of the Banning of Unregulated Deposit Schemes (BUDS) Act, noting the legislation came into effect after the offence occurred.

The court, in the judgment passed on Saturday, ordered that the entire fine amount of ₹30 lakh, once recovered, be paid as compensation to the woman, a resident of Thane in Maharashtra.

According to the prosecution, the woman, who lost her husband and



brother in a road accident, had invested her entire compensation money and proceeds of Rs 51.5 lakh from selling a commercial shop with Giri between July 2017 and April 2018.

Giri, who operated a firm at Bandra in Mumbai, had promised her an average annual return of 12 per cent through mutual funds.

He paid regular dividends till January 2021, but stopped thereafter and failed

to return the principal amount, eventually defaulting on the remaining balance of ₹ 32.46 lakh, as per the prosecution.

Following a court order during the bail process, Giri deposited ₹13.86 lakh, leaving an outstanding default of ₹18.6 lakh. While evaluating the intersection of cheating and criminal breach of trust charges under the Indian Penal Code, Judge Pawar observed that in order to prove the offence under IPC Section 420 (cheating), it must be established that since inception, the accused had a dishonest intention.

"But in the present case, in the evidence of the prosecution witness, it has come on record that initially, i.e. from 2017 to 2020, the accused paid dividend to her which shows that there was no dishonest intention of the accused since inception," he said.

wage prescribed by the State for unskilled and semi-skilled workers. This is a systemic exploitation. State is acting as a model employer through the endowments department, but violating the minimum wages Act and the directive principles of state policy (Article 43)," it said.

The plea further said the continued refusal to meet the minimum wages with the 2026 inflation-adjusted cost of living index has forced the petitioner to seek judicial intervention to prevent the further marginalisation of priests and temple staff.

Upadhyay further said the precarious nature of livelihood was starkly exposed on February 7, 2025, when a Tamil

Nadu department issued a circular at the 'Dandayuthapani Swami Temple' in Madurai, strictly prohibiting priests from accepting 'dakshina' in 'aarti plates'.

"It is necessary to state that priests in such temples often receive no formal salary from the State and rely entirely on 'Dakshina'; the State's administrative order directly threatened them with starvation. Although withdrawn due to public outrage, the incident highlights the State's arbitrary power over the survival of the priests. This is also a bitter truth that States are controlling lakhs of temples but not a single mosque or church," the PIL claimed.

## SBI told to pay ₹5 lakh to woman despite 6-yr delay

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Mumbai

A Nagpur consumer commission has ordered SBI to pay ₹5 lakh to a widow despite a six-year delay in filing the insurance claim, saying "mental shock" following a spouse's sudden death is natural and it takes time to recover from the grief.

A bank cannot use the 90-day claim window as a shield when it fails to inform customers of their rights, said a verdict delivered last month by the District Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission (Additional DCF) in Maharashtra's Nagpur.

Labelling its refusal as a "deficiency in service and unjust," the commission ordered the State Bank of India (SBI) to pay the ₹5 lakh insurance amount with six per cent annual interest from the date the complaint was filed (September 5, 2019).

The commission emphasised that if a bank claims insurance protection is not applicable to a particular card, it must clearly provide the conditions and supporting documentation. In this case, since other cardholders received insurance coverage

without any fees, treating customers differently under similar circumstances was deemed unfair and amounted to a "deficiency in service", it said.

The bank was also ordered to pay ₹10,000 for mental agony and litigation costs.

As per the complainant, her husband had an account with the bank's Tri Junction Cantonment area in Nagpur. She stated that insurance protection up to ₹5 lakh was being provided to the relevant debit cardholders of the bank.

However, no information about this was given by the opposite party (bank) to her or her husband, the woman claimed.

Her husband died in a road accident in September 2013, and she suffered a major mental shock and took some time in recovering from that grief, the complainant said.

Later, after obtaining information regarding the said insurance scheme, she approached the bank to avail herself of the benefits on March 26, 2019. Despite submitting all necessary documents, the bank kept the claim pending and did not take a decision on it.



## No embargo on legislature in giving benefits to MLAs, ex-MLAs:HC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Lucknow

The Allahabad High Court has dismissed a plea challenging the legal provisions granting pension and other benefits to former MLAs and MLCs, observing the provisions fall within the legislative domain and cannot be declared unconstitutional merely on the basis of policy disagreement.

The Constitutional Scheme does not inhibit the Legislature from enacting provisions relating to pension, allowances, or allied benefits in favour of Members of Legislative Assembly (MLA) and Members of Legislative Council (MLC), including former members, the Lucknow bench of the court said.



A bench of Justices Rajan Roy and AK Chaudhary passed the verdict on a PIL filed by SN Shukla, general secretary of an NGO, Lok Prahari. The bench had completed its hearing on February 17 and delivered its verdict on May 13.

In its judgment, the bench observed, "There exists no Constitutional embargo upon

the State legislature in enacting a measure of social security for its members as well as former members. The nature, character, and quantum of the benefits so extended do not disclose any manifest arbitrariness so as to attract the prohibition embodied under Article 14 of the Constitution of India."

## Assistant collector competent to declare farm-land transaction void: Allahabad HC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Prayagraj

The Allahabad High Court has ruled that under the Uttar Pradesh Revenue Code, the assistant collector (first class) is the competent authority to declare any transaction of agricultural land void under section 166, if it is contravention of sections 154 and 157A, and the district magistrate has no jurisdiction to do so.

With the above observation, Justice Arun Kumar set aside an order passed by the Sant Kabir Nagar DM and its subsequent confirmation issued by the commissioner, Basti division, whereby a sale deed in favour of a society that had constructed the Al-

Huda Madarsa on purchased land at Khalilabad was declared void as it was executed in the name of the society and its chairman, Samsul Huda Khan, is a foreign national.

While declaring the sale deed as void, both the DM and the commissioner had directed to vest the entire property in the State. The order was passed while allowing a writ petition filed by the Kulliyatul Banatir Razviya Educational and Welfare Society.

In its order on Friday, the court observed, "A plain and simple reading of the Uttar Pradesh Land Revenue Act makes it clear that the collector, including the additional

collector as well as the assistant collector, is authorised to discharge the powers and duties conferred upon him under the Act."

"The aforesaid Act does not confer upon the collector (DM) the power to declare a transaction to be void under section 166 of the Act, being violative of sections 154 or 157A of the Act. Such power is vested only in the assistant collector first class (SDM), who may be authorised by the state government to discharge all or any of the functions of the DM but converse to it is not permitted," it added.

The court further said that "the duties and functions assigned therein to the SDM under law are not to be dis-



charged by the DM even though he may be the controlling authority of the SDM. The DM is not authorised to take over the functions assigned to the SDMs. Thus, the DM is not supposed to discharge the

functions specifically assigned to the SDM under the Act, including that of declaring a transfer to be void."

The petitioner is a registered society under the Societies Registration Act,

1860, running a madarsa. The society purchased the land in dispute through a registered sale deed on August 28, 2014. The sale deed was executed in favour of the petitioner society and its "sarparast" (chairman), who was Samshul Huda Khan at that point of time.

Subsequently, one Abdul Karim filed a complaint before the Sant Kabir Nagar DM, alleging that as Khan had become a British citizen in 2013, the purchase of immovable property in India in his name without the requisite permission of the state government was void in accordance with section 90, read with section 104, of the Uttar Pradesh Revenue Code,

2006, and as such, the land may be vested in the state government.

The DM himself proceeded to decide the said complaint by an order dated February 12, 2024, and directed the vesting of the land in the State, free from all encumbrances. Against the said order, the petitioner filed a revision plea before the commissioner, Basti division, which was allowed by an order dated July 10, 2025, and the matter was remanded back to be decided afresh.

After the remand, the DM, by his order dated November 14, 2025, again held the sale deed to be void as it was executed in the name of Khan, who was a foreign national,

and directed the vesting of the entire property in the State.

Aggrieved by the aforesaid order, the petitioner again filed a revision plea before the commissioner, Basti division, which was dismissed by an order dated April 24, 2026. Hence, the society filed the writ petition before the high court, challenging the orders of both the DM and the commissioner.

During the court proceedings, the counsel for the society contended that the entire proceedings have been carried out by the DM, who had no jurisdiction to take a decision as the authority under the relevant rules is vested in the sub-divisional magistrate (SDM).

# The Traditional Indian Solutions to Natural Disaster Mitigation

Many ancient Indian scholars mentioned about natural calamities or *vipatti* in their texts and some also proposed ways to deal with them. For instance, the text *Kamandakiya Nitisara* (c. 500-700 CE) enumerates 15 categories of disasters including those caused by excessive rainfall and drought.

For earthquake resilience, the Pallavas of Kanchi strengthened stone structures by using precisely cut joints without mortar and inserting granite layers as binders, improving resistance to seismic movement. The Kakatiya dynasty of Warangal, which built the UNESCO World Heritage site of Ramappa Temple in the 13th century CE, employed 'sandbox' technology in its construction to help the structure withstand seismic forces. In the Himalayan region, traditional techniques like *Kath Kuni* from Himachal Pradesh continue to offer earthquake-resistant solutions. This style combines interlocking deodar wood, stone and hay without mortar, creating flexible structures that can withstand tremors. Small doors and windows with strong wooden frames reduce structural stress, while heavy slate roofs add stability. Another Himalayan technique, *Dhaji Dewari*, uses timber frames with earth infill and is considered more economical and time-efficient.



**R K PACHNANDA**  
FORMER CHAIRMAN, HARYANA PUBLIC SERVICE COMMISSION; FORMER CHAIRMAN, HARYANA ELECTRICITY REGULATORY COMMISSION; FORMER DG-ITBP; FORMER DG-NDRF; COMMISSIONER OF POLICE, KOLKATA; DIRECTOR, BHARAT KI SOCH



**NEHA G**  
JR. RESEARCH FELLOW, BHARAT KI SOCH

अग्निना ग्रामे दहमाने सर्वे नागरिकाः अभ्यवपचेरन् ।  
यश्च न अभ्यवपचेत् तस्य द्वादशाणो दण्डः ॥  
(Arthashastra, Book 4)

Vedic scholars gave more importance to prevention than cure and hence suggested suitable firefighting implements, fire brigades and water backups to deal with fires. For instance, Kautilya's *Arthashastra* prescribes that every household should keep some indigenous devices to douse fire. The city superintendents are instructed to set up fire extinguishing devices in various public places as precaution. Interestingly, the indigenous practices against forest fires advocate for 'controlled' burning, contrary to the policy of complete fire suspension followed in modern forestry. This is done to avoid the accumulation of excess dry matter (leaves, twigs, etc.) that induces catastrophic wildfires and promote the growth of new vegetation aiding in biodiversity

conservation. For instance, the indigenous practice of *jhum* cultivation from Northeast India uses controlled burning to clear pests and weeds while preventing large fires through local knowledge of wind patterns, vegetation, topography and buffer forests. The ash also restores soil nutrients on rain-washed hill slopes. It is important to note here that, historically long fallow cycles allowed ecological recovery unlike today's shortened cycles caused by population pressure.

Similarly, in Uttarakhand, winter burning on steep hill slopes promotes grass regrowth, supports livelihoods, maintains biodiversity and lowers wildfire risk in the Himalayan Forest. In Central India, tribal communities conduct controlled burning in early summer, create fire-breaks around villages and fields, monitor animal behaviour and vegetation changes to predict fires. Forest fire management is generally a community effort and the indigenous knowledge is passed down across generations. Community traditions such as planting fire-resistant trees among the Khasi tribe of Meghalaya and seasonal fire bans among the Munda tribe of Jharkhand further highlight the value of indigenous knowledge in forest fire management.

Since the time of Indus Valley Civilization, water harvesting systems have played a vital role in India for drinking water, irrigation and adaptation to extreme weather. Traditional reservoirs and tanks helped tackle droughts, recharge groundwater and reduce soil erosion through community participation. The Vijayanagara Empire (13th-17th century CE) for instance, developed extensive community-managed tank systems for agriculture and drinking water. Today, these neglected traditional practices are regaining importance amid growing water insecurity.

Water-scarce regions such as Rajasthan, Gujarat and Delhi historically relied on stepwells like *Baolis* and *Bawaris* for water conservation. Their layered steps reduced evaporation, while canals diverted rainwater into reservoirs to recharge aquifers. Karnataka's Pushkarni stepwell at Hampi is another example of efficient water storage. *Jhalaras* collected seepage from upstream reservoirs, *Kunds* stored rainwater in underground wells for drinking, and *Nadis* served as village ponds harvesting rainwater from nearby catchments. Even during the Mauryan period, Arthashastra stressed maintaining food and water reserves to mitigate droughts, seeking assistance from



friendly foreign governments, etc. to mitigate droughts. He also gave paramount importance to the preservation of natural resources, such as planting suitable vegetation to protect drylands, conserving pasturelands, protection of forests, water reservoirs and mines for ecological preservation.

वर्षात्रौ नदीपर्यन्ता ग्रामा बहिश्चरेयुः ।  
तृणकाष्ठमपोहन्तः फलकवेणुनावाश्चरेयुः ॥  
(Arthashastra, Book 4)

Kautilya considers floods as highly devastating. He advises that the villages located near water sources should be relocated to a higher ground above the flood level during monsoons. A stock of supplies such as gourds, skin bags, canoes, tree trunks, hand planks, bamboo poles and braided ropes should be kept ready along with rescue teams to evacuate people from inundated areas. He also highlights the importance of community involvement in the flood rescue operations. A Mahasthan inscription from the Mauryan period also reflects flood mitigation measures focussed on recovery and rebuilding mainly through agricultural support. Further, the conventional water harvesting systems as discussed above, also help in flood mitigation by collecting and storing excess precipitation, shielding from property damage without the need for additional constructions against floods.

Over centuries, rural communities have relied on ecological knowledge to anticipate seasonal changes and withstand weather extremes. Texts like the *Taittiriyaopanisad* emphasise harmony between humans and nature as the basis of true prosperity. As climate change accelerates disasters across the globe, the modern solutions can be considered to be blended with indigenous wisdom that sustained its civilisation for centuries. From earthquake-resistant Himalayan architecture and community-led forest fire management to ingenious water harvesting systems and flood preparedness measures, India's traditional knowledge reflects a profound understanding of resilience, sustainability and coexistence with nature. Reviving these traditions and empowering communities who practice them can help India build not just disaster resilience, but also a more sustainable and resilient future.

## Fable with Moral

### The Loyal Mongoose

(Book 5, Aparikshitakarakam, Panchatantra)

Long ago there was a farmer who lived with his wife and infant son in a village. The couple loved their son a lot. One day, while returning from the fields, the farmer found a little injured mongoose lying near the road. The farmer picked it up and brought it home. He told his wife that the little mongoose would be a pet for their son. His wife was not happy with the idea, however, accepted reluctantly.



The farmer tended to the wounds of the mongoose and nourished it with food. As a result, the mongoose recovered quickly. The farmer's son and the mongoose started growing together.

One day the farmer's wife had to visit the market. She put her son to sleep instructing her husband to look after him. She told him not to allow the mongoose go near their son. She considered it unsafe for the animal to be in close proximity with the infant. The husband assured her that he would take good care of the baby.

Soon after his wife had left for the market, the farmer was summoned by the local moneylender. The moneylender wanted his money to be returned that he had lent to the farmer. Due a good harvest that season, the farmer had the money ready with him. The baby was in deep sleep, thus the farmer could not take the child with him. He placed the child in his cradle and left him with the mongoose. He believed that the mongoose was an intelligent animal and could take care of their son. After some time, when the farmer's wife

came back with a basket full of vegetables, she found the mongoose waiting for her outside the house.

She looked at the mongoose and realized that something was not right. She was shocked to see the face and paws of the mongoose smeared with blood. "You terrible creature, you have killed my son!" she cried and struck the mongoose on the head with her basket. She ran inside and was relieved to find the baby sleeping peacefully in his cradle. On the floor lay a black snake, that had been torn into pieces and was bleeding. The snake appeared very poisonous. The farmer's wife understood the chain of events. The mongoose must have seen the snake and in order to protect the sleeping baby, it killed the snake.

The wife was extremely regretful about her action. With tears in her eyes, she lifted the heavy basket to find the 'loyal' mongoose dead.

**Moral of the Fable**  
Acting impulsively in anger leads to regretful consequences.

## Did you know?

### The Floating Islands of Loktak

Manipur's Loktak Lake is home to the world's only floating national park. The lake features "Phumdis," unique, heterogeneous masses of vegetation, soil, and organic matter that float on the water's surface. These floating islands support the endangered Sangai (brow antlered deer). This delicate ecosystem serves as a vital carbon sink and a natural water purifier,



showcasing how traditional biodiversity can survive within unique geological formations through community led conservation efforts.

## QUIZ

### Environment & Sustainability

|                                            | Questions                                                                                                                                                                           | Option A                                        | Option B                                   | Option C                          | Option D                         |
|--------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|----------------------------------|
| 1                                          | Why did many ancient Indian civilizations settle along river valleys like the Indus and the Ganges?                                                                                 | To beat the heat                                | Defense against mountain tribes            | Ease of transportation            | Source of fertile soil and water |
| 2                                          | Name the traditional sacred groves of Manipur.                                                                                                                                      | Kaavu                                           | Dev Van                                    | Orans                             | Umang Lai                        |
| 3                                          | Name the tribal festival from Karnataka where there are strict community-enforced bans on cutting trees or harming wildlife in forests, allowing the local ecosystem to regenerate. | Kunde Habba                                     | Baha                                       | Tihar                             | Sarhul                           |
| 4                                          | What is the function of Zings in Ladakh?                                                                                                                                            | To collect melting glacier water for irrigation | Fortifications for defense against enemies | Sacred groves                     | Set of agricultural techniques   |
| 5                                          | What is the purpose of 'Fire Lines' in tribal communities?                                                                                                                          | Ritual to invoke the Almighty                   | To prevent forest fire                     | To provide warmth in cold weather | To tackle enemy attack           |
| Answers: 1 - D, 2 - D, 3 - A, 4 - A, 5 - B |                                                                                                                                                                                     |                                                 |                                            |                                   |                                  |

# panchatantra

## The Flying Turtle

1

Once upon a time two swans and their friend, a talkative turtle called Kambugriva, lived near a lake. However, the lake was drying up due to less rains. This worried them.

2

The turtle Kambugriva suggested that the swans fly around and look for another lake. This led them to find a huge lake with plenty of water at a distance from where they were.

3

When the swans came back, they decided to move to the bountiful lake. The problem was how the turtle would ever reach there. Kambugriva suggested that both the swans would hold two ends of a stick in their mouth and he would hang on to the middle of the stick with his mouth.

4

The swans agreed to the plan on the condition that Kambugriva should not open his mouth to talk mid-air. Thus, they carried the turtle hanging on the stick.

5

Soon they flew over a village. When the villagers looked up, they started to talk loudly about the incredulous scene of a flying turtle!

6

The turtle, wanting to react, opens his mouth to speak, loses his grip on the stick, and falls to his death.

**MORAL OF THE STORY:** Self-restraint and following good counsel is the key to safety and success.

FROM THE WORLD

PAKISTAN

Five terrorists killed

Security forces gunned down five terrorists in intelligence-based operations in northwest Pakistan, police said on Sunday. The operations were conducted late Saturday in the Bannu district of restive Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, according to police. The Regional Police Officer (RPO) Sajjad Khan said that the operations were launched following a recent attack on a police checkpoint in Fateh Khel area in the district. At least 15 security officials were killed and several were injured in the attack at the police post on May 10. However, no particular group claimed responsibility for it. The terrorists killed were allegedly involved in attacks on security forces, the Counter Terrorism Department (CTD) and civilians, RPO Khan said. Federal Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi praised the Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Police for eliminating the terrorists in Bannu.

CHINA

One dead as truck falls off bridge

One worker died and nine remain missing after a pickup truck fell off a bridge in southwest China on Saturday, state media reported. The truck, carrying a total of 15 people, was transporting workers to a sweet potato farm in the southern Guangxi region. Five people were rescued, authorities said. Search and rescue efforts continued Sunday for the remaining nine missing people. The truck plunged into the river while crossing a low-water bridge in Huanjiang Maonan Autonomous County, state-run broadcaster CCTV reported. More than 700 rescuers equipped with underwater sonar devices, dinghies and drones were deployed Sunday to search for the missing people and the truck. Heavy rainfall in the area caused torrents and increased the risk of landslides.

Pakistan Army criticises Gen Dwivedi’s remarks

**SAJJAD HUSSAIN**  
■ Islamabad

The Pakistan Army on Sunday criticised Indian Army Chief Gen Upendra Dwivedi’s recent remarks, while urging New Delhi to learn to “co-exist” peacefully.

Gen Dwivedi on Saturday said that if Pakistan continues to harbour terrorists and operate against India, then they have to “decide whether they want to be part of geography or history or not”.

Terming Gen Dwivedi’s comments as “provocative”, the Pakistan Army said that responsible nuclear states

**PRESS TRUST OF INDIA**  
■ The Hague

Driven by shifting global geopolitics, India and the Netherlands elevated their ties to a strategic partnership and inked 17 agreements to boost cooperation in defence, critical minerals and other key sectors during talks between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and his Dutch counterpart Rob Jetten.

In their meeting on Saturday evening, the two prime ministers expressed deep concern over the situation in West Asia, especially its serious implications for the region and beyond in view of disruptions caused to the global energy supplies and trade networks.

Ukrainian drone strikes on Russia kill 4, wound 12 others

**ASSOCIATED PRESS**  
■ Kyiv

One of Ukraine’s largest drone strikes on Russia killed at least four people, including three near Moscow, and wounded a dozen others, local authorities said Sunday. Debris fell on Russia’s largest airport without causing damage.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy confirmed the drone strikes, saying that they were “entirely justified”.

Russia has repeatedly launched similar attacks on Ukraine’s capital and other cities during the war, and an expert said that the strikes appeared to be retaliation for recent Russian attacks on Kyiv.

Modi and Jetten also called for freedom of navigation and global flow of commerce through the Strait of Hormuz, while opposing any “restrictive” measures, and reaffirmed their support for ongoing initiatives in this regard, according to a joint statement.

Roughly one-fifth of global energy supplies pass through this narrow waterway, where shipping has been severely disrupted since February 28 after the US and Israel launched a joint attack on Iran, triggering retaliatory strikes.

The two leaders also discussed the situation in Ukraine — marked by the ongoing conflict with Russia and regional security developments.

They agreed to continue

supporting efforts towards the achievement of comprehensive, just and lasting peace in Ukraine through dialogue and diplomacy, based on the principles of the UN Charter and international law, the joint statement said.

On the subject of Ukraine, the two sides also expressed concern over the ongoing war, which continues to “cause immense human suffering and carries global consequences,” it said.

As he left for Sweden on Sunday, Modi said in a social media post: “My Netherlands visit has added new momentum to India-Netherlands ties.”

“From elevating our relationship to a strategic partnership to expanding cooperation in water resources, semi-



India’s Prime Minister Narendra Modi, left, shakes hands with Netherlands’ Prime Minister Rob Jetten after a meeting at the Catshuis in The Hague, Netherlands

conductors, innovation, defence, sustainability and mobility, we have charted an ambitious roadmap for the future,” the prime minister

said. PM Modi, who was seen off by PM Jetten at Schiphol Airport, further said, “I am confident that the friendship between India and the



Russian drone strikes on Ukraine overnight wounded eight people, Ukrainian authorities said.

In Ukraine’s strikes on Russia, a woman was killed after a drone hit her home in Khimki, a Russian city just

northwest of Moscow, and two men died in the village of Pogorelki, which is 10 kilometres (6 miles) north of the capital, according to local Gov Andrei Vorobyev.

Ukrainian drones had also damaged unspecified “infra-

structure” and several high-rise buildings, Vorobyev said on social media.

One man was also killed after a drone struck a truck in the Belgorod region, which borders Ukraine, according to local authorities.

In Moscow itself, at least 12 people were wounded in the nighttime strike, mostly near the entrance to the city’s oil refinery, mayor Sergei Sobyanin reported. Sobyanin reported that the “technology” of the refinery hadn’t been damaged.

Russia’s largest airport — Moscow’s Sheremetyevo — said that drone debris had fallen on its grounds without causing damage or affecting flights.

Russian defences shot down 81 drones headed for

Moscow overnight, state agency Tass reported, citing Sobyanin, marking one of the largest attacks on the city since Russia launched a full-scale invasion of Ukraine on February 24, 2022.

Russian air defences destroyed 556 drones over Russia overnight, the country’s defence ministry said Sunday morning. Shortly after midday local time, it reported that more than 1,000 drones had been shot down or jammed in the previous 24 hours.

Zelenskyy said that the drones had flown more than 500 kilometres (310 miles) from Ukrainian territory and that Ukraine was “overcoming” Russian air defence systems concentrated in and around the capital.

Drone strike sparks fire on edge of UAE’s nuclear power plant

**JON GAMBRELL/ SAMY MAGDY**  
■ Dubai

A drone strike targeted the United Arab Emirates’ sole nuclear power plant on Sunday, sparking a fire on its perimeter. There were no reports of injuries or radiological release, but it highlighted the risk of renewed war as the Iran ceasefire remains tenuous.

No one immediately claimed responsibility, and the UAE did not blame anyone. It has, however, accused Iran of launching multiple drone and missile attacks in recent days as tensions have risen over the Strait of Hormuz, a vital energy waterway that Iran still has in a chokehold.

The United States is blockading Iranian ports, and diplomatic efforts aimed at a more durable peace have repeatedly faltered. The UAE has meanwhile hosted air defences and personnel from Israel, which joined the US in the Feb. 28 attack that sparked the war.

US President Donald Trump has suggested hostilities could resume, and Iranian state television has repeatedly aired segments with anchors holding Kalashnikov-style rifles in an effort to prepare the public for war. Fighting has also heated up between Israel and the Iran-backed Hezbollah militant group in Lebanon despite a nominal ceasefire there, further



straining the wider truce.

**Barakah plant can provide a quarter of the UAE’s energy**

The USD 20 billion Barakah nuclear power plant was built by the UAE with the help of South Korea and went online in 2020. It is the first and only nuclear power plant in the Arab world and can provide a quarter of all

the energy needs in the UAE, a federation of seven sheikhdoms.

The UAE’s nuclear regulator said the fire didn’t affect plant safety. “All units are operating as normal,” the organisation wrote on X.

The UAE statement didn’t blame any party for the attack. The Vienna-based

International Atomic Energy Agency, the United Nations’ nuclear watchdog, said the strike caused a fire in an electrical generator and that one reactor was being powered by emergency diesel generators.

IAEA director-general Rafael Mariano Grossi expressed “grave concern” about the incident and said military activity that threatens nuclear safety is unacceptable, the agency said in a statement.

Sunday’s strike marked the first time the four-reactor Barakah plant has been targeted in the war. It is near the border with Saudi Arabia, some 225 kilometres (140 miles) west of the UAE’s capital city, Abu Dhabi. (AP)

SriLankan Airlines accuses Indian employees of ₹22 million fraud

**PRESS TRUST OF INDIA**  
■ Colombo

SriLankan Airlines has accused several Indian employees based in its Chennai office of misappropriating funds worth ₹22 million. In a statement issued on Saturday, the Sri Lankan flag carrier said that the fraud was carried out by altering invoices, payment details and signatures.

“With regard to the misappropriation of funds at SriLankan Airlines’ office in Chennai, the airline wishes to inform that a few employees, all Indian nationals working in the finance



department in Chennai, are alleged to have misappropriated a total of INR 22 million over a period of time by fraudulently altering invoices, payment details and signatures,” it said.

The airline did not specify the duration of the misappropriation. It said that

Indian law enforcement has been contacted, and investigations are currently ongoing to recover the loss.

It also referred to a separate incident of an erroneous payment made to a service provider in the UAE due to a compromised email account.

At UN, India flags concerns over targeting of vessels in Strait of Hormuz

**PRESS TRUST OF INDIA**  
■ United Nations

Targeting commercial shipping, endangering civilian crew and impeding freedom of navigation in the Strait of Hormuz is “unacceptable”, India’s Permanent Representative to the UN Parathaneni Harish has said.

Harish’s remarks at a special meeting of the United Nations Economic and Social Council (UNECOSOC) on safeguarding energy and supply flows came days after an India-flagged commercial vessel came under attack off the coast of Oman.

Omani authorities rescued



all 14 crew members of the vessel sailing from Somalia, but it was not immediately known who carried out the strike. In a post on X on Sunday, Harish said that at the UNECOSOC meeting, he shared India’s approach to the recent energy and fertiliser crisis caused by the West Asia conflict.

“A combination of short-term and structural mea-

sures alongside international cooperation are essential to respond to the crisis,” he said.

“Reiterated that targeting of commercial shipping, endangering civilian crew and impeding freedom of navigation in the Strait of Hormuz, are unacceptable. International law in this regard must be fully respected,” he added.

The attack on the India-flagged vessel on May 13 took place amid the fragile situation in the Strait of Hormuz, a narrow waterway close to the coast of Oman through which roughly one-fifth of the world’s energy supplies pass.

Wes Streeting of Labour Party wants to be Britain’s next prime minister

**BRIAN MELLEY/ JILL LAWLESS**  
■ London



Wes Streeting

Wes Streeting’s ambition to head the British government was one of the worst-kept secrets in UK politics.

But if anyone was unaware, it’s now official — the former health secretary announced on Saturday his intention to oust Prime Minister Keir Starmer.

Streeting is the first member of Parliament to say he will take on Starmer in what is likely to be a bruising internal contest for the reins of the Labour Party,

can win a special election for a seat in the House of Commons.

Starmer has vowed to fight on despite being widely unpopular after a series of setbacks, policy U-turns and questions over his judgment for appointing a friend of the sex offender Jeffrey Epstein as US ambassador.

The government is facing weeks of chaos after it rejected calls to resign following the party’s disastrous results in the May 7 local and regional UK elections, in which Nigel Farage’s anti-immigrant Reform UK made huge gains. (AP)

Venezuela says it deported close ally of Maduro to face criminal proceedings in US

**JOSHUA GOODMAN**  
■ Miami

Venezuela’s Government said on Saturday it deported a close ally of Nicolas Maduro facing several criminal investigations in the US, less than three years after the businessman was pardoned by President Joe Biden as part of a prisoner swap.

The decision marks a stark reversal for Alex Saab, who Maduro fought tooth and nail to bring home after his previous international arrest in 2020. Now, the Colombian-born insider, long described by US officials

as Maduro’s “bag man,” may be asked to testify against his former protector, who is awaiting trial on drug charges in Manhattan after being captured in a shock raid by the US military in January.

The Venezuelan immigration authority, in a short statement Saturday, did not explicitly say where it had sent Saab but said the decision was made based on several ongoing criminal investigations in the US. The statement’s reference to Saab only as a “Colombian citizen” appeared to be a nod to Venezuelan law,

which prohibits the extradition of its nationals.

Following his last arrest, Maduro and acting President Delcy Rodriguez presented a copy of what they said was Saab’s Venezuelan passport, claiming he was a high-level diplomat who had been illegally detained during a refuelling stop en route to Iran.

**A fortune built from government contracts**

Saab, 54, amassed a fortune through Venezuelan government contracts. But he fell out of favour with the country’s new leadership that took power following Maduro’s ouster. (AP)

Former mayor shot dead in central Colombia

**ASSOCIATED PRESS**  
■ Bogota

A former mayor allied with presidential candidate Abelardo de La Escriella was shot dead in Colombia’s heartland, local authorities said Saturday. One of his aides was also killed.

The killings of Rogers Devia and his staffer Eder Cardona were the latest incident of political violence in a region under dispute by two groups labelled as terrorists by the US government and a third group — a splinter of the once dominant guerrilla Revolutionary Armed Forces of Colombia, or FARC.

Devia died in an attack by gunmen in the rural area of Cubarral, a city he governed between 2020-2023 lying 170 kilometres (105 miles) south of the capital Bogota, said the Public Defender’s Office of the department of Meta in a posting on X. De La Escriella represents the National Salvation Movement.

The Public Defender’s Office said the killings could hurt “the exercise of political rights and democratic participation” ahead of Colombia’s presidential elections, which take place May 31. There will be at least half a dozen candidates competing in the election.

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NEW DELHI | MONDAY | MAY 18, 2026

BUSINESS13

## New footwear testing lab to boost quality, aid MSMEs

A state-of-the-art footwear testing laboratory has been established at the National Test House (Northern Region) in Ghaziabad, aimed at strengthening quality infrastructure for one of India's key labour-intensive sectors.

The facility offers comprehensive testing capabilities across multiple footwear categories, with assessments carried out in accordance with relevant Indian Standards (IS), the consumer affairs ministry said in a statement.

Strategically located near major footwear manufacturing clusters, it promises faster turnaround times and affordable access for MSMEs, exporters, manufacturers, and regulatory agencies. The ministry said the laboratory is expected to play a significant role in helping Indian footwear producers meet stringent domestic and international benchmarks — a critical factor in improving export competitiveness and market acceptance in an increasingly quality-conscious global marketplace.

The initiative is positioned as a contribution to India's broader national quality infrastructure, with testing and certification support designed to enhance consumer confidence and drive improvements across the value chain, from product reliability to safety compliance.

The facility also aligns with the Government's "Make in India" push and the overarching "Viksit Bharat" vision, both of which emphasise manufacturing self-reliance and the development of a robust quality assurance ecosystem.

For the footwear sector — where global buyers demand consistent compliance with technical standards — accessible domestic testing infrastructure could reduce dependence on overseas certification facilities and shorten lead times for export-bound consignments.

LEKHA  
CHAKRABORTY

In a rare public appeal that blended economic urgency with cultural sensitivity, Prime Minister Narendra Modi urged Indians this month to postpone gold purchases for at least a year, framing restraint as a patriotic act to safeguard the nation's foreign exchange reserves. Days later, on May 13, the government followed with a sharp policy response: more than doubling import duties on gold and silver to 15 percent from 6 percent.

The moves come as India grapples with a double blow to its external accounts with surging oil prices triggered by escalating tensions in West Asia and persistent demand for gold, a metal deeply embedded in the country's weddings, festivals and household savings. With the rupee touching record lows near 95-96 to the dollar, officials are determined to prevent a wider current account deficit from undermining economic stability.

India, the world's second-largest consumer of gold after China, imported roughly \$72 billion worth of the metal in the financial year that ended in March 2026. Although volumes have moderated somewhat, the value has climbed sharply amid high global prices, adding to pressures already intensified by costly crude oil imports. ?

### A Cultural and Economic Tightrope

Gold holds profound significance in Indian society. It is gifted at weddings, worn during religious ceremonies and viewed as a safe store of value, particularly in rural areas and among middle-class families. Modi's May 10 address in Hyderabad went further than gold, calling for reduced fuel consumption through carpooling and public transport, limits on non-essential foreign travel, and greater use of domestic products — evoking the spirit of austerity seen during the Covid-19 pandemic.

The appeal was not a formal ban but carried moral weight in a country where the prime minister's words often influence public behaviour. Some families have reportedly

cancelled or scaled back gold bookings for upcoming weddings, while jewelers report mixed reactions ranging from patriotic compliance to quiet frustration over potential business losses. The announcement also triggered panic buying of gold.

The subsequent duty hike — a 10 percent basic customs duty plus 5 percent Agriculture Infrastructure and Development Cess — took effect almost immediately. Domestic gold prices jumped in response, with futures rallying before stabilising and retail prices for 22-carat gold rising by several thousand rupees per 10 grams. The increase aims to make non-essential imports less attractive while channeling scarce dollars toward critical energy needs.

### Pressures on the Current Account

India's external vulnerabilities have deepened in recent months. The country imports more than 80 percent of its crude oil, and disruptions in West Asia have pushed energy costs higher, widening the trade deficit. The rupee has been one of Asia's worst-performing currencies in 2026, reflecting investor caution and outflows. Foreign exchange reserves, while still substantial, have faced downward pressure.

Gold and oil together dominate India's import concerns. By curbing bullion demand, policymakers hope to ease the current account deficit, which India fear could approach or exceed 2 percent of GDP if

unchecked. This echoes the 1991 balance-of-payments crisis, when India was forced to pledge gold reserves to the International Monetary Fund — a painful memory that still shapes official thinking, even as today's buffers are far stronger.

Earlier steps this year, including restrictions on certain jewelry imports requiring licenses to prevent misuse of free trade agreements, had already signaled tighter oversight. The latest duty increase represents a more blunt tool to compress demand.

### Impact on Industry and Consumers

The gems and jewelry sector, which employs millions directly and indirectly — many in small and medium enterprises in Gujarat, Rajasthan and southern India — faces immediate headwinds. Industry groups warn of margin compression, inventory challenges and possible job losses during peak wedding seasons. Organised retailers like Titan and Kalyan Jewellers have seen their shares react negatively to the combined effect of the appeal and tariff hike. ?

There are potential upsides. Higher duties may boost recycling of old gold, supporting a more circular domestic supply chain. Sovereign Gold Bonds and gold exchange-traded funds could attract investors seeking formal, paper-based exposure without adding to physical imports. Investment demand for gold as a hedge against rupee weakness and global uncertainty may also prove resilient.

For ordinary Indians, gold just became more expensive. While cultural demand often shows price inelasticity — buyers historically absorb higher costs or turn to lighter jewelry — sustained high prices could shift some preferences toward alternatives or delay purchases.

Smuggling risks, which eased after duties were cut in 2024, could re-emerge if the price gap with international markets widens significantly. ?

### Gold strategy

The Government's approach combines short-term demand management with longer-term efforts to formalise the gold market. Expanded hallmarking, digital gold products and incentives for value-added jewelry exports aim to reduce reliance on raw imports while preserving the sector's contribution to employment and growth.

I support the intent behind the measures, viewing them as pragmatic responses to cyclical shocks rather than permanent protectionism. Success however will depend on several factors like how quickly global oil prices and geopolitical tensions moderate, public adherence to the austerity appeal, and the effectiveness of enforcement in preventing illicit trade.

As of mid-May 2026, the rupee has shown some stabilisation, but markets remain watchful. Bond yields will be closely monitored in coming weeks. Foreign investors are assessing whether these steps avert the need for more drastic actions, such as tighter capital controls or emergency financing.

India's \$4 trillion-plus economy has demonstrated resilience in recent years through diversified exports, a strong services surplus and robust domestic demand. Yet its dependence on imported energy and culturally driven gold consumption leaves it exposed to commodity cycles and global shocks.

Modi's Government is betting that a blend of moral suasion, targeted tariffs and gradual financialisation of savings can thread the needle — honouring cultural feelings while protecting macroeconomic stability. In a world of heightened uncertainty, this balancing act will test India's ability to manage its external vulnerabilities without stifling one of its most enduring symbols of prosperity.

The writer is a Professor and Chair, NIPFP NET-Website Committee, National Institute of Public Finance and Policy, New Delhi

## West Bengal rice industry seeks infra push, faster clearances

BISHASWAR MALAKAR  
■ Kolkata

The rice industry in West Bengal, the country's largest rice-producing State, has sought better infrastructure, faster approvals and stronger export promotion from the new BJP Government in the State to boost growth and investments in the sector.

Ricevilla Foods CEO Suraj Agarwal said the industry was looking for improvement in infrastructure for rice mills and warehouses, particularly in rural areas

where poor roads, drainage systems and delayed electricity connections continue to affect operations.

"In many rural districts, electricity connections for new rice mills take months, causing delays, higher project costs and harass-

ment. The industry expects faster services and proper infrastructure support from the Government," Agarwal said.

He said modern storage and logistics infrastructure has become increasingly important as India's annual rice production crossed 1,500 lakh tonnes and Government rice stocks exceeded 590 lakh tonnes.

The industry has also demanded a single-window clearance mechanism for licenses and approvals to reduce delays and paperwork. (PTI)

## India's gems, jewellery exports down 9 pc

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Mumbai

India's gems and jewellery exports declined by 9.07 per cent at \$ 2,226.45 million (20,825.01 crore) in April following the West Asia conflict, the Gem & Jewellery Export Promotion Council said.

The total exports were \$ 2,448.53 million (₹ 20,952.26 crore) in the same month in 2025, as per the data by the industry apex body GJEPC.

"Decline in exports is mainly due to the ongoing conflict in West Asia, which has caused world-

wide disruptions affecting exports. Besides geopolitical tensions, exports to the US, a major export market for the gems and jewellery industry, were also affected because there is still no clarity on the tariffs," GJEPC Chairman Kirit Bhansali told PTI.

## NTPC chief cautions against dependence on single supplier for nuclear technology

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ New Delhi

The country must remain watchful of becoming over-dependent on any single supplier or country for nuclear technology as it moves ahead with the ambitious 100 GW nuclear power plan, an industry executive has cautioned.

Surdeep Singh, the Chairman of India's largest power generation company NTPC, has asserted that the country should prioritise control over technology and resources, even if domestic options are 5-10 per cent costlier at the initial stage, to avoid the supply chain vulnerabilities currently seen globally.

Singh, at a workshop organised by Central Electricity Authority on India's nuclear power roadmap, urged stakeholders to move beyond legislative intent and focus on the immediate formulation of rules and guidelines, arguing that clarity in implementation is the only way to convert policy into actual investment, according to the minutes of the workshop released by the CEA at the weekend.

The workshop on "Shanti Act, 2025: Enabling India's 100 GW Nuclear Power Roadmap through Public-Private Partnership" held last month.

"The chairman has also cautioned against technological over-dependence on

any single supplier or country, asserting that India should prioritise control over technology and resources, even if domestic options are 5-10 per cent costlier at initial stage, to avoid the supply chain vulnerabilities currently seen globally," as per the minutes.

Singh said his company aims to build 30 GW of nuclear capacity by 2047, and to achieve this goal NTPC is exploring feasible locations across 14 States of the country. On the size of the projects being planned by NTPC, he stated the focus must remain on large capacity reactor sets.

"For a large-scale power producer like NTPC, the focus must remain on large capacity reactor sets rather than Small Modular Reactors (SMRs), he said and suggested it might be better

suited for captive industrial use despite their high standby costs.

According to the NTPC website, the company currently has an installed capacity of 89,805.30 MW at group-level, spanning coal, gas/liquid fuel, hydro and solar power. As of March 31, 2026 NTPC held 17 per cent of India's total power generation capacity and contributed 24 per cent of total power generation of the country.

The SHANTI Act repealed the Atomic Energy Act of 1962 and the Civil Liability for Nuclear Damage Act, 2010, which had proved to be impediments to the growth of the civil nuclear sector in India.

The new law enables private companies and joint ventures to build, own, operate, and decommission nuclear power plants under a Government licence.

## ICAI to embed AI, data analytics in CA curriculum

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ New Delhi

Chartered accountants' apex body ICAI will embed artificial intelligence, data analytics, and other subjects in its curriculum as it works to keep pace with the evolving technological and professional changes.

Lakhs of students are pursuing chartered accountant programme at the Institute of Chartered Accountants of India (ICAI), which has more than five lakh members.

ICAI President Prasanna Kumar D in an interview to PTI said as technology is taking the front seat now, artificial intelligence (AI)

and data analytics need to be embedded into the subjects.

The institute has recently formed the Committee for Review of Education and Training (CRET), which is expected to finalise its recommendations, including updates for the curriculum, in the coming months.

"We have formed the CRET. It is working to review the entire curriculum like what syllabus and subject need to be changed and training (articleship)," Kumar said. Currently, various subjects, including AI, data analytics, ESG, and sustainability are not part of the CA curriculum.

"For an engineer, AI is a

separate subject but for us, AI is not a subject but without AI, no chartered accountant can survive. Be it in employment or in practice, AI is a must," Kumar, who took over as President

in February, said.

In recent years, the accountancy profession has witnessed a major transformation with the increasing focus on non-financial reporting, ESG disclosures,

## India becomes largest market for KitKat globally for Nestle

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ New Delhi

India has emerged as the largest market globally for KitKat, the iconic chocolate-coated wafer bar of Swiss food and confectionery major Nestle, driven by strong consumer penetration, product innovation and aggressive marketing investments, according to the company. India, which had been the second-largest market for the brand over the last 2-3 years, has now become its biggest market globally, underscoring India's growing importance for the iconic chocolate wafer brand sold in over 85 countries.

"India is now the largest market for KitKat globally, and the brand has accelerated its market share growth over the last few years," Nestle India Chairman

and Managing Director Manish Tiwary said during a recent media interaction.

KitKat has now become the second brand in Nestle's portfolio, after Maggi, to emerge as the largest market globally.

A decade ago, India was at number 10 globally for KitKat.

As part of Nestle India's confectionery portfolio, KitKat contributed to strong momentum in FY26, with the confectionery product group delivering high double-digit growth in both value and volume, backed by robust underlying transaction growth across its key brands, he added.

According to reports, Japan, Brazil, and Europe are among the other leading markets for KitKat.

Nestle India Director Confectionery and Cereals Jagatheesan Gopichandar

said KitKat's performance was driven by "strong increase in core penetration and also entry into new consumer demand spaces" with innovations across mainstream and premium segments.

"We entered into gifting with KitKat Celebriety and nibbling with KitKat pops. We accelerated the premium portfolio with the launch of KITKAT Delights range with variants including Salted Caramel and Hazelnut, alongside mainstream innovations such as KITKAT DUO and KitKat Lemon and Lime," he said.

To further deepen consumer engagement, Nestle India has significantly increased advertising spends and rolled out partnerships and campaigns aimed at strengthening brand relevance.

The company also said investments in its viscooler programme (commer-

cial glass-door refrigerator designed to store and display) have helped accelerate growth across urban and rural markets while supporting the rollout of new product innovations.

Nestle India, in its annual report for FY25, had said it had 3,950 million fingers of KitKat after doubling its market share and becoming the fastest-growing brand within the chocolate category in the country.

While Maggi's business in India is also the largest market worldwide, where it sold 5+ billion serves.

KitKat was created in the 1930s by the British confectionery company Rowntree's. It came under Nestle's fold after the Swiss multinational acquired Rowntree's in 1988. However, in the US, KitKat is manufactured under licence by the Hershey Company.

# NCLAT upholds separate insolvency processes for 2 Videocon group entities

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Appellate tribunal NCLAT has upheld separate insolvency proceedings for two Videocon group entities — Videocon Industries Ltd (VIL) and Videocon Oil Ventures Ltd (VOVL) — while setting aside an earlier NCLT order that had directed clubbing of the two cases.

Passing a final order, the NCLAT said creditors of VIL and VOVL had intended the Corporate Insolvency Resolution Processes (CIRPs) of the two companies to run independently, considering the distinct nature of their businesses and the need for a specialised resolution.

In this, state-owned Bharat Petroleum subsidiary, BPRL has acquired VOVL, exercising its Right of First Refusal (ROFR), which was subsequently approved by NCLT through a June 2024 order, while the CIRP of VIL is still pending.

The appellate tribunal in its order said VIL and VOVL operate in starkly different



sectors — with VIL engaged in consumer electronics and VOVL in oil-related businesses — making it impractical for a single entity to possess the expertise required to revive both operations effectively. “One single entity would not have the expertise to revive these varied businesses,” the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) bench of Justice Yogesh Khanna and Ajai Das Mehrotra said.

The objective of the Insolvency & Bankruptcy Code (IBC) is to keep the corporate debtor a going concern besides the resolu-

tion of creditor dues. “Therefore, the creditors of VIL and VOVL intended to conduct separate CIRPs for the two companies to ensure different buyers with the requisite expertise for their businesses, who would be able to effectively handle the assets and revive the businesses,” the tribunal said in a 40-page order passed on May 14, 2026.

It further held that the “decision was taken in the commercial wisdom of the Committee of Creditors (CoC), which should not be interfered with by the tribunal (NCLT).

Earlier, the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) had, on February 12, 2020, while allowing a plea filed by Venugopal Dhoot, directed the resolution professional to consider and treat all assets, properties rights, claims, benefits of Videocon Oil Venture, Videocon Hydrocarbon Holdings, Videocon Energy Brasil and Videocon Indonesia Nunukan Inc as assets and properties of VIL for insolvency.

Dhoot had sought that all foreign oil and gas assets be considered as assets of Videocon Industries.

This NCLT order was challenged before the appellate tribunal NCLAT by petitioners, which include public sector lender SBI, BPRL Ventures Indonesia, Pertamina Hulu Energi Nunukan Company, among others. This order was stayed by NCLAT a week after, on February 19, 2020.

The matter dates back to 2012, when VOVL and VIL availed of finances on an obligor/co-obligor basis, from a consortium of lenders led by the State Bank of India.

# FTAs, lower import duties, better business environment to boost net FDI flows: ADB chief

KUMAR DIPANKAR ■ New Delhi

Free Trade Agreements (FTAs), reduction in import tariffs and improvement in business environment would encourage higher net foreign capital inflows into India, which have moderated in recent years, ADB Chief Economist Albert Park has said.

During 2021-22, India attracted net Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) of USD 38.6 billion, which came down to USD 28 billion in FY23 and further fell to USD 10.2 billion in FY24. Net FDI — inflow minus outflow — came down significantly to single digit to USD 1 billion in FY25 but improved to USD 3 billion during the April-December period of FY26. The government should continue reducing import tariffs to ensure foreign investments remain competitive, he said in an interview.

It also needs to strengthen the overall manufacturing ecosystem by developing industrial zones with robust infrastructure and integrated facilities, making them



easier for foreign firms to address their business needs efficiently in one place, he said, adding that free trade agreements should help increase FDI flow in India.

“Asian Development Bank has also been pushing the idea of better governance of cities. This involves a form of integrated planning that encompasses the logistical, regulatory, and human capital needs of the businesses. Smart urbanism that addresses the concerns of the business community,” he said.

Stressing that uncertainty always leads to a flight of capital to safety, Park said the Asian market is witness-

ing this phenomenon triggered by uncertainty.

Asia is a little bit more vulnerable to the Middle East shocks than other parts of the world, he added.

Appreciating various reforms, including labour and GST undertaken by India, Park said India should continue the momentum.

On the outlook on crude oil prices, Park said they are likely to stay higher for longer due to the disruption caused by the longer-than-expected Middle East crisis.

“With a higher oil price expectation, we actually have it as USD 96 per barrel as average for 2026 as per the new reference scenario.

It should stay elevated at USD 80 per barrel in 2027. So, our idea is that oil prices are likely to stay higher for longer,” he said.

Future prices are showing higher prices farther out into next year than they did before, he said.

However, he said, “We have also seen always a kind of a premium of the spot market prices and the nearby futures market because there is such a shortage currently.”

On the impact of the ongoing Middle East crisis on India, Park said it is going to shave off 0.6 per cent from the country’s GDP growth, bringing it to 6.3 per cent, and also stoke inflation significantly in the current financial year.

The Asian Development Bank (ADB) in April projected India’s GDP growth to remain “robust” at 6.9 per cent in the current fiscal year, and rise to 7.3 per cent in FY28, driven by strong domestic demand. With regard to inflation, ADB had projected 4.5 per cent for the current fiscal year.

# FPIs pull out ₹27,000 cr in May; 2026 outflows hit ₹2.2 lakh cr-mark

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Foreign investors continued to pare their exposure to Indian equities, withdrawing ₹27,048 crore so far this month, indicating cautiousness among global investors amid an evolving global macroeconomic and geopolitical environment.

With this, total outflows by Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) from the equity market have reached ₹2.2 lakh crore in 2026, higher than the ₹1.66 lakh crore pulled out during the entire 2025, according to data with the NSDL.

FPIs were net sellers in all months of 2026, except February. They withdrew ₹35,962 crore in January before turning net buyers in February, when they invested ₹22,615 crore, the highest monthly inflow in 17 months.

However, the trend reversed in March, when foreign investors pulled out a record ₹1.17 lakh crore. The selling continued in April



with net outflows of ₹60,847 crore and extended into May with withdrawals of over ₹27,000 crore so far.

Himanshu Srivastava, Principal — Manager Research at Morningstar Investment Research India, said the latest outflow trend reflected persistent uncertainty surrounding global growth, elevated geopolitical tensions across key regions and volatility in crude oil prices, which continued to weigh on risk appetite towards emerging markets, including India.

He added that a stronger US dollar and elevated US bond yields remained key drivers behind the selling activity, as higher returns in developed markets improved the relative attractiveness of safer assets and prompted

investors to adopt a more defensive stance.

Srivastava further said concerns over the trajectory of global inflation and uncertainty regarding the pace and timing of future interest rate cuts by major central banks continued to influence capital allocation decisions globally.

Geojit Investments Chief Investment Strategist VK Vijayakumar said sustained FPI selling, coupled with a widening current account deficit, has exerted pressure on the rupee. “At the beginning of the year, the rupee was at 90 to the US dollar. On May 15, it breached the 96-mark to touch 96.14,” he said.

Vijayakumar said the rupee could weaken further if FPI outflows persist and crude oil prices remain elevated. He also noted that the continuing flow of capital into artificial intelligence-focused companies globally has led to some diversion of funds away from markets such as India, which are seen as lagging in the AI space.

# REC approves ₹1.40 cr for Green Innovator Immersive Learning Labs in Haryana

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Gurugram

State-owned REC Limited has committed ₹1.40 crore under its Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) programme for the implementation of the ‘Green Innovator Immersive Learning Lab’ project in 10 government schools in Haryana’s Karnal district.

The project will be implemented by I-Hub Foundation for Cobotics (IHFC), a technology innovation hub associated with Indian Institute of



Technology Delhi.

A Memorandum of Agreement (MoA) for the initiative was signed on May 14, 2026, at REC’s corporate office

in Gurugram. The agreement was signed by Arun Kumar Tyagi, Executive Director (CSR), REC Limited, and Ashutosh Dutt Sharma, Chief

Executive Officer of IHFC.

The ‘Green Innovator Immersive Learning Lab’ project aims to strengthen experiential learning in government schools through the use of advanced educational technologies such as Augmented Reality (AR), Virtual Reality (VR), 3D learning tools, and STEM-based learning modules.

The initiative will also focus on equipping students with future-ready skills, including coding, robotics, innovation, and digital literacy, helping them adapt to

the rapidly evolving technological landscape.

According to REC Limited, the collaboration reflects the company’s continued commitment to improving educational infrastructure and providing students in government schools with access to advanced technological learning environments.

The project is expected to create a more engaging and interactive educational experience for students while encouraging innovation and scientific thinking at the school level.

# Central Bank hosts mega MSME outreach in Faridabad

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Faridabad

In a major push towards boosting the Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSME) sector and driving financial inclusion, the Central Bank of India organised a nationwide mega MSME outreach programme in Faridabad on Saturday. The event, which witnessed enthusiastic par-

ticipation from a large number of local industrialists and entrepreneurs, culminated in the on-the-spot sanction of credit facilities worth ₹75 crore.

The high-profile event was attended by Tarsem Singh Zira, Zonal Head (Delhi), and Dr Himanshu Gupta, General Manager (MSME), Central Bank of India.

Addressing the gathering, senior bank officials provided



detailed insights into various tailor-made MSME schemes. They highlighted a series of strategic initiatives under-

taken by both the Central Government and the bank to empower and promote small-scale industries.

The officials also outlined upcoming financial products designed to accelerate entrepreneurship and streamline credit flow to the sector.

The key highlight of the outreach programme remained the immediate sanctioning of loans amounting to ₹75 crore, reinforcing the bank’s commitment to fostering regional industrial development.

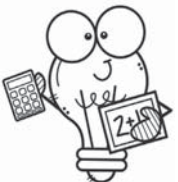
## DAILY SUDOKU

|   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 6 |   | 1 | 7 |   |   | 2 |   |   |
| 3 |   |   |   | 1 |   |   |   |   |
| 8 |   | 7 |   |   |   |   | 3 | 6 |
|   | 6 |   | 3 |   |   | 5 |   | 9 |
|   |   |   | 1 |   | 7 |   |   |   |
| 9 | 4 |   |   | 6 |   |   | 2 |   |
| 5 | 8 |   |   |   |   | 3 |   | 4 |
|   |   |   | 7 |   |   |   |   | 2 |
|   |   | 9 |   |   | 2 | 8 |   | 1 |

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

### HOW TO SOLVE IT

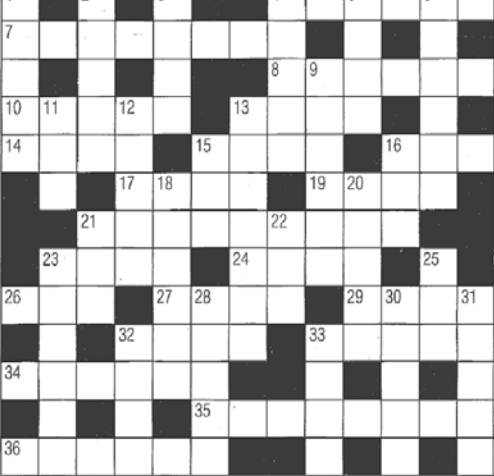
Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



| SOLUTION (16.5.26) |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |
|--------------------|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1                  | 5 | 7 | 3 | 2 | 4 | 6 | 9 | 8 |
| 3                  | 6 | 9 | 5 | 1 | 8 | 4 | 2 | 7 |
| 8                  | 4 | 2 | 6 | 7 | 9 | 1 | 5 | 3 |
| 6                  | 8 | 3 | 9 | 5 | 2 | 7 | 4 | 1 |
| 4                  | 7 | 5 | 1 | 6 | 3 | 9 | 8 | 2 |
| 2                  | 9 | 1 | 8 | 4 | 7 | 3 | 6 | 5 |
| 5                  | 1 | 4 | 2 | 3 | 6 | 8 | 7 | 9 |
| 7                  | 2 | 8 | 4 | 9 | 1 | 5 | 3 | 6 |
| 9                  | 3 | 6 | 7 | 8 | 5 | 2 | 1 | 4 |

## DOUBLE CROSSWORD

MONDAY | MAY 18, 2026



### ACROSS

- The notion that steak is only about £1 (6)
- Where Cain, in his wandering, came to a valley (8)
- Doesn't kill, but merely brandishes spears (10)
- Noted figure's outcry in historical battle (5)
- Containing a load of rubbish, let's ignore it (4)
- Inexperienced converted Tory (4)
- Figure to go to sea, perhaps, in a vessel (4)
- A flier in black? (3)
- Disable a military leader on purpose (4)
- See a chap's dressed (4)

### DOWN

- Cause to give up one's occupation (5)
- A slippery youngster (5)
- But commonly halved (4)
- At the Boar's Head, calls for revels (5)
- Bound to be in a hole, apparently (4)
- Smoothed over for a couple (6)
- Portions of pies containing some spice (6)
- A grassy place (3)
- A laughable publication (5)
- Pete, was well able to serve at court (7)
- By way of being a bit of an aviator (3)
- A drink? Yes, that's right (3)
- Like a bird behind the poop (6)

- "Go," possibly said very softly to a listener (9)
- A deal that brings father to court (4)
- Looking promising rather than thorny (6)
- Plot a bit of disobedience (3)
- Key water barrier in the Netherlands (4)
- Prepare to publish a new diet (4)
- Weapon involving risk (4)
- Bloomer by an egghead, reading and writing nought but arithmetic! (5)
- The agreement is forwarded (6)
- A naval reject? (8)
- Grab a bit of air (6)

- Covering a fifty year arrangement? (5)
- Pop up again (3)
- Dog going round in the afternoon? (3)
- Anybody can be the source of a quiet snore! (6)
- It was a capital little place (3)
- There's a Red one in W. central England, by the way (5)
- Be slow to speak (5)
- People can have tea on them (5)
- In the southeast, where part of a lake is National Trust (4)
- Helps ensure survival in a sweatshop (4)

# Loans likely to cross ₹1 lakh cr milestone in FY27: IRFC CMD

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ New Delhi

State-owned Indian Railway Finance Corporation (IRFC) has set a target of crossing a milestone of ₹1 lakh crore loan sanction during the current financial year.

To fund its business growth, the public sector undertaking (PSU) of the Ministry of Railways is looking to raise ₹70,000 crore, including from overseas in FY27.

“We are aiming for a loan sanction of ₹1 lakh crore and disbursement of about ₹40,000 crore during the ongoing financial year, as the pipeline of high-quality infrastructure projects looks strong,” IRFC Chairman and Managing Director Manoj Kumar Dubey said.

A steady pipeline and emerging opportunities in sectors such as metro and ports are expected to further



accelerate growth in the coming financial year, following its whole-of-government approach, he said.

During FY26, IRFC sanctioned projects worth ₹72,949 crore and disbursed approximately ₹35,067 crore, exceeding its annual guidance.

The company, which last year got Navratna status, witnessed its net worth raising to all-time high at ₹56,748 crore and AUM crossing a record high at ₹4.85 lakh crore.

The diversification-led expansion resulted in improved spreads and a consistent rise in net interest margin (NIM), while IRFC maintained its zero NPA status.

“Our diversification strategy is now translating into stronger spreads, improved margins and enhanced shareholder value, he said, adding that NIM should further improve to 1.65 per cent in FY27 as against 1.5 per cent

recorded in FY26.

He further said IRFC made a structural shift in business model, from a traditional railway financier to a diversified infrastructure financing institution keeping railways at its Centre.

With Indian Railways not availing fresh disbursements since 2023-24, the company has expanded into sectors with strong forward and backward linkages to railways, including power generation, renewable energy, transmission, fertilisers and railway-linked infrastructure.

For the financial year ended March 31, 2026, IRFC reported its highest-ever profit of ₹7,009 crore, compared to ₹6,502 crore in 2024-25, registering a growth of 7.8 per cent.

The company's total assets crossed the landmark milestone of ₹5 lakh crore for the first time in FY26.

# UCIL to extract uranium from Hindustan Copper’s tailings, to set up recovery plant in Jharkhand: CMD

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Uranium Corporation of India Ltd (UCIL), a public sector company under the Department of Atomic Energy (DAE), will set up a recovery plant in Jharkhand to extract uranium from tailings of state-owned Hindustan Copper, a top official said on Sunday.

The move would help in augmenting domestic supplies of the strategic mineral used in nuclear power and defence applications.

In an interview with PTI, Hindustan Copper Chairman and Managing Director (CMD) Sanjiv Kumar Singh said that



the copper PSU has reached an understanding with UCIL under which tailings will be handed over to the Uranium Corporation of India to extract uranium.

Copper tailings are finely ground waste rock and water that remain after copper minerals are extracted from mined ores.

Singh said, “UCIL was concerned with our proposal and technically agreed because there is a presence of uranium in small quantities in our tailings, which they can extract.”

UCIL will process the tailings and, after extracting uranium, return the treated tailings to HCL, he said. The process will take time because UCIL operates under the DAE and follow atomic energy clearances and protocols, the CMD said.

Industry experts believe that the agreement could have both strategic and environmental benefits.

Recovering uranium from

tailings can provide an additional domestic feedstock for the country’s civil nuclear programme and reduce reliance on imports. “It also converts a waste liability into a resource besides addressing legacy environmental management.”

The country is aggressively pushing for expanded uranium production and international sourcing to support India’s nuclear power target of 100 GW by 2047.

Hindustan Copper Ltd on Friday reported a 137.3 per cent surge in net profit to ₹444.27 crore for the quarter ended March 31, 2026, on the back of higher revenue.

BRIEFLY

Satwiksairaj-Chirag finish runners-up at Thailand Open



Star Indian pair of Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty saved four championship points before going down fighting against Indonesia's Leo Rolly Carnando and Daniel Marthin in a gripping men's doubles final to finish runners-up at the Thailand Open Super 500 tournament here on Sunday. World number 4 Satwik and Chirag, champions here in 2019 and 2024, looked off-colour in the opening game but showed great mental fortitude under pressure in the second to almost take the match to the decider before losing 12-21 23-25 in a 53-minute summit clash. It was another creditable finish for Satwik and Chirag, who have established themselves as India's most consistent doubles pair in recent years. For the Indian duo, who had missed some tournaments due to Satwik's shoulder injury, it was a third final appearance at the \$475,000 event and their first of the season. They had also finished runners-up at the China Masters and Hong Kong Open last year. While the Indians returned to the podium once again, it proved to be a dream finish for Carnando and Marthin, who reunited for this tournament after two years following the latter's recovery from a long-term knee injury that required surgery. It was also the Indonesians' first win over Satwik and Chirag, who had entered the contest with a 4-0 head-to-head record against them, with three of those victories coming in three-game matches.

BCCI mulls converting U23 50-over tournament to T20



The Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) is mulling to convert the national Under-23 men's 50-over tournament to T20 format from the upcoming domestic season. It is learnt that the BCCI is set to seek opinion of state associations and other respected voices before effecting the change to the tournament, currently known as the State A Championship. "It is still in the early stages, as opinions of state associations and a few other stakeholders will be asked before taking a call. But if it's done then it will happen from the new domestic season (2026-27)," a source close to the development indicated to PTL. Currently, the tournament is divided into Elite and Plate Divisions, as is the norm in Indian domestic cricket. Tamil Nadu are the defending champions in the Elite section while Meghalaya hold the Plate segment title. The corresponding U23 red-ball tournament is being played for Colonel CK Nayudu Trophy.

St Pauli and Heidenheim relegated on last day of Bundesliga season

CIARAN FAHEY  
■ Berlin

St Pauli and Heidenheim were relegated from the Bundesliga while Wolfsburg grabbed the last chance for survival on a dramatic last day of the season on Saturday.

Wolfsburg won a relegation decider at St Pauli 3-1 to send the home team down and qualify for a playoff where it will be favored against the third-place finisher from the second division to decide which plays in the top division next season.

Heidenheim, which had been level with Wolfsburg and St Pauli going into the



final round, needed a win at home against Mainz to keep alive its hopes but it slumped to a 2-0 loss.

The last two are automatically relegated to the second division. Both demoted teams were given shows of support and appre-

Alex Smalley grabs a two-shot lead in PGA

ASSOCIATED PRESS  
■ Newtown Square (Pennsylvania, USA)

Alex Smalley kept his composure amid pure chaos Saturday in the PGA Championship, when he vanished from the leaderboard with a shaky start and when he surged back in front with sublime shots along the back nine at Aronimink Golf Club.

His voice was calm and steady after signing for a 2-under 68 for a two-shot lead. He recognizes the stakes and the stage for someone who has yet to win on tour.

"I'm trying to downplay that as much as I possibly can just to make it seem like any other golf tournament,

because essentially that's all it really is," Smalley said.

One look at the leaderboard would illustrate this PGA Championship is wildly different. Fourteen players had at least a share of the lead at some point Saturday. There was a seven-way tie for the lead with an hour left in the third round until Smalley's big finish.

And he's still left with an All-Star cast of contenders — 11 of them major champions — within five shots, a list that includes Masters champion Rory McIlroy and world No. 1 Scottie Scheffler, Jon Rahm and Xander Schauffele.

"I've never seen anything like this," Scheffler said when he finished with a 71, leaving



him five shots behind. "I've never seen a leaderboard like this, this bunched up. Going into tomorrow, it's quite literally anybody's tour-

nament." Smalley at least gets a head start thanks to six birdies over his last 10 holes that helped him recover from the rough start to become the

Ex-Real Madrid coach Xabi Alonso set to take Chelsea job

JAMES ROBSON  
■ London

Xabi Alonso is set to be named Chelsea coach after reaching an agreement with the Premier League club, a person with knowledge of the situation told the Associated Press on Saturday.

The person spoke on condition of anonymity because the appointment has not been publicly announced.

Alonso talked with Chelsea in the past week and is expected to sign a four-year contract.

It would be the Spaniard's first job since lasting less than eight months at Real



Madrid. Alonso left Madrid by mutual consent in January after poor results and widespread media reports that he lost control of the locker room.

Despite the short tenure at the Bernabeu Stadium, Alonso's reputation remained high across Europe

after leading Bayer Leverkusen to a German league and cup double and breaking Bayern Munich's dominance of the Bundesliga. Chelsea has been searching for a new coach since firing Liam Rosenior last month. Rosenior was the second coach to be fired since the turn of the year following the departure of Club World Cup winner Enzo Maresca in January.

Alonso would become the fifth permanent coach appointed by Chelsea's American owners Todd Boehly and Clearlake Capital since they bought the club in 2022. (AP)

McIlroy surges into PGA Championship contention with a 66 at Aronimink

DAN GELSTON  
■ Newtown Square (Pennsylvania, USA)

Rory McIlroy smashed his drive on the 397-yard sixth hole and landed a beauty on the green to the delight of a roaring Aronimink crowd.

He made a birdie and kept a second straight major victory firmly in sight on a day in which several players made big moves up the leaderboard in more favourable conditions.

The pin placements, the course, nothing bothered McIlroy at Aronimink as he charged back from 105th at the end of Round 1 of the PGA Championship all the way to a share of the lead until he bogeyed 17, finishing at 3 under Saturday, a day after he complained about the setup

at Aronimink Golf Club. "I feel like I still did enough to think I have a chance going into tomorrow," McIlroy said.

**Who would count out McIlroy?**

He won the Masters and is trying to join Ben Hogan (1953), Arnold Palmer (1960), Jack Nicklaus (1972), Tiger Woods (2002) and Jordan Spieth (2015) as the only players to win the first two majors of the year in the modern rotation.

The number 2 player in the world, McIlroy was buried on the leaderboard Thursday after he shot a 74. Only four players in history have ever won a major championship after being 50th or worse at the end of the first round.

His Round 3 was a different story. He had six birdies, 10



pars and two bogeys and shot 66.

"I've climbed my way out of that hole a little bit, which is, I'm proud of myself for doing that, but there's one more day left, and I feel like I'm — again, if I can - depending on what the guys do, be

close enough to the lead, I feel like I've still got a good chance," McIlroy said.

Two long days at Aronimink produced the highest 36-hole score to par to lead the PGA Championship in 14 years. The 15 players separated by

CIARAN FAHEY  
■ Munich

Bayern Munich finally got hold of the Bundesliga trophy after extending its goals record with a Harry Kane hat trick on Saturday.

Kane's fourth hat trick this season lifted his tally to 36 goals — five shy of Robert Lewandowski's league record from 2020-21 — in Bayern's 5-1 rout of Cologne in the last round. Tom Bischof and Nicolas Jackson also scored.

Bayern finished with 122 goals, easily surpassing the previous Bundesliga record haul of 101 by the 1971-72 Bayern team with the likes of Franz Beckenbauer and Gerd



Muller. Leon Goretzka, who's leaving the club after eight seasons, scored the goal that broke the record with five rounds still to play.

"We have a great group, a

great togetherness, and to celebrate success with that is awesome," Bayern board member for sport Max Eberl said after his second league title with the club. (AP)

includes Rahm and three ahead of McIlroy, Schauffele and Reed. "The challenge can also be kind of fun if you do well. That's probably the reason why the leaderboard is so bunched up," Rahm said. "And it's going to be such a good Sunday tomorrow."

It starts with Smalley, a 29-year-old who spent three years in the Wannamaker dormitory at Duke, the name on the heavy PGA Championship trophy to be awarded Sunday. He is playing only his fifth major, never cracking the top 20. He's also winless on the PGA Tour, but he showed up for his first major of the year off three straight finishes in the top 20.

Bayern Munich finally receives Bundesliga trophy and celebrates

great togetherness, and to celebrate success with that is awesome," Bayern board member for sport Max Eberl said after his second league title with the club. (AP)

Scheffler's putter goes cold, forcing big comeback

DAN GELSTON  
■ Newtown Square (Pennsylvania, USA)

Scottie Scheffler walked off Aronimink with his putter still in the bag, though the defending PGA Championship winner might not have been blamed had he chucked the club into the water.

His putter failed him, and cost Scheffler a major opportunity in a tournament where no standout has emerged and led to a bunched leaderboard through three rounds.

Scheffler will still be in the mix in the final round — 14 players had at least a share of the lead at some point - yet the short game failures

only stretched his odds at pulling out another PGA.

A four-time major winner, Scheffler missed six putts inside 10 feet, four of them for birdie. But he made a 9-foot bogey putt on 18 for a 71.

Scheffler shot 1 over in a round where he could have grabbed a healthy lead if not for the muffed putts. Scheffler followed an opening 3-under 67 with consecutive rounds of 1 over. He slipped 14 spots, into a tie for 23rd, and is 5 shots off the lead. "If I continue to do what I'm doing and hole a few more putts, then I think I'll be in a good spot when tomorrow ends," Scheffler said.

The Scheffler who tore through the 2025 season, winning six times in a 4 1/2-



month span, hasn't arrived yet this year. Not even playing his best golf might be enough for Scheffler to pull off back-to-back PGA crowns.

Take last month's Masters,

for a recent example. Scheffler was trying to pull off what would have been an unprecedented comeback from 12 strokes down after 36 holes. He put a champi-

onship round together and shot a 4-under 68 at Augusta National, a terrific finish but he still finished one stroke behind winner Rory McIlroy.

Buoyed by that recent flashpoint for success, Scheffler believed he could play his way through a crowded field of contenders — from unheralded Alex Smalley looking for his first career PGA Tour win, to the blistering hot McIlroy - and shoot his way back to the top and leave with another Wanamaker Trophy.

Scheffler and McIlroy have won four of the last five majors, with McIlroy winning the 2025 and 2026 Masters and Scheffler taking the PGA Championship and British Open last year. (AP)

Cristiano Ronaldo's Saudi trophy wait drags on

ASSOCIATED PRESS  
■ Riyadh (Saudi Arabia)

Cristiano Ronaldo's wait for a first major trophy in Saudi Arabia continued when Al-Nassr lost to Japan's Gamba Osaka 1-0 in the Asian Champions League Two final on Saturday.

A first-half goal from Turkish forward Deniz Hammat helped Osaka secure Asia's second-tier tournament despite Al-Nassr dominating possession and having more attempts on goal. The defeat came five days after Al-Nassr was seconds away from winning the Saudi Pro League for the first time since 2019, only to concede in stoppage time and leave the title race to be



decided on the final match-day on Thursday.

It was a frustrating night for the home side. Al-Nassr created multiple openings in the first half but Osaka took the lead in the 30th minute. Hammat turned and fired a low shot into the bottom corner from just inside the area. After a lengthy VAR check for offside, the goal stood.

"I am happy to score and help the team and to do my best for this club," said Hammat, who went off injured at halftime. "I was nervous watching in the second half but the most important thing is that we won and I am proud of my teammates. Now it is time to celebrate and enjoy."

Osaka defended in numbers and with discipline, making it difficult for Al-Nassr's star-studded attack to create clear chances.

Ronaldo, who joined the club in December 2022, came close to equalizing just before halftime but his close-range header from a Joao Felix cross sailed wide. Felix, who signed from Chelsea in July, went even closer with 13 minutes remaining, striking the post with a low shot from outside the area.

Despite the double disappointment this week, Al-Nassr can still clinch the Saudi Pro League. It leads Al-Hilal by two points heading into the final game against Damac on Thursday.

Svitolina wins Italian Open, Sinner in men's final

ASSOCIATED PRESS  
■ Rome

Elina Svitolina claimed a third Italian Open title on Saturday by beating Coco Gauff, who lost in the final in Rome for the second straight year. In the men's final on Sunday, home favorite Jannik Sinner will face Casper Ruud.

Svitolina took nearly three hours to prevail 6-4, 6-7 (3), 6-2 and win her first WTA 1000 title since lifting the title in Rome in 2018. The Ukrainian also won in 2017.

"It's very hard to believe that it's been eight years when I had this trophy here and very, very, very pleased of course with the two weeks here," Svitolina said on court after her



20th career title.

"I told my coach that it would be nice before I finish my career to have a round number. So he told me that hopefully we're going to get this this year. So, I'm very, very happy," Gauff, who was hoping to become the first American to win in Rome since 2016, lost to Jasmine

Paolini last year but went on to win the French Open.

"It's been a great two weeks... and I definitely feel the momentum going into the French Open," she said. "A lot of lessons learned from this match."

Gauff started brilliantly, breaking Svitolina and holding to love.

# Delhi Capitals beat Rajasthan Royals

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ New Delhi

Abhishek Porel and KL Rahul hit fluent half-centuries as Delhi Capitals overhauled a competitive Rajasthan Royals total to register a five-wicket victory in their Indian Premier League clash here on Sunday.

Porel, playing only his third IPL match of the season, looked in fine touch during his 31-ball 51, while KL Rahul bounced back from a couple of underwhelming outings with a composed 56 off 42 deliveries as Delhi Capitals completed the chase of 194 in 19.2 overs.

The opening pair stitched together a match-winning 105-run partnership that laid the



foundation for DC's chase, before Axar Patel scored an unbeaten 34 off 18 deliveries to complete the chase.

Earlier, Mitchell Starc started with the ball for DC, producing a devastating spell of fast bowling to restrict Rajasthan Royals to 193 for 8.

Starc ripped through the RR middle order in a dramatic 15th over, dismissing a well-set Riyan Parag (51), Donovan Ferreira (0) and Ravi Singh (4). The left-arm pacer struck off the second, third and fifth deliveries of the over, narrowly missing out on a hat-trick. Despite the collapse, Rajasthan Royals still managed a competitive total thanks to impressive half-centuries from skipper Parag and Dhruv Jurel.

## We did not deserve to win: Shubman Gill blames fielders for loss against KKR

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Kolkata

Gujarat Titans skipper Shubman Gill blamed his team's poor fielding effort for the 29-run defeat to Kolkata Knight Riders, saying they "didn't deserve to win" after dropping multiple catches against the former champions in the IPL match here on Saturday.

GT endured a sloppy outing in the field, spilling four catches, including a reprieve to the dangerous Finn Allen, who made them pay with a blistering 93 as KKR piled up a massive 247 for 2. The daunting target eventually proved beyond the visitors despite a



spirited chase. The defeat also brought an end to Gujarat Titans' five-match winning streak.

"Looking at the wicket, 200-210 was par score but we dropped too many catches. Pitch was good, the odd one was stopping but I felt we batted well to get to

the score we did. No concerns but our fielding could've been a lot better," Gill said after the match.

"We set a certain standard and dropping 3 sitters - we didn't deserve to win this one. Looking at it that way, best to have a game like this now than in the Qualifiers."

Allen capitalised fully on the missed opportunities, smashing 10 sixes and four boundaries during his explosive knock.

Angkrish Raghuvanshi added further damage with a 44-ball 82 studded with seven sixes and four fours, while Cameron Green chipped in with a brisk 52 off 28 balls.

## Dropped catches made the difference: Parthiv Patel

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Kolkata

Gujarat Titans assistant coach Parthiv Patel admitted their sloppy catching proved costly as they dropped as many as four catches, including two chances of Finn Allen, who made them pay with a blistering 35-ball 93 in a 29-run loss to Kolkata Knight Riders.

After Allen's explosive start, Angkrish Raghuvanshi (82 not out) and Cameron Green (52 not out) maintained the tempo as KKR posted their highest total of the season - 247 for 2. In reply, GT managed 218 for 4.



league game and Patel said the equation for qualification is straightforward.

"It's a simple scenario for us. We don't have to depend on other results," he said.

"If we win the next game, we qualify. It's as simple as that." Much of GT's success this season has revolved around the prolific opening pair of Shubman Gill and Sai Sudharsan, while questions have often been raised over the middle-order finishing.

Patel, however, dismissed concerns over their lower middle order and backed Washington Sundar's role as a finisher.

"We have won five games in a row and chased well in two-three of them. I don't think there is any issue," Patel said.

"Washington Sundar has scored a fifty and in the last four-five matches he has finished games for us without even getting out.

"Even today, we scored 220 while chasing 250. If the expectation is to score 300 runs, then no team is doing that. So I don't think we are struggling," he added.

## Royal Challengers Bengaluru secure berth for playoffs

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Dharamsala

Royal Challengers Bengaluru held their nerve and survived a late onslaught to edge out Punjab Kings by 23 runs to become the first team to secure an IPL playoffs berth with an all-round performance here on Sunday.

Venkatesh Iyer blasted a spectacular 40-ball 73 not out and powered RCB to 222 for four. Virat Kohli (58 off 37 balls), Devdutt Padikkal (45 off 25 balls) and Tim David (28 off 12) were the other significant contributors for RCB after they were asked to bat first. In reply, PBKS were stopped at 199 for eight after Shashank Singh's valiant 56 off 27 balls, the home team suffering its sixth consecutive

defeat after a great start to the season.

In a daunting chase of 223, Punjab Kings endured a nervy start as RCB's pace attack kept the batters under pressure in the first 10 overs.

PBKS were jolted early when veteran seamer Bhuvneshwar Kumar removed Priyansh Arya in the opening over, forcing the hosts on to the back foot immediately.

With the required rate hovering around 11-an-over from the outset, Punjab's batters were compelled to attack but RCB's disciplined bowling and sharp fielding denied the home side the momentum they were looking for. Cooper Connolly and Prabhsimran Singh looked to counterattack with



a few boundaries, but the visitors continued to chip away with timely breakthroughs.

Prabhsimran threw his bat at a Bhuvneshwar delivery way outside off and the edge flew to Devdutt in the slips.

Skipper Shreyas Iyer too bit the dust inside the Power Play. After reaching 35 off 22 balls, Suryansh Shedge hit an innocuous Suyash Sharma delivery to long-off, where Kohli completed a neat, flat

catch. However, Shashank kept up the fight with his bold hits, including three sixes in one over against Suyash, even as Jacob Bethell dropped Marcus Stoinis on 22, who too found the boundaries at will to keep PBKS in the hunt.

But Josh Hazlewood returned to dismiss Stoinis (37 off 25) with a full toss which the batter failed to put away. Shashank continued to battle for PBKS as Bhuvneshwar, who gave away just eight runs in his first spell, leaked 30 runs in his last two overs.

However, Shashank's innings came to an end in the final over in which PBKS needed 33 runs. Earlier, in a game that PBKS needed to win to keep their playoff

qualification hopes alive, Venkatesh hogged the lime-light with his scintillating innings after Kohli and Devdutt did the initial groundwork with an authoritative 76-run partnership for the second wicket.

After losing Jacob Bethell early to Harpreet Brar, RCB recovered strongly through Kohli and Adevdutt, who kept the scoreboard ticking with a flurry of boundaries and smart rotation of strike on a batting-friendly surface.

Kohli looked in sublime touch, using the pace of Arshdeep Singh and Lockie Ferguson effectively, while Devdutt counterattacked against both pace and spin to ensure that Punjab's bowlers never settled into any sort of rhythm.

## Self-inflicted pressure made me a shallower human: Finn Allen

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Kolkata

Finn Allen feels stepping away from the playing XI helped him rediscover the joy of batting as the KKR opener by his own admission had become a "shallower" person by putting too much "self-inflicted" pressure during the early part of the IPL season.

Coming into the tournament on the back of a blistering 33-ball 100 not out against South Africa in the T20 World Cup semifinal at the same venue, Allen arrived with huge expectations of providing KKR similar starts at the top.

But the aggressive New Zealand opener endured a rough beginning, managing



just 81 runs in five innings, including scores of 6, 9 and 1, before KKR benched him for three matches against Gujarat Titans, Rajasthan Royals and Lucknow Super Giants. Allen on Saturday smashed a 35-ball 93 as KKR posted their season's highest

247/2 in a must-win match against a rampaging Gujarat Titans fresh from a five-match winning streak.

"At the start of the tournament, I was putting far too much pressure on myself to perform. I was probably a shallower human for a bit

there and it was all self-inflicted," Allen said in the post-match media interaction after their 29-run win.

"When you go out of the side, you have time to relax and take a breath and look at things from a different perspective. "I love playing cricket, I love batting and I probably wasn't enjoying it as much as I should have because I was putting so much pressure on myself."

Since returning against Sunrisers Hyderabad, the opener is back into his destructive best, smashing 240 runs in four innings, including a 47-ball unbeaten hundred and the 93 in his last three knocks.

Allen said the short break helped him return with a clearer mindset. "Having

those few games off really did me a good thing. It's a great learning for sure," he said.

The 27-year-old added that his focus now is on staying relaxed and enjoying the game instead of chasing results. "If I'm relaxed and enjoying myself, then I watch the ball harder, I'm in better positions and I'm a better cricketer for it," Allen said.

"Pressure is just something that I put on myself. There's no real pressure in sport. We're very blessed to do what we do, so the pressure was all me."

He smashed 10 sixes in his knock as 76 of his 93 runs came off boundaries in his impactful knock. "It's just for me keeping my intent early, trying to get in good positions. If it's there, try

and hit it for four or six and if it's not, just try and get off strike, really. I guess for me, I'm just trying to get in stronger positions so I can be more consistent," he said.

Starboy Raghuvanshi: After Allen got out, 21-year-old Angkrish Raghuvanshi kept up the momentum in his 44-ball 82 not out as he along with Cameron Green (52 not out; 28b) gave the final flourish in a century-plus unbroken stand.

"Starboy. Yeah, he's an incredible player. I think he's just expanding his game. The more we see him bat, he's got a great base. He can play some incredible shots," he hailed the Mumbai youngster who is KKR's leading rungetter (422) this season with five fifties.

## Avani Prashanth struggles in third round as Pranavi makes early exit

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Hamburg (Germany)

India's Avani Prashanth endured a difficult third round, carding an 81 to slip down the leaderboard at the 2026 Amundi German Masters on the Ladies European Tour.

After showing impressive resilience earlier in the week, the young Indian golfer struggled in challenging weather conditions during moving day at the Green Eagle Golf Courses near Hamburg.

Avani had opened the tournament with a 78 but bounced back brilliantly in



the second round with a superb four-under 69 to comfortably make the cut. She was the lone Indian to make the cut, as Pranavi Urs missed the cut out and Vani Kapoor withdrew after a first round 83.

However, the demanding North Course and unpredictable weather proved far tougher in round three. Avani had no birdies and had four bogeys and two double bogeys and eventually signed for an 81, dropping well down the standings at 9-over-par after 54 holes.

At the top of the leaderboard, Germany's Alexandra Forsterling produced an excellent round of 69 (-4) to take a two-shot lead into the final day. The four-time Ladies European Tour winner handled the testing conditions superbly despite a brief suspension caused by a hailstorm.

## BCCI unhappy as KKR fields injured Varun Chakravarth

KUSHAN SARKAR  
■ New Delhi

The Country versus Club debate has resurfaced once again after Varun Chakravarth bowled his full quota of overs for Kolkata Knight Riders against Gujarat Titans in an IPL match on Saturday despite India's top T20 spinner carrying a hairline fracture that required rest.

Watching Chakravarth hobble in pain and continue bowling has not gone down well with people connected with the Indian team, particularly with the country scheduled to play as many as seven T20Is in Dublin and across England next month.

"I know for a fact that KKR physio is in touch with Team

India physio (Kamlesh Jain). There has been a communication from KKR to BCCI that in a previous match, Varun injured his left foot while saving a boundary. It is understood that he has a hairline fracture. I believe as a centrally contracted player of the BCCI, his fitness is paramount and the BCCI medical team could intervene. Jain might be asked as to what was the input from the KKR medical team," a senior BCCI official told PTI on conditions of anonymity.

While Chakravarth is considered as a T20 specialist and the upcoming Afghanistan home series doesn't comprise of the shortest version games, the question remains whether the Tamil Nadu



mystery spinner will have enough time to recuperate before UK tour starting on June 26 if his injury gets aggravated due to this desperation from the franchise.

But questions are being asked as to why the player

himself didn't stop bowling when he was visibly uncomfortable going back to his run-up. He gave away 47 runs in four wicketless overs and could manage only three dot balls. "If Varun was rested against RCB in the last game

because of his foot injury, it is imperative to know how he couldn't make it for that game (on May 13) after four-day break (vs DC on May 8) but played on Saturday. Yes, KKR's campaign is on the line but can the BCCI allow franchises this kind of indiscretion? A player would want to play through pain but is that a fair thing?", the official questioned.

It will be interesting to see if the BCCI medical team headed by physio Kamlesh Jain pulls the plug and asks KKR not to field Chakravarth during the next two games.

The Knight Riders are scheduled to play Mumbai Indians (May 20) and Delhi Capitals (May 24) at the Eden Gardens. (PTI)

## Super Chess Classic: Praggnanandhaa draws with Keymer

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Bucharest

Indian GM R Praggnanandhaa played out a draw with Vincent Keymer of Germany to stay in joint lead after the third round of the Super Chess Classic, part of the Grand chess tour.

After a well-deserved victory over Javokhir Sindarov of Uzbekistan in the previous round, Praggnanandhaa took his tally to two points out of a possible three. He now shares the lead with Maxime

Vachier-Lagrave of France, Dutch duo of Jorden Van Foreest and Anish Giri along with Keymer.

With half the field of ten-players sharing the lead, Americans Fabiano Caruana and Wesley So have both drawn all their games to be on 1.5 points while Iranian turned Frenchman Alireza Firouzja and local star Deac Bogdan-Daniel both have a half point apiece. For Praggnanandhaa, the white pieces did not matter much. Keymer has been a consistent



performer amongst the top players for quite some time and on this day too was in his element as he gave little chance to the Indian.

Praggnanandhaa went for

the Capablanca variation against the Nimzo Indian and Keymer sacrificed a pawn early in the opening to restore parity. As it happened in the game, the players reached a rook and minor piece endgame wherein Pragg's extra pawn was effectively dealt by a perfect blockade and the game was drawn after 64 moves.

Anish Giri proved why no one should take him lightly yet again as he scored his first victory in the event over Alireza Firouzja. The King's

Indian was the preferred choice by the French GM and Giri got a stronghold leading to a small sacrifice wherein Firouzja gave up his rook for a minor piece. The technicalities remain but one could on Anish to deliver the goods.

Foreest continued to surprise his detractors as he scored over Deac with black pieces. It was another King's Indian wherein the initial skirmish led to wild complexities and clearly, Foreest was much superior in handling them compared to Deac.

## Toronto to host 6 World Cup games

ROB GILLIES  
■ Toronto

Toronto, one of the most culturally diverse cities in the world, will host six World Cup games, including the first-ever such match in Canada on June 12.

The host country will face Bosnia and Herzegovina in that opening match. Ghana plays Panama on June 17, Germany plays Cote d'Ivoire on June 20, Croatia faces Panama on June 23 and Senegal plays Iraq on June



26. Toronto also hosts a round of 32 match on July 2.

**Landmarks/Places to See:** Canada's largest city is welcoming the world and emphasizing its diversity, a contrast to the U.S., where fears about border control

could keep international fans away. Toronto touts itself as the "world in a city."

"More than half our residents were born outside Canada," Toronto Mayor Olivia Chow said.